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The Sunday EXPRESS



EYE Mammooty wants to dance

At 75, Mammooty is the face of arrival, one who can sit with kings and not lose the common touch

BOOKS

Sheena Kalayil on her Women's Prize longlisted novel, writing about migrants and refusing to stay in her lane



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NEW DELHI DECLARATION 2026 FINDS COMMON GROUND ON GLOBAL CONFLICTS

As walls rise, BRICS speaks

Modi and Xi hold talks: 'Partners not rivals, committed to resolution of boundary question'

Leaders agree to address each other's concerns over economic, trade relations, facilitate 'meaningful' market access

Shubhajt Roy & Divya A
New Delhi, September 12

TWO YEARS after their meeting in Russia's Kazan led to the disengagement of troops along the Line of Actual Control in eastern Ladakh after a tense military standoff that began 2020, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping said Saturday that "differences should not become disputes" and committed themselves to "a fair, reasonable, and mutually acceptable resolution of the boundary question".

Holding bilateral talks in New Delhi on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit — it was their first meeting in India in seven years amid efforts to re-

store relations that plummeted after the Chinese incursions six years ago — Modi and Xi said "both countries should take a strategic and long term perspective of their ties".

During the meeting, the Prime Minister, according to a statement from the Ministry of External Affairs, highlighted that "both sides must be guided by three mutuals: mutual respect, mutual sensitivity and mutual interest".

These "three mutuals" have been part of Delhi's redlines over the last five years.

The Chinese Foreign Ministry statement on the talks quoted Xi telling Modi that "China and India are partners rather than rivals" providing

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Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Chinese President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin in New Delhi, Saturday. ANI

UAE PRINCE, PEZESHKIAN MEET

Six months into war, Iran and UAE find consensus in BRICS joint declaration

Bloc calls for restraint, flags sovereignty, threat to civilians, infra, smooth oil flows

Shubhajt Roy
New Delhi, September 12

AS THE six-month-long West Asia war flares up with US and Iran exchanging strikes, India achieved the much-anticipated — and the much-fraught — consensus at the BRICS summit between UAE and Iran after hectic negotiations paving the way for the joint declaration adopted Saturday.

Against this backdrop, UAE's Sheikh Khaled bin Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, who is the Crown Prince of Abu Dhabi, met Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian on the margins of the BRICS summit.

In paragraph 28 of the joint declaration, the BRICS leaders said, "We express deep concern over the continued escalation of tensions in Middle East/West Asia and, recalling our respective national positions, call for exercising maximum restraint, as well as avoiding actions that

Business as Usual
By EP UNNY

could further aggravate the situation."

The declaration acknowledged the sensibilities of both sides by flagging territorial sovereignty and the need to secure civilians and infrastructure. UAE has been at the receiving end of a series of Iranian strikes on its cities with Tehran calling

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EXPRESS special

No fire & brimstone: Delhi pushes back against making BRICS a geopolitical bloc



At the BRICS Summit venue in New Delhi, Saturday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

C Raja Mohan
Gudauri (Georgia),
September 12

UNDERLYING THE wordy 140-paragraph declaration of the Delhi BRICS summit is India's careful steering of the twenty-year forum amid deepening great-power conflict involving its own members, economic uncertainty accentuated by wars in Europe and the Middle East.

Delhi's diplomatic success lies in keeping BRICS "boring", if you will, amid the rhetorical excess about radical global

change that often accompanies its summits.

The declaration reaffirms the political diversity of the forum and dispels the notion of an ideological crusade against the West — one that some supporters of BRICS desire and many of its critics assume is already under way.

It contains familiar criticism of unilateral sanctions, tariffs and protectionism, as well as strong language on Gaza and other humanitarian crises.

But it does not turn BRICS into a collective political front

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FULL COVERAGE

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ZERO TOLERANCE
ON CROSS-BORDER
TERROR: GROUPING
ON PAHALGAM**PAGE 9**
NIMHANS AT CENTRE
OF BRICS' MENTAL
WELLNESS NETWORK**PAGE 15**
BLOC PUSHES FOR
REFORMS IN WTO

Happening today

●ON THE FINAL DAY of the BRICS Summit, member countries will take part in an open session on 'Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation, and Sustainability: Shaping the Future for Inclusive Global Growth'.

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PROPOSES MECHANISM FOR FOLLOW-UP OF INITIATIVES

Pyramid of privilege must give way to partnership platform: PM



BRICS leaders plant trees at the Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi, Saturday. MEA

'Coming of age moment for BRICS@20, Global South must be rule-shaper'

Shubhajt Roy & Divya A
New Delhi, September 12

UNDERLINING THE "coming of age" of BRICS in its 20th year, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said Saturday that the grouping has carved a distinct identity for itself on the global stage and its members "respect each

other's perspectives and move forward through consensus". He said they strive to progress "not by opposing anyone, but by taking everyone along".

He made these remarks hours before the BRICS declaration was adopted through consensus. The UAE and Iran, at loggerheads ever since the start

of the war in West Asia, came around after hectic negotiations over the last few days.

Pitching for the Global South's presence at the table, Modi said the message from the summit hosted by India is clear: "If our future is shared, then the right to shape it must also be shared. From voice to impact. From privilege to partnership. Let this be the resolve of BRICS at 20."

With Chinese President

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Behind the agreement: No Ukraine, Iran-UAE balance, swipe at (US) tariffs, flagging Gaza

UNSC reform, terror, Gaza: 2026 Delhi borrows from 2025 Rio
Divya A & Shubhajt Roy
New Delhi, September 12

THE 45-page BRICS declaration achieved a consensus through careful diplomatic calibration nuancing the most divisive issues and creating space for each of the participants to walk away with their stated goals acknowledged — and their triggers avoided.

As many as 140 paragraphs of the document dwelt at length on trade, health, AI and tourism, making the document cooperative rather than confrontational.

In many cases, it echoed the

2025 Rio declaration — be it the war in Gaza, Pahalgam terror attack or UNSC reforms.

The declaration avoided any mention of the "T" that matters the most — Trump — but it used the other two Ts, trade and tariff. These found repeated mentions in the declaration. While all participants have been at the receiving end of US tariffs, two important members of the grouping — Russia and Iran — have repeatedly faced the pressure of US economic sanctions.

In this context, para 22 of the declaration says the members condemn "unilateral coercive measures," "unilateral economic sanctions and secondary sanctions" — which is standard BRICS shorthand for Western sanctions regimes. Para 27 talks about Latin America and the Caribbean as a zone of peace, mentions "tightening of unilateral blockade measures" on

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RBI rejects Tata Sons request to remain private, asks it to go public

Listing Tata Sons was key issue on which trustees of Tata Trusts were divided

George Mathew
Mumbai, September 12

IN A big setback to the Noel Tata-led Tata group, the Reserve Bank of India has rejected the application of its principal holding company Tata Sons Ltd, to remain an unregistered investment company. It has, instead, directed the company "to ensure full compliance with all guidelines/ instructions"

which means Tata Sons will have to go for an initial public offering (IPO) and list its shares on the stock exchanges.

Listing Tata Sons was one of the key issues which had divided the trustees of Tata Trusts, which holds about 66 per cent in the company through various entities. The RBI decision comes at a critical juncture when the Tata Group is searching for a new chairman

to replace N Chandrasekaran, who announced he would step down after his term ends on February 20, 2027, since the board was not unanimous on his reappointment.

In a letter to the Chief Financial Officer of Tata Sons, the RBI said it cannot agree to the company's March 28, 2024, request for the voluntary surrender of its certificate of registration for being classified as an unregistered Core Investment Company. Further, it advised Tata Sons to comply with the central bank's instructions applicable

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● LEADERS DISCUSS LONG-STANDING BONDS OF FRIENDSHIP BETWEEN IRAN AND INDIA

Delhi rolls out red carpet for Pezeshkian, daughter: Rashtrapati Bhavan to shopping at BRICS Bazaar

Divya A
New Delhi, September 12

AHEAD OF the opening session of the BRICS Summit, President Droupadi Murmu hosted visiting Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian — the only dignitary hosted by the Rashtrapati Bhavan during the summit.

Pezeshkian, who landed in New Delhi along with his daughter Zahra, held extensive bilateral talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday. This comes during the West



President Droupadi Murmu with Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian; his daughter Zahra (second from left) at the BRICS Bazaar along with Union Minister Annpurna Devi, in New Delhi, Saturday. PTI & ANI



Asia conflict between Iran and the US.

During his visit to the presidential estate, the Iranian president also visited the Iranian Hall at the presidential estate — referring to the grand Ashok Mandap, which houses prominent Qajar-era Persian artwork dating back to the reign of Fath-Ali Shah Qajar, the second Shah of Qajar Iran, who reigned from June 1797 until his death in October 1834.

Welcoming President Pezeshkian on his first visit to

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

MP HC declines to quash case against 4 in Damoh hijab row

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, September 12

MORE THAN three years after a controversy erupted over the alleged imposition of hijab and religious practices at a school in Damoh, the Madhya Pradesh High Court has refused to quash the criminal proceedings against the four accused, holding that the allegations in the FIR and material collected could not be termed inherently absurd or incapable of constituting the offences alleged.

Justice Himanshu Joshi, who heard the case, made an important distinction on the issue of hijab, observing that wearing hijab by itself "...without the statutory ingredients of conversion or an attempt to convert by the prohibited means" cannot constitute an offence under the Madhya Pradesh Freedom of Religion Act. The court said the prosecution's case, however, included allegations that a particular dress code was made compulsory, that students were allegedly prohibited from wearing *tilak* and *kalawa*, were required to follow certain religious practices and prayers, and that threats and coercion were used.

"Whether these practices were actually compulsory, whether students acted voluntarily, and whether there was an intention to convert through prohibited means were questions that could only be determined after appreciation of evidence," the court said.

The court rejected the accused's attempt to have the

prosecution terminated at the threshold, saying the allegations could not be described as "inherently absurd" or "inherently improbable".

Two of the accused, Shaileendra Kumar Jain and Abdul Wasim Bari, had argued that they were not members or office-bearers of the school's management committee during the relevant period. The High Court said documents they produced supported their defence regarding the subsequently constituted committee, but the prosecution alleged their involvement and relied on material collected during the investigation. Whether they had any role in the school's affairs or exercised influence over its functioning would therefore have to be decided at trial.

The court also refused to treat affidavits subsequently furnished by some parents or students as a basis for quashing the case. The affidavits stated that the books supplied to students were government-prescribed books and that no religious education beyond the syllabus had been imparted. Such material, the court said, could be considered by the trial court along with the statements recorded during the investigation and the evidence.

The Ganga Jamuna Higher Secondary School in Damoh was thrust into controversy in May 2023 after a poster celebrating its Class 10 board results showed several girl students, including those from non-Muslim communities, wearing headscarves.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Modi-Xi

"development opportunities rather than threats to each other".

The twosides, Xi said, should "address each other's economic and trade concerns in a balanced way and promote the sound and steady development of economic and trade relations".

According to the MEA statement, Modi said "peace and tranquility in the border areas remains an essential basis for the continued development of bilateral relations". He underlined the need for both sides to observe existing agreements and understandings on border related issues. "The two leaders expressed commitment to a fair, reasonable, and mutually acceptable resolution of the boundary question proceeding from the political perspective of their overall bilateral relations and the long-term interests of the two peoples," it stated.

Last month, National Security Advisor Ajit Doval and Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi met in Beijing. The meeting resulted in eight outcomes and consensus including the decision to advance discussions on

"an early and substantial harvest" of boundary delimitation and border management.

According to the Chinese Foreign Ministry statement, Xi told Modi that "institutional exchanges between the two countries have gradually resumed, the cooperation list has continued to lengthen, and the bilateral trade volume has hit a new high. This situation has not come easily and needs to be cherished".

"China and India have different national realities. We should draw on each other's strengths, support each other, help each other succeed, and develop together. In the face of the changing and turbulent international landscape, the world's two most populous countries and important members of the Global South shoulder important responsibilities," it quoted Xi.

Modi and Xi, the MEA said, took note of the "progress in people-to-people ties and underscored the need to further promote cultural exchanges, business linkages and greater mobility" between the two countries.

"On economic and trade relations, they underlined the need to address each other's concerns, including structural

trade imbalance and supply chain issues, and facilitation of meaningful and predictable market access," it stated.

"The two leaders agreed that both sides must continue to expand common ground on regional and global issues, and in addressing challenges," it stated. Modi "appreciated China's support for India's BRICS chairmanship and its contributions towards the success of the BRICS Summit".

The Chinese statement said Xi made "four observations on promoting the steady and sustained development of China-India relations".

"First, calibrate the direction with an objective and rational strategic perception. China and India are partners rather than rivals, and development opportunities rather than threats to each other... Second, help each other succeed in the spirit of win-win cooperation. Both sides should focus on development as the greatest common denominator... The two sides should also address each other's economic and trade concerns in a balanced way and promote the sound and steady development of economic and trade relations."

"Third, remove irritants... The two sides should stay committed

to advancing bilateral relations and resolving the boundary question, seek parallel, mutually reinforcing progress, and maintain peace and tranquility in the border areas." "Fourth, contribute to a better world with open and inclusive multilateral coordination. The two sides should support each other's BRICS chairship, strengthen coordination in the United Nations, the Shanghai Cooperation Organization, and the G20, work together to address global challenges..." it said.

Modi, according to the Chinese statement, said, "India always views its relations with China from a strategic and long-term perspective. It hopes to be a partner, not a rival, of China, and regards each other's development as an opportunity, not a challenge."

"India has an independent foreign policy, and developing relations with China is not affected by any third party," it quoted Modi telling Xi, alluding to India's ties with the US.

"India's policy and position on issues relating to Taiwan and Tibet remain unchanged, and it will not allow any force to engage in anti-China activities on its territory," the Chinese statement said.

Behind agreement

Cuba, which is again an unnamed but pointed reference to the US embargo. There is also emphasis on "proliferation of trade-restrictive actions... indiscriminate rising of tariffs" — an oblique nod to Trump-era tariff policy. The declaration also opposed "carbon border adjustment mechanisms", aiming at US/EU trade-climate measures.

In Rio BRICS declaration 2025, it had only said that the "multilateral trading system has long been at a crossroads... We voice serious concerns about the rise of unilateral tariff and non-tariff measures which distort trade and are inconsistent with WTO rules."

On Ukraine, there was no mention at all in the Delhi 2026 declaration. In Rio 2025, there was an anodyne paragraph: "We recall our national positions concerning the conflict in Ukraine as expressed in the appropriate fora, including the UN Security Council and the UN General Assembly."

With Russia at the high table as India's long-time partner, any mention of Ukraine has been

avoided. No paragraph in the 45-page declaration mentions Ukraine, Russia's invasion, or related sanctions by name.

Russia would have blocked any critical language, on a topic that could have been too divisive. At the G20 New Delhi Summit in 2023, India had forged a consensus on the Russia-Ukraine war by softening the language of the joint declaration to avoid naming or directly condemning Russia.

In the section on UN Security Council reform, the declaration states: "Recalling the 2022 Beijing and 2023 Johannesburg-II Leaders' Declarations, China and Russia, as permanent members of the UN Security Council, reiterate their support to the aspirations of Brazil and India to play a greater role in the UN, including its Security Council." This copy-paste of the Rio 2025 declaration is how the geopolitical weight of China, as a UN Security Council member, is made explicit, along with that of Russia, while supporting the aspirations of New Delhi and Rio towards a seat at the table.

No fire & brimstone

against the United States or the West.

Its principal achievement is to underline a simpler proposition: a more fragmented world requires more, not less, practical cooperation among major nations. The emphasis is on reforming the international order, not demolishing it.

The Delhi summit's emphasis on resilience, innovation, cooperation and sustainability moves the focus towards supply chains, health, food security, climate adaptation, digital systems, small enterprises and development finance. This does not make BRICS a transformative economic institution. But it makes the forum more useful than an ideological platform devoted to denouncing American dominance.

The most consequential Indian success may be what the summit did not do. For several years, "de-dollarisation" has been presented by some BRICS enthusiasts as the defining test of the forum's strategic purpose. Russia, facing Western sanctions, has understandable reasons to seek alternatives to dollar-centred financial channels.

China, too, wants to reduce exposure to American financial power and increase the international use of its own currency and expand its global influence.

But India has no interest in turning BRICS payments cooperation into a political battle against the dollar. The Delhi declaration steers clear of a common BRICS currency. It supports the more modest objective of making cross-border payments faster, cheaper and more reliable.

The summit's emphasis is on continuing technical work and consultations, not on decisive moves towards replacing the dollar. It explicitly recognises that there can be no "one-size-fits-all" approach. It preserves the right of every BRICS member to reduce particular vulnerabilities in its financial links without committing the grouping to an implausible project of monetary separation from the West. It keeps BRICS focused on financial functionality rather than geopolitical theatre.

This distinction matters greatly for India. New Delhi has deepened cooperation with

America, Europe, and US allies in Asia in the domains of trade, technology, defence, and supply-chain resilience. At the same time, Delhi remains committed to an independent foreign policy and to the democratisation of the global order. India can pursue both aims only if BRICS remains a forum for pluralism rather than an instrument of China-Russia confrontation with the West.

Delhi has also left a small but distinctive Indian stamp on BRICS through its digital agenda. The declaration's attention to inclusive and resilient digital systems, digital public goods and AI capacity-building gives India's experience with digital public infrastructure a place in the BRICS conversation. India's success with large-scale payments platforms and public digital systems gives it credibility on this issue.

There is, however, a familiar BRICS problem. The New Delhi Declaration's extraordinary breadth is a measure of the grouping's ambition, but also of its institutional weakness. It ranges across global governance, wars, terrorism, health, agriculture, energy, trade, finance, climate, technology, culture, education and sport. The result often reads like a cata-

logue of global problems rather than a sharp political document.

Yet the verbosity serves a purpose — by preventing BRICS from hardening into an ideological bloc. It has enabled Russia, China and Iran to voice their grievances, allow the articulation of the developing world's concerns, press for global reform, and preserve the freedom of all to maintain their separate engagement with the US.

BRICS has not resolved the conflicts among its members, including between India and China, or ended their competition for influence. It has simply avoided imposing an ideological straitjacket on them and making the world worse off.

Contrary to the widespread sentiment, the BRICS has no magic wand to solve the world's problems. That game is being played elsewhere. India and the world will watch with great interest Chinese president Xi Jinping's visit to Washington later this month, the latest US peace initiative on Ukraine with Kyiv and Moscow, and the continuing tussle between the US and Iran in the Middle East.

C Raja Mohan is a contributing editor on international affairs for The Indian Express

Iran, UAE

it a proxy of the United States. In addition, the declaration underscored dialogue and diplomacy and smooth flow of energy — all important issues and challenges faced by all the countries from the developing countries.

"We urge to ensure the protection of civilians and civilian infrastructure in accordance with the purposes and principles of the Charter of the United Nations in their entirety and interconnectedness, including respect for the sovereignty and territorial integrity of the States," the declaration said. "We encourage increasing efforts, through dialogue and diplomacy, towards a long-term understanding that will contribute to lasting peace, security and stability in the region. We stress the need to work together to maintain smooth flow of global trade, supply chains and energy, in accordance with applicable international law."

The phrasing of the war in West Asia had divided Iran and UAE in the last six months. Incidentally, barely three months ago, in May, there was no consensus on the paragraph at the BRICS Foreign ministers meeting.

At that time, Delhi had issued a chair statement and an outcome document, trying to reflect the divergences between Iran and the UAE over the war. The statement had underlined "differing views among some members" over the West Asia situation, and that BRICS members had expressed their "respective national positions". In contrast, there was a much more expansive paragraph in the BRICS declaration.

Said Secretary (economic relations) in the Ministry of External Affairs Sudhakar Dalela, who is also the BRICS Sherpa: "The adoption of New Delhi Declaration was among the defining outcomes of India's chairmanship demonstrating that BRICS members can forge consensus on matters of global importance."

The negotiators were able to achieve this in the last few days of hectic negotiations. With the war in West Asia flaring up following the exchange of strikes between the US and Iran, the BRICS Sherpas, the most senior negotiators from the 11 member countries of the grouping, have been burning the midnight oil to hammer out the joint declaration. With UAE and Iran, new members of the BRICS since 2024, part of the negotiations, Indian officials worked to bridge the gap between the two sides.

Tata Sons

to NBFC-Upper Layer (NBFC-UL).

An NBFC-UL requires enhanced regulatory oversight because of its size, systemic importance, interconnectedness, and risk profile, using a prescribed scoring methodology. The RBI (NBFC-Governance) Directions issued on November 28, 2025, also require an NBFC-UL to list within three years of being identified as one by the central bank.

When contacted, Tata Sons did not comment on the development. Legal circles were, however, of the view that Tata Sons has the option to approach the court against the RBI rejection of application to remain an unregistered Core Investment Company. The issue may end up in the court as Tata Trusts led by Noel Tata is against the company going public, they said.

Trustees of Tata Trusts have been divided on the issue for long, with those opposing listing holding a strong view that listing would dilute control, or in other words reduce the influence and rights of Tata Trusts. Noel Tata, Chairman of Tata Trusts and a Director of Tata Sons, was advocating the company should remain a private, unlisted entity. Some former Tata Sons directors too are against listing.

Two trustees — Venu Srinivasan and Vijay Singh — have argued for listing. Pallonji Mistry group which holds 18.3 per cent stake in Tata Sons is also in favour of listing since it will provide the group an exit route. With 18.3 per cent stake in Tata Sons, it is a big shareholder, and an IPO will enable it to monetise its holding and raise funds for the group's expansion plans.

According to a trustee of Tata Trusts, control, be it in charitable trusts, was a workable proposition in earlier times, but Tata

Sons needs stability and a rigorous regulatory mechanism now. "The Tata Trusts have been fractious and turbulent in the recent past and there is no guarantee of a better future. I do not think listing will significantly affect the trusts which will retain their large shareholding, board seats etc and will not lose their promoter status," he said.

"A public listing would not only unlock value for minority shareholders but also equip Tata Sons with capital to sustain growth," said another Tata Trusts trustee.

The RBI's direction places the onus on Tata Sons to address any gaps in its regulatory compliance framework and align its operations, governance and financial practices with the enhanced requirements applicable to upper-layer NBFCs. Any requirement to strengthen compliance could therefore result in additional oversight, changes to internal processes and greater emphasis on board-level monitoring and disclosures. It may also require the holding company to reassess certain group-level practices to ensure that its activities remain consistent with the regulatory expectations governing its NBFC status.

On August 6, the RBI had classified Tata Sons in the list of upper layer NBFCs. It, however, said the company's application for de-registration was under examination. Now that the company has been categorised as an NBFC-UL, it will be subject to enhanced regulatory requirement, at least for a period of five years from its classification in the layer, even in case it does not meet the (prescribed) criteria in the subsequent years. In other words, it will be eligible to move out of the enhanced regulatory framework only if it does not meet the criteria for classification for five consecutive years.

Red carpet

India, the President expressed appreciation for the support extended by Iran during India's BRICS presidency, a statement from the Rashtrapati Bhavan said. "The two leaders discussed the long-standing bonds of friendship between Iran and New India, including strong cultural and people-to-people ties," it said, adding that Murmu reiterated India's commitment to the pursuit of enduring peace in the region.

Union Minister Annpurna

Devi escorted the president's daughter to the BRICS Bazaar, being held at the Crafts Museum adjoining Bharat Mandapam, bringing together artisans from all member countries. "It was a pleasure to welcome Ms Zahra Pezeshkian, daughter of Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, to the BRICS Bazaar at the National Crafts Museum, New Delhi," she said in a post on X. "Had the opportunity to show them around the Bazaar and share the rich traditions, art, crafts and cultural heritage showcased by BRICS members and partner nations," she said.

making. First, regarding representation: Reform of the UN Security Council can no longer be deferred. Text-based negotiations on this issue must be linked to a definite time frame and clear outcomes. Similarly, voting power, leadership positions and policy priorities within financial institutions must align with today's economic realities. Nations that drive global economic growth should also play a commensurate role in steering global economic governance."

On responsiveness, he said, "Public trust in global institutions will only be established if they prove capable of effectively resolving problems. We must focus on the speed, scale, and last-mile impact of our collective responses."

He highlighted the plight of seafarers, many of them Indians.

"Seafarers make a massive contribution to global trade, yet they often find themselves lacking support during difficult times. I propose the creation of a 'Seafarers Emergency Support Network'. This network would link the maritime authorities and diplomatic missions of relevant countries, facilitating assistance with distress alerts, medical aid, family notifications, and evacuations," he said.

"Third, regarding rule-making: Ensuring equal participation in defining future global rules is of paramount importance. Domains such as AI, cyberspace, outer space, biotechnology, and critical technologies are shaping not only future opportunities but also future rules... We must strive to transform the Global South from a rule-taker into a rule-shaper."

'Pyramid of privilege'

Xi Jinping, Russian President Vladimir Putin and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian among leaders at the summit, the Prime Minister said the Global South must become a "rule-shaper" and the existing "pyramid of privilege" structure in global governance must give way to a "platform of partnership".

"In human life, the age of 20 marks the beginning of a new phase of maturity and responsibility. It is a stage where responsibilities are intertwined with dreams, and potential finds a new direction."

"Today, BRICS, too, is at a moment of coming of age. Over the past 20 years, BRICS has carved a distinct identity for itself on the

global stage. We respect each other's perspectives and move forward through consensus. We strive to progress not by opposing anyone, but by taking everyone along," he said.

"The time has now come for us to translate our unity and consensus within BRICS into concrete results on the global stage. We must work on a new and ambitious agenda for the next 20 years. We need to begin this process with our own working systems," he said.

To keep track of the initiatives, the Prime Minister proposed a mechanism. "The BRICS chairmanship rotates annually, but this should not halt our institutional momentum. I propose a

'BRICS Continuity and Implementation Mechanism.' This would enable the follow-up of all initiatives and outcomes through the Troika (the troika refers to a framework comprising past, current and incoming chairs of the grouping). We could create a secure digital repository where the nodal point, timeline and implementation status for every decision are recorded," he said.

Proposing reforms in global governance, he sought representation for the Global South. "While strengthening BRICS, we must also chart the course for global reform. The current structure of global governance resembles a pyramid. Power and decision-making are concentrated at the top, while the countries that are affected by these decisions, yet unable to shape

them, occupy the lower tiers," he said.

"Today, the Global South stands in the front row of global crises but in the back row of decision-making. We must transform this pyramid of privilege into a platform of partnership, one where every country has a voice, every member has a stake, and human development lies at the heart of every endeavour," he said. "I propose that we collectively formulate 10 proposals for global governance reform, aiming to shape them into a 'BRICS Reform Roadmap'."

Incidentally, the next summit will be hosted by China which has resisted India's moves for a permanent seat at UNSC.

In crafting this roadmap, Modi said, "We must focus on three key aspects: Representation, Responsiveness, and Rule-

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE

	LANCE NAIK JAGDEV SINGH 17 BN BSF 23.10.1959 – 13.09.1988		CONSTABLE RAM PRAKASH 17 BN BSF 20.10.1956 – 13.09.1988
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Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans Lance Naik Jagdev Singh and Constable Ram Prakash on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained fatal bullet injuries in an encounter with militants in Ferozepur area, Punjab and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

	HC HIRA BALLAB JOSHI 50 BN BSF 15.03.1950 – 13.09.1994		HC HARENDER SINGH 50 BN BSF 25.07.1951 – 13.09.1994		CT DULAL SARKAR 50 BN BSF 26.04.1969 – 13.09.1994		CT RATAN SINGH 50 BN BSF 01.01.1970 – 13.09.1994
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Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans Head Constables Hira Ballab Joshi, Harender Singh and Constables Ratan Singh and Dulal Sarkar on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained fatal bullet injuries during a Counter terror operation in Anantnag area, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

	CONSTABLE KULBHUSHAN KUMAR 102 BN BSF 02.07.1971 – 13.09.1999	Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Kulbhushan Kumar on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal injuries in an IED blast triggered by militants in Ramban area, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.					
	CONSTABLE R B KERKATTA 102 BN BSF 05.01.1964 – 13.09.1999	Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable R B Kerkatta on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries in Counterpart firing in area of BOP Kotkuba, R S Pura (Jammu) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.					
	CONSTABLE DAVALASA, PPMG 141 BN BSF 01.07.1972 – 13.09.1999	Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Davalasa on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries in an encounter with militants in Srinagar area, J&K. He fought bravely and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty. His sacrifice and gallant action have been aptly recognized by GOI by awarding them with PPMG (Posthumously).					
	HEAD CONSTABLE B C MAHATO 151 BN BSF 02.02.1965 – 13.09.2001	Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Head Constable B C Mahato on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal injuries in an IED blast triggered by militants in Anantnag area, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.					

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE

	Veer Balidani Head Constable Hiralal Yadav 76 Bn 10-7.1949 To 13-09-1988	DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable Hiralal Yadav of 76 Bn who made the supreme sacrifice in an encounter with terrorists in Punjab on 13 September 1988. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.					
	Veer Balidani Head Constable Shivalingayya Mathapati 161 Bn 01-06-1966 To 13-09-2008	DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to HC/GD Shivalingayya Mathapati of 161 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after being grievously injured in a cowardly attack by a militant in Srinagar, J&K on 13 September 2008. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.					

CENTRAL INDUSTRIAL SECURITY FORCE

	CT/GD AVTAR SINGH 5 th Res. Bn.	CISF proudly remembers the supreme sacrifice of this brave-heart. On this day, he laid down his life at the altar of duty while fighting with the terrorists at Baramula (Jammu & Kashmir) His courage and bravery would remain an abiding source of inspiration for the force. The force will remain eternally indebted to him for his noblest deed.					
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INDO-TIBETAN BORDER POLICE (ITBP)

	Deputy Commandant Sanjay Gupta	ITBP salutes its braveheart Deputy Commandant Sanjay Gupta of M&SI Auli, who made the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty on this day in Uttarakhand in 1997.					
	Head Constable Gosai Hajong	ITBP salutes its braveheart Head Constable Gosai Hajong of 49th Battalion, who laid down his life in the line of duty on this day in Arunachal Pradesh in 2017					



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1	131.724	110.13	₹ 84,000	₹ 21,000	₹ 10,85,482	₹ 22,12,963	₹ 77,45,371	₹ 1,10,64,816
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Message from the Chargé d’Affaires



YUDHO SASONGKO

Chargé d’Affaires of Indonesia to India and Bhutan

As Indonesia celebrated the 81st anniversary of its Independence and India rejoiced at its 80th Independence, both in August, it is a fitting moment to reflect upon the enduring bonds of friendship that unite Indonesia and India. This occasion reminds us of the sacrifices and perseverance of the founders of our nations, and of a partnership grounded not only in geographical proximity but in shared history, values, and aspirations.

Indonesia and India are maritime neighbours, cultural cousins, and partners in the quest for freedom and dignity. Our peoples drew strength from each other’s struggles for independence, inspired by leaders such as Sukarno, Nehru, Sjahrir, and Biju Patnaik, who envisioned a world where sovereignty, solidarity, and justice would guide international relations. That spirit found expression in the 1955 Bandung Conference, which laid the foundation for the Non-Aligned Movement and continues to resonate today as a pillar of cooperation across the Global South.

The past two years have raised the Indonesia-India partnership to a new level. In January 2025, President Prabowo Subianto paid a visit to India as Chief Guest at the 76th Republic Day celebrations, and Prime Minister Narendra Modi returned the favour by undertaking a visit to Indonesia in July 2026. Exchanged within eighteen months, these visits produced a substantive cooperation agenda spanning defence and maritime security, critical minerals, digital transformation, health, agriculture, and education, which further provides our relationship with a strategic depth commensurate with the weight our two nations carry in Asia and beyond.

Culture and heritage remain the soul of this partnership. The joint restoration of the Prambanan Temple Compounds, the designation of 2026–2027 as the Tagore–Dewantara Year of Cultural and Educational Diplomacy, joint tourism promotions, expanding air connectivity, and growing academic collaboration have brought our peoples closer than ever, sustaining a dialogue between our artistic and spiritual traditions that is far older than our republics. Above all, our vibrant and forward-looking young generations hold the key to ensuring this partnership continues to flourish.

Looking ahead, our two countries stand as partners in shaping inclusive cooperation in this multipolar world through ASEAN - India frameworks, the G20, and BRICS. Indonesia’s accession to BRICS as a full member in January 2025 opens a further avenue for a common purpose. Within BRICS, Indonesia seeks a fairer international architecture in which the voice of the Global South is properly represented. We therefore look forward with anticipation to the fruitful results of the BRICS Summit in New Delhi on 12 - 13 September 2026.

I express my appreciation to The Indian Express for providing a platform to showcase the richness of our bilateral ties, and my gratitude to all friends of Indonesia and India who continue to nurture this friendship. Our two nations have always walked side by side as partners in dialogue, diversity, and dignity, and will keep doing so.

Terima kasih. Dhanyavaad. Thank you.

“India – Indonesia: Shared Civilizational Heritage”



India and Indonesia share a deep cultural bond shaped by centuries of exchange. From the enduring stories of the Ramayana and Mahabharata to art, architecture, and spiritual traditions, the shared heritage continues to connect the two nations.

India is also an important tourism market for Indonesia, with growing interest among Indian travellers. This reflects the strong cultural affinity between the two countries and offers significant opportunities to further strengthen tourism exchanges and people-to-people connections.

The recent visit of Prime Minister Modi to the iconic UNESCO World Heritage listed Prambanan Temple Complex in Yogyakarta, alongside President Prabowo Subianto, further highlighted these enduring ties. The leaders unveiled a plaque marking the commencement of the Archaeological Survey of India’s (ASI) conservation and restoration project at the temple complex.

During the visit, Prime Minister Modi was also conferred with the Bintang Adipurna (Star of the Republic of Indonesia), Indonesia’s highest civilian honour, reflecting the deepening ties and close friendship between the two countries.

Built in the 9th century, Prambanan is Indonesia’s largest temple complex dedicated to the Trimurti—Lord Brahma, Lord Vishnu, and Lord Shiva. Its magnificent architecture and spiritual legacy stand as an enduring symbol of the shared civilizational heritage between India and Indonesia.

Further strengthening these cultural links, the two countries have designated 2026–2027 as the Tagore-Dewantara Year, aimed at promoting closer cultural and educational exchanges. The initiative commemorates the historic meeting in Yogyakarta in 1927 between Indonesian education pioneer Ki Hajar Dewantara and Indian poet, philosopher, and Nobel laureate Rabindranath Tagore.

Rooted in Indonesia. Growing with the world

Indonesia has always been more than our country of origin. It is the ground beneath everything we have built.

For over four decades, APP Group has grown from an Indonesian enterprise into one of the world’s leading pulp and paper companies with manufacturing, distribution, and partnership networks spanning more than 150 countries. Yet through every stage of that journey, Indonesia has remained our anchor, the source of our raw materials, the home of our largest operations, and the wellspring of the values that define how we do business.

Today, as President Prabowo Subianto visits New Delhi for the BRICS Summit, APP Group joins in extending a warm and respectful

welcome. His Excellency’s presence at this forum is a testament to Indonesia’s growing stature as a global economic force and a moment of pride for every Indonesian enterprise operating on the world stage.

The BRICS nations are not abstract geopolitical designations to us, they are markets where our products reach end-consumers, countries where our partnerships have helped build supply chains, and nations whose sustainable development aspirations align with our own.

At the same time, we recognise that economic ambition must be matched by environmental responsibility. APP Group has spent years building operations that respect the natural systems

underpinning Indonesia’s long-term prosperity, from responsible land management to investments in cleaner production across our mills. As we continue to supply packaging, tissue, and printing products to BRICS nations and beyond, sustainable stewardship remains inseparable from how we grow.

The BRICS Summit in New Delhi is an opportunity for dialogue, for partnership, and for the kind of durable multilateral cooperation that creates shared prosperity. APP Group is proud to support Indonesia’s voice in that conversation.

Selamat datang, Bapak Presiden. The world is watching—and Indonesia is ready.

India–Indonesia: Deepening Ties in The BRICS Era

Indonesia’s entry into the expanded BRICS framework adds new weight to its Comprehensive Strategic Partnership with India, elevated in 2018. Trade, investment and people-to-people links between Asia’s two largest democracies have grown steadily, positioning the relationship as a template for Global South economic cooperation.

Bilateral trade currently runs under the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement (AITIGA, 2010), which both sides are now reviewing to modernise tariffs and rules of origin. A standalone India-Indonesia Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement (CECA) has been under study since a 2011 Joint Study Group report but remains uncompleted; talks gained fresh momentum after PM Modi’s July 2026 Jakarta visit, his first since the 2018 upgrade.

US\$28 billion in FY2024-25. Indonesia continues to be India’s largest ASEAN supplier of coal and crude palm oil, along with rubber and mineral products, while India exports machinery, automobiles,

refined petroleum products, meat, and pharmaceuticals. Overall, the trade relationship remains significantly tilted in Indonesia’s favour.

Indian companies have invested more than US\$1.5 billion in Indonesia across nearly 7,300 projects since 2000, with significant contributions from Tata Power and Adani in the energy and mining sectors, TCS, HCL, and Tech Mahindra in information technology, as well as pharmaceutical majors such as Dr. Reddy’s and Aurobindo, alongside financial institutions including SBI and Bank of India. In contrast, Indonesian investments in India total around US\$668 million since 2000 and are concentrated in palm oil and agribusiness, infrastructure, and consumer goods through approximately 100 companies.

With BRICS providing an expanded platform for economic collaboration, the India-Indonesia partnership, underpinned by strong linkages in energy, pharmaceuticals, technology, and agricultural trade, is well positioned to serve as a key example of South-South economic cooperation.



Sohrab Bararia,
Partner and Leader - Global Trade & Incentives Advisory,
Grant Thornton Bharat

India-Indonesia Expand Cooperation

Health is emerging as a key pillar of the India-Indonesia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, with the two countries expanding cooperation across healthcare delivery, affordable medicines, medical education, hospital investments and traditional medicine.

Through an Implementation Arrangement on Professional Health Workforce Development, India and Indonesia are creating opportunities for fellowships, specialised clinical training, skills enhancement and the exchange of medical expertise—strengthening healthcare capabilities while deepening professional and people-to-people ties between the two countries.

India’s Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) and Indonesia’s Food and Drug Authority (BPOM) are working together on the regulation of medical products. This cooperation will simplify approval processes and facilitate the movement of quality Indian pharmaceutical products into the Indonesian market.

India’s globally recognised strength in generic medicines also offers significant opportunities for Indonesia. Greater trade in medicines and pharmaceutical components can help diversify and strengthen supply chains, while supporting access to quality and affordable treatments.

Indian Private-sector healthcare providers are expanding their footprint in Indonesia, with Apollo Hospitals partnering with the Mayapada Group on the Mayapada Apollo Batam International Hospital.

Indian Private-Sector healthcare providers are expanding their footprint in Indonesia, with Apollo Hospitals partnering with the Mayapada Group on the Mayapada Apollo Batam International Hospital. The venture is expected to enhance specialised healthcare services while supporting Indonesia’s ambitions in medical tourism.

Cooperation between India’s Ministry of AYUSH and Indonesia’s BPOM on traditional medicine quality assurance aims to promote the safe and regulated development of Ayurveda and Indonesia’s traditional wellness practices.

Together, these initiatives show that India-Indonesia health cooperation is moving beyond conventional diplomacy. By connecting medicines, medical professionals, hospitals, technology and traditional knowledge, the partnership is creating new pathways towards more accessible, affordable and capable healthcare systems.

Indonesia's SEZs: A Gateway for Indian Investment

As India hosts the 18th BRICS Summit, the grouping’s growing economic weight offers an opportunity to translate diplomatic ties into greater trade, investment and business linkages. For Indian companies, Indonesia, which joined BRICS in 2025, with its strategic location, large market and access to ASEAN, can serve as an important gateway to Southeast Asia.

Indonesia manages over 25 active Special Economic Zones (SEZs), which offer sector specific infrastructure and investment incentives. For Indian healthcare companies, Batam’s Health SEZ presents opportunities in medical research, advanced diagnostics, pharmaceuticals and international healthcare services.

Kendal and Sei Mangkei can attract manufacturers in areas such as electronics, EV components and agro-processing, while East Java’s Singhasari SEZ offers prospects in digital services, tourism and high-technology education.

The attraction is not merely geographical, SEZs provide Indian investors with a range of fiscal, customs and administrative incentives, including:

● **Tax holidays:** Corporate income tax reductions of up to 0% for periods of 10–20 years, depending on the scale of qualifying capital investment, including investments above IDR 100 billion.

● **Import and VAT exemptions:** Exemptions or relief from import duties and VAT on qualifying raw materials, factory equipment and capital machinery.

● **Greater foreign ownership flexibility:** Relaxation of certain restrictions under Indonesia’s national Positive Investment List, enabling 100% foreign ownership in eligible activities within designated SEZs, subject to applicable regulations.

● **Regional market access:** Indian enterprises can use Indonesian SEZs as a gateway to the 680-million-strong ASEAN market and wider RCEP markets, benefiting from preferential tariff access subject to applicable trade agreements and rules of origin.

The BRICS Summit can serve as a platform to deepen India-Indonesia business ties. A focused SEZ investment dialogue could translate strategic cooperation into factories, technology partnerships, healthcare ventures and jobs.



IIM Bangalore Campus Deepens India–Indonesia Ties

Indian Institute of Management Bangalore (IIMB) is establishing its first international campus at the Singhasari Special Economic Zone (SEZ) in Malang, Indonesia, marking a major step in the global expansion of Indian higher education and India–Indonesia cooperation.

The campus serves Indonesian students and professionals while also attracting learners from across the ASEAN region. It follows a two-phase model, beginning with Executive Education Programmes for senior executives, business leaders and public-sector professionals, followed by degree-granting management programmes.

Its curriculum focuses on emerging areas such as artificial intelligence, digital transformation, global supply chains, climate and sustainability, and healthcare management. The initiative also promotes research, faculty development, consulting and industry collaboration.

The campus has significance beyond education. By connecting students, academics and business leaders, it strengthens people-to-people and business ties and gives India a stronger knowledge presence in ASEAN. It complements growing cooperation in trade, technology, critical minerals, maritime security and defence.

The initiative supports the internationalisation objectives of National Education Policy 2020 and has the potential to position Singhasari as a

regional hub for management education and leadership development.

IIMB’s Indonesia campus thus represents a new chapter in India’s educational outreach and an important instrument of knowledge diplomacy and long-term India–Indonesia engagement.



IIMB’s Indonesia campus thus represents a new chapter in India’s educational outreach and an important instrument of knowledge diplomacy and long-term India–Indonesia engagement.



Indonesia is stepping up efforts to tap India’s vast wedding industry, estimated at \$60–75 billion and considered the world’s second-largest wedding market after the US. With destination weddings gaining traction among affluent Indian travellers, Bali is emerging as a key focus of Indonesia’s outreach. Wedding tourism has been identified as a priority segment alongside honeymoons, family travel and MICE.

Bali’s deep-rooted Hindu heritage gives the island a natural cultural affinity with Indian couples. Its temples, traditions and ceremonies offer families the opportunity to incorporate familiar customs into their celebrations. Luxury resorts in Nusa Dua, Jimbaran and Ubud add to the appeal, offering event spaces, accommodation and wellness facilities, along with an expanding range of Indian, vegetarian and Jain culinary options.

Indonesia is also deepening its engagement with Indian wedding planners and the travel trade through familiarisation trips, B2B meetings, sales missions and destination showcases.

With outreach expanding across major Indian cities, the country is presenting Bali and other destinations as a combination of cultural familiarity, tropical settings and international hospitality. The growing focus on weddings also offers a new avenue to deepen tourism and people-to-people ties between India and Indonesia.

Strengthening Defence Ties

India–Indonesia defence ties are entering a new phase. What began with military exchanges and maritime cooperation is increasingly expanding into defence trade, technology and industrial partnerships, reflecting growing strategic convergence between the two countries in the Indo-Pacific.

The 2018 Defence Cooperation Agreement strengthened institution-

alised military engagement, including regular Army-to-Army Staff Talks. Exercises such as Garuda Shakti and the multilateral KOMODO have further enhanced interoperability and operational cooperation.

Maritime security remains central to the relationship. Since 2002, the Indian and Indonesian navies have conducted coordinated patrols in the Indian Ocean, contributing to the security of vital sea lanes and reflecting their shared interest in a stable and secure Indo-Pacific.

The relationship has gained further momentum through defence-industrial cooperation. The recent BrahMos contract with Indonesia’s Ministry of Defence marks a significant milestone for India’s defence exports and its growing presence in Southeast Asia. BrahMos, one of the world’s fastest cruise missiles, can travel at Mach 2.8–3.0 and has an export range of up to 290km.

An agreement between Bharat Dynamics Limited and Indonesia’s defence holding company Republikorp for the Astra beyond-visual-range air-to-air missile further expands this cooperation. With the Astra Mk-1 being integrated onto Indonesian fighter aircraft, the partnership is increasingly moving towards defence technology and equipment collaboration.

The relationship has gained further momentum through defence-industrial cooperation. The recent BrahMos contract with Indonesia’s Ministry of Defence marks a significant milestone for India’s defence exports and its growing presence in Southeast Asia.

APP

APP Group welcomes BRICS Summit India 2026 and reaffirms its commitment to sustainable growth, trade, and cooperation across BRICS Economies.

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From CP to Akshardham, delegates, kin venture out to explore Delhi



Louise Araneta-Marcos, wife of Philippine President Ferdinand R Marcos Jr, at the Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya on Saturday.
PHOTO COURTESY: PRIME MINISTERS MUSEUM AND LIBRARY

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, September 12

FROM THE summit halls to temple premises, coffee shops and markets, visiting delegates and their families on Saturday got a taste of Delhi beyond the formal BRICS schedule.

In the afternoon, Belarus Foreign Affairs Minister Maxim Ryzhenkov and his delegation stepped out for a visit to the Akshardham temple. He arrived around 4 pm and spent about an hour-and-a-half there, leaving around 5.30 pm. Security arrangements were put in place for the visit.

The diplomatic crowd also made its way to some of the Capital's shopping and cultural destinations. Delegates from both Brazil and Russia visited the Khan Market.

"Some of the delegates from Brazil visited Khan Market yesterday. Today, again we were able to host a few delegates from Russia," said Sanjeev Mehra, president of the Khan Market Traders Association.

But the security cordon meant traders had little opportunity to interact with the visitors, he added.

At Connaught Place, delegates, spouses and family members dropped into popular bakeries and coffee shops, shopped and also posed for photographs with employees, said New Delhi Traders Association president Atul Bhargava.

"We have had foreign delegates, their spouses and extended families at Connaught Place today. They have been moving around freely and doing some shopping and enjoying some good food at Starbucks and Wenger's," he added. Some visitors also spent

time sitting on benches and in the open spaces around Connaught Place, said Bhargava.

However, despite the crowd, traders said the overall footfall remained low as several roads remained blocked as part of the summit's security arrangements.

Moreover, the spouses and families of visiting leaders visited some of Delhi's cultural attractions.

Louise Araneta-Marcos, spouse of Philippine President Ferdinand R Marcos Jr; Zahra Pezeshkian, daughter of Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian and Hassan Majidi, son-in-law of the Iranian President, visited the Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya.

According to a statement issued by the Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya, the visitors undertook a curated walk through blocks 1 and 2 and visited the Anubhuti section of the museum.

Further, union Minister Annapurna Devi hosted Louise Araneta-Marcos for a luncheon meeting.

During the meeting, Devi said she shared Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of women-led development and India's commitment to empowering women as leaders and equal partners in shaping a prosperous future.

Devi has also hosted family members of heads of state at the Crafts Bazaar at Bharat Mandapam. With the spouses' and families' itinerary kept flexible, more Delhi landmarks, including the National Gallery of Modern Art, could find their way onto the list on Sunday, the final day of the summit.

WITH INPUTS FROM MISHAL MUSSADDIQUE, DIVYA A



(Top) Bharat Mandapam during the BRICS Summit on Saturday; a deserted view of Connaught Place in New Delhi. PRAVEEN KHANNA & AMIT MEHRA

• MENU FOR GALA DINNER HOSTED BY PM MODI

Starters

Khandvi Mille Feuille Steamed gram-flour roll, tempered with mustard, coconut and curry leaves. Served with Kesar mango, micro-greens and yoghurt dressing

Khumb Galouti Tender pan-grilled mushroom kebabs with mint pearls, served on a bed of sheermal bread

Main Course

Paneer Lababdar Soft cottage cheese cubes simmered in a rich gravy of shallots and tomato

Gucchi Marmik Himalayan morel mushrooms and tender asparagus, gently simmered with saffron, raisins, and manna almonds

Carrot Bean Poriyal Blend of carrots and green beans toasted in aromatic South Indian spices in hand-pressed virgin coconut oil and finished with freshly grated coconut

Thakkali Belle Saaru Light lentil broth of toor dal enriched with fresh tomatoes and curry leaves

Millet Pulao Fragrant basmati rice

and pearl millets cooked with spices and seasonal aromatics

Beetroot Raita Chilled yoghurt with beetroot and fresh herbs

(Assorted Indian breads)

Dessert

Old Delhi fruit cream with Jalebi Seasonal fruits and lightly whipped cream paired with a crispy sweet fritter

Shaktoot Phirni Slow-cooked pudding of milk and rice, topped with sweet mulberries and gold leaf

Key routes see traffic restrictions, disruptions

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 12

DELHI WITNESSED traffic disruptions and regulated vehicle movement across key routes on Saturday, in the wake of the BRICS Summit beginning at Bharat Mandapam on Saturday.

Traffic congestion was observed in the Safdarjung Enclave area, near Deer Park Road in Hauz Khas, and on the fly-over towards Lajpat Nagar, during late Saturday.

However, most areas around Lutyens' Delhi witnessed relatively fewer traffic snarls, as Saturday was declared a public holiday for Central government and Delhi government officials, as well as schools. Many shops in the area were also shut.

Dr Zakir Hussain Marg, Baba Banda Singh Bahadur Marg, and Shyama Prasad Mukherjee Marg saw delays in traffic movement of over 12 minutes during the day, officers said.

The route around the AIIMS area also saw traffic snarls. However, according to a Delhi Traffic Police statement on X, this was mostly due to a fallen tree.

Meanwhile, commuters made use of the 22 diversion points identified earlier by the Delhi Police to tackle congestion. Many commuters also took to X to ask the Delhi Traffic Police about the routes they should take to avoid traffic snarls.

The area around Indira Gandhi International Airport (IGI) Airport, towards Dhaula Kuan, also saw traffic snarls on Saturday.



Heavy traffic congestion near Barapullah amid heightened security arrangements on Saturday. ANI

day, though to a lesser extent, as most of the BRICS delegates had already arrived by Friday.

The Delhi Traffic Police also issued a traffic advisory for Sunday in view of the ongoing BRICS Summit and the India-Afghanistan T20 cricket match at the Arun Jaitley Stadium, urging commuters to plan their journeys in advance and avoid affected areas wherever possible.

Traffic regulations will remain in force in the notified controlled area from 8 am to 8 pm, specifically during the movement of dignitaries attending the BRICS Summit, as per the advisory.

For assistance, commuters can contact the Delhi Traffic Police helpline at 1095.

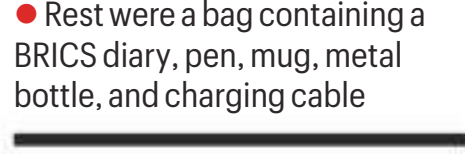
• THE MEDIA KIT



Sattu and makhana from Bihar: Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary highlighted the inclusion of the two products, calling it a moment of pride for the state.



Coffee from Koraput, Odisha: The Ministry of External Affairs partnered with the Odisha government to showcase coffee grown in the region.



Block-printed scarf from Gujarat: Made by hereditary artisans using centuries-old woodblock techniques and natural dyes.

• Rest were a bag containing a BRICS diary, pen, mug, metal bottle, and charging cable



Artists perform during the gala dinner hosted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi for leaders attending the summit. PTI



Union ministers Piyush Goyal and Arjun Ram Meghwal, with LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, travel in a bus to attend a banquet hosted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi for visiting dignitaries, in New Delhi on Saturday. PTI



Artists from BRICS countries have created a mural at the venue, inspired by India's idea of sangam (a meeting of rivers). The mural, part of the 'BRICS Friendship Mural' project, is displayed inside the main building at Bharat Mandapam. At its centre is the summit logo, topped by Jaipur's Hawa Mahal and flanked by two elephants, representing India. The rest of the mural shows nature, wildlife, and cultural symbols from other BRICS nations. PTI & INSTAGRAM/@MEAINDIA

• ELEVEN TOP HOTELS IN DELHI HOSTING INTERNATIONAL DELEGATES

Chocolate pyramids and Matryoshka dolls: Red carpet welcome for guests

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, September 12

A GOLDEN pyramid made of chocolate, hand-painted chocolate Matryoshka nesting dolls, elaborate floral arrangements: Luxury hotels in the Capital hosting international VIP guests for the 18th BRICS Summit have rolled out the red carpet.

Heads of states and guests from 11 member nations and 10 partner countries began arriving on Friday for the two-day summit. They are being hosted at 11 prime hotels — including ITC Maurya, Taj Palace, The Leela Palace, Taj Mahal Hotel,

and The Oberoi — that have been fortified by security cover by the Delhi Police and central agencies.

In some of these hotels, pastry chefs have curated special items, personalised with touches from the guests' home countries.

At ITC Maurya, the culinary team has designed a showcase featuring a line of hand-painted chocolate Matryoshka nesting dolls set beside a sculpted chocolate panorama of the Moscow skyline.

Accompanying it is a *thali* laden with traditional Indian *mithai*, alongside chocolate



A showcase at ITC Maurya featuring chocolate Matryoshka nesting dolls; (right) the spread at the Sheraton New Delhi. EXPRESS



bonbons spiced with Indian flavours of cardamom, saffron, rose, ginger, and fennel.

A similar showcase welcomes the President of Egypt at the Sheraton New Delhi. This

one features a textured golden pyramid made entirely of chocolate, placed alongside a framed

portrait of the President Abdel Fateh El Sisi and the Egyptian national flag. Glass clothes con-

taining artisanal cheeses and pastries have been placed along with bowls of dried apricots and nuts, and a spread of traditional Indian sweets.

"Our team has curated many specials for this iconic moment. Our chefs have drawn upon India's rich and diverse, inspiring culinary heritage," said Amit Kumar, General Manager, Sheraton New Delhi.

The décor is elaborate too. A multi-tiered floral installation, with yellow and white chrysanthemums and lilies, bedecks the lobby at ITC Maurya. Green, orange, yellow and red flowers have been arranged to spell out

'BRICS' on a table there.

At the Sheraton, an expansive floor art piece adorns the entrance, rendering the BRICS India 2026 lotus emblem and the summit's theme of 'Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability'.

"Such occasions call for meticulous preparation and seamless coordination. At the heart of the experience is the timeless Indian tradition of *namaste*. The culinary experience is an equally important part of this welcome," said Amaan Kidwai, Area Manager North Luxury Hotels & General Manager, ITC Maurya.

Skywatch

Forecast:

September 13, 2026

Generally cloudy sky, spell of very light to light rain likely

MAX: 33-35

1.5°C above normal

MIN: 25-27

0.6°C below normal

Sunrise: 6:05 AM (September 14)

Sunset: 6:29 PM (September 13)

Moonrise: 9:01 AM (September 14)

Moonset: 7:35 PM (September 13)

AQITracker

Pusa

Satisfactory

AQI: 73

JNU

Satisfactory

AQI: 57

Anand Vihar

Moderate

AQI: 103

Najafgarh

Good

AQI: 32

● Good (0-50)

● Satisfactory (51-100)

● Moderate (101-200)

● Poor (201-300)

● Very Poor (301-400)

● Severe (401-500)

3 arrested over pro-Khalistan graffiti near Singhu border

Express News Service

New Delhi, September 12

THREE MEN from Punjab were arrested in connection with alleged pro-Khalistan graffiti and objectionable slogans found near the Singhu border earlier this month, the Delhi Police said on Saturday. The accused, identified as Preetpal, Harminder Singh and Sheeshpal, were arrested from Faridkot after investigators examined CCTV footage from the area and tracked their movements, officers said.

According to police, Preetpal was allegedly in direct communication with designated terrorist Gurpatwant Singh Pannun, chief of the banned pro-Khalistan outfit Sikhs for Justice (SFJ). Pannun had reportedly instructed Preetpal to carry out the graffiti, sources in the police said. The slogans and graffiti were discovered on walls near the Singhu border on September 6. Following the incident, the Special Cell registered a case and began investigating the matter.

SATYA NIKETAN BUILDING COLLAPSE

Cops rely on rescued student to build case against PG operators

Pragynesh

New Delhi, September 12

ONE OF the students injured in the five-storey PG building collapse in South West Delhi's Satya Niketan is a key witnesses the Delhi Police is relying on to frame charges against the property's operators, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Nitish Chib (19) was a tenant at the PG, which was run from building 14 by 'Hostel Days', operated by Sudhanshu Lovneesh and Subham Tyagi. Both were arrested after the collapse on Sunday claimed seven lives.

When the structure came crashing down on Sunday, killing seven people – including five of Chib's fellow tenants – he was among those rescued.

Chib, who is from Raipur village in Jammu's Satwari area, was living in room 202. In his statement to the police, he said construction work in the basement had been going on for 10-12 days.

He and other students had complained to Lovneesh and



A building collapsed on September 6, killing 7 people. FILE

Tyagi about the noise and the cutting of iron rods on the ground floor, court documents showed.

"Chib said both Sudhanshu and Shubham allegedly told him that the PG would be extended to the basement and allegedly threatened to expel him from the PG if he objected," the source added.

Sources further said that the police will use Chib's statement, among other evidence like the lease papers of the property, to prove that Hostel Days was not merely a operator watching the construction

from the sidelines, but was actively promoting it, and threatening anyone who warned the operators about it.

Earlier, police sources had said a plumber warned Lovneesh hours before the collapse that the building's wall could give way because of the construction. While Lovneesh was arrested on Wednesday, Tyagi reached the police station and surrendered on Friday. He was produced in court and sent to two-day police custody.

Though Tyagi had earlier reportedly claimed that he only contributed financially to the

PG operation, police have allegedly found that the building was leased to both him and Lovneesh last year. While the upper ground and first floors were leased to Lovneesh, the second and third floors were leased to Tyagi.

Besides Lovneesh and Tyagi, building owner Hariram, his wife Urmila, their son Mahesh and labour contractor Saroj were arrested earlier this week. According to the police, the owner had permission to construct only the first and second floors of the building, but three additional floors were later added. The ongoing basement construction, which the owner allegedly said was undertaken to address seepage, further weakened the structure.

Lovneesh and Tyagi were in charge of installing the 16-bed facility with amenities, looking after maintenance, and overseeing the repair and construction work needed at the decades-old building.

They ran similar units in other parts of the area too.

Former Air India pilot found dead inside hotel room

Express News Service

New Delhi, September 12

A FORMER Air India pilot was found dead inside his hotel room in South Delhi's Vasant Kunj on Friday, said police. A probe has been launched to ascertain the circumstances of the death while the autopsy report is awaited to establish the cause of the death, officers added.

Identified as Captain Sunny Asladekar, he had checked in into The Grand on September 10. He was in the Capital for a Boeing 787 conversion training, said officers.

On Friday, when the pilot's brother allegedly rang him, no one answered the phone. His brother then alerted the management at the hotel, said police. The manager went to the room and found the door locked from inside. The room was opened with the help of a master key and the pilot was found lying unresponsive inside, said officers.

According to police, a PCR call regarding the ill health of a

guest at the hotel was received at the Vasant Kunj North police station on September 11.

A team reached the site and he was immediately taken to a hospital, where doctors declared him brought dead. The Crime Team was subsequently called to the spot.

Police inspected the room and initiated an enquiry into the circumstances of the death. The Crime Team was also called to examine the scene and collect any evidence that could assist the investigation.

A post-mortem examination was conducted at Safdarjung Hospital on September 12. Police said the exact cause of death would be established after the final medical report is received.

Meanwhile, inquest proceedings under Section 194 of the BNSS are being conducted. Investigators are examining the circumstances leading to the death and verifying other relevant facts. Police said further enquiry is underway and necessary legal proceedings are being carried out.

'Worms in idli, insects in chhole': Hostel students protest at Jamia

Sophiya Mathew

New Delhi, September 12

"YEKAANCH ketukde sabzi me nikal rhe hain... ye kayi baar hua hai mere saath... kisi aur ko bhi ye mila hai?" (Pieces of glass have been found in vegetable curry. This has happened multiple times. Has anyone else found this too?),

A student of Jamia Millia Islamia's Jammu and Kashmir Girls' Hostel shared this message with her hostel mates last November after allegedly finding a glass shard in her curry. As it turned out, this was not the last time the hostel students raised concerns over food quality.

On Wednesday, insects allegedly found in the chole during lunch was a fresh trigger. The students began a protest on

Thursday, demanding action against the mess contractor. Even as the demonstration was paused the next day following a written assurance from the varsity, students resumed the stir within hours, claiming the issues persisted. On Saturday night, students finally said they have called off the protest following a key meeting and fresh assurances.

'Long-standing issue'

According to the students' claims, worms in idli and rice, insects in dal and *chhole*, undercooked rice, raw chicken, and even glass shards in *sabzi* have been a recurring issue at the hostel for years. For nearly 700 students dependent on the J&K Girls' Hostel mess at JMI, such incidents have allegedly become common since the Covid-



Insects were found in food, as per students.

19 pandemic. Students said several of them had fallen sick after eating the food.

Tasleem Fathima, a fifth-year law student and member of the hostel mess committee, said, "Before Covid too, the quality was very bad. Roti is sometimes very hard, rice is uncooked."

After Wednesday's incident,

in a formal representation, the students' demands to the varsity included immediate termination of the mess contractor, a written assurance that protesters would not face disciplinary action, and deployment of women staff in the hostel mess. They also sought the resignation of the Provost, Warden, and Caretaker.

In response, the administration, agreed to the first set of demands early Friday. At the bottom of the formal representation submitted by J&K Girls' Hostel residents, an administrative official signed a response at 2:49 am Friday: "We are removing the mess contractor with immediate effect. Demand no. 1, 2 & 3 (pertaining to immunity for protesters, deployment of all women staff, termination of current contractor)

have been agreed to," the note read, *The Indian Express* learnt.

Following the written assurance, students temporarily paused their protest. However, alleging that same food arrangement continued, they resumed the protest around 9 pm Friday. They claimed that around 1 am on Saturday, amid the protest, the electricity supply was shut down. They also alleged that an official manhandled the protesters.

"In spite of such intimidation, students continued the demonstrations asking for the fulfillment of demands," a statement by the All India Students' Association read Saturday.

However, on Saturday night, following a key meeting with administration, Fathima said, "The protest has been called off after Proctor assured that all our

demands have been met."

In a formal communication, university officials said that regular monitoring of food quality by the Students' Mess Committee, Provost and Wardens would be done, female staff would serve food and that a Committee will be formed to look into hygiene specific concerns in the hostels.

Chief PRO Prof Saima Saeed told *The Indian Express*, "All the demands have been met. The contractor was changed. As this is a government university, due procedure for onboarding would require floating a tender. An interim arrangement has been made. A notice has been issued to the girls formally... Getting food for 700 people is not easy. Our food is the cheapest in Delhi, under Rs 3,000 per month, per person."

Construction waste rates cut by 85% amid garbage pile-up in Gurgaon

Gurgaon: In a bid to curb illegal dumping of garbage across vacant plots, green belts and roadsides, the Municipal Corporation of Gurugram) slashed the processing and lifting charge for non-bulk construction and demolition (C&D) waste by over 85% during a General House meeting on Friday. The meeting came on the day the 37-day

statewide strike by municipal sanitation workers was called off, potentially easing the garbage situation in Gurgaon.

The decision has been taken to reduce the fee for non-bulk C&D waste generated primarily by individual homeowners and small renovation projects from Rs 360 per tonne to Rs 50 per tonne.

ENS

Central University of Punjab

Dated: 11.09.2026WALK-IN-INTERVIEWAdvt. CUPB/26-27/013

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TRAFFIC POLICE DELHI

AFGHANISTAN Vs INDIA

13, 15 & 17 September 2026

6:00 PM to 11:00 PM

HELP US SERVE YOU BETTER

Map of the stadium area showing roads, landmarks, and parking zones.

USE METRO FOR HASSLE FREE JOURNEY

Free Parking : Mata Sundari Parking, Rajghat Power House Road, Under Velodrome Road

SECURITY INSTRUCTIONS: Spectators visiting the stadium are requested not to bring the following prohibited items:

Laptop

Camera

Helmet

Bagpack

Eatables

Water Bottles

Power Bank

Lighter & Match Box

Knives & Arms

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ITO (Gate No. 3, 4 & 5)

24 Hours Traffic Helpline: 011-25844444 / 1095

ARUN JAITLEY STADIUM, FIROZESHAH KOTLA GROUND, NEW DELHI

DIVERSION / RESTRICTION (AS AND WHEN REQUIRED)

There will diversion of traffic for one hour before start of the match and one hour after conclusion of the match. No Carrier goods shall be allowed on Bahadurshah Zafar Marg, Delhi Gate to J.L.N. Marg, from Darya Ganj to Bahadurshah Zafar Marg and from Guru Nanak Chowk to Asaf Ali Road, People are requested to avoid following roads from 6:00 PM to 12:00 PM on 13.09.2026, 15.09.2026 & 17.09.2026 when there spectstators would be leaving/coming to the stadium and congestion in expected.

Raj Ghat to JLN Marg.

Asaf Ali Road from Turkman Gate to Delhi Gate.

Bahadurshah Zafar Marg from ITO Chowk to Delhi Gate

ENTRY TO THE STADIUM

(I) Gate No. 1 to 8 are located on the southern side of the Stadium & entry to these enclosures are from Bahadurshah Zafar Marg.

(II) Gate No. 10 to 15 are located on the Eastern side of the Stadium on the road and entry is from J.L.N. Marg next to Ambedkar Stadium Bus Terminal.

(II) Gate No. 16, 17 & 18 are located on the Western side of the Stadium & entry is from Bahadurshah Zafar Marg Near Petrol Pump.

PARKING

Labeled Vehicles

Car parking label holders are advised to take Ring Road, J.L.N. Marg, Asaf Ali Road or Bahadurshah Zafar Marg. 'U' turn at Delhi Gate is allowed. Entry to parking lots P1, P2, & P3 shall be from Bahadurshah Zafar Marg only from near the Vikram Nagar Cut, Shaheed Path.

Limited parking is available for labeled vehicles in the proximity of the stadium. Display of car parking label on windscreen is mandatory. Vehicle number must be written on the parking label. Those who do not display parking label with vehicle number will not be allowed in the proximity of the stadium.

Free parking for vehicle is available on Mata Sundri Road, Rajghat Power House Road Velodrome Road and free park & ride.

General Vehicles

No vehicle shall be allowed to be parked on Bahadurshah Zafar Marg, Jawaharlal Nehru Marg & Ring Road from Rajghat to I.P. Flyover (both the carriageways) on the match day. Vehicles parked on these roads shall be towed away and prosecuted as per law.

FREE PARKING

Mata Sundri Road Rajghat Power House Road Under Velodrome Road



(From left) Brazil's Foreign Minister Mauro Vieira, Abu Dhabi Crown Prince Sheikh Khaled bin Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto, Egyptian President Abdel Fattah el-Sisi, Russian President Vladimir Putin, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Chinese President Xi Jinping, South African President Cyril Ramaphosa, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian and Ethiopian Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed Ali during the BRICS Leaders' Summit at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi on Saturday. PTI

•Summit Snippets

From Sept 21, Guangzhou to Delhi flights

AS CHINESE President Xi Jinping arrived in Delhi for BRICS Saturday, China Southern Airlines announced resumption of passenger flights on Guangzhou-New Delhi route from September 21, after a six-year hiatus. The airline said it will operate Guangzhou-New Delhi service as part of more than 100 weekly flights across eight round-trip routes in South Asia.



PM Narendra Modi and South African President Cyril Ramaphosa in New Delhi on Saturday. ANI

BRICS nations pitch for wider access to AI

BRICS LEADERS called for wider access to AI resources and stronger international cooperation to ensure the technology is safe, secure, inclusive and reliable, and its potential risks are mitigated, as they committed to implementing grouping's statement on 'Global Governance of Artificial Intelligence'. The declaration called for fostering AI for science and innovation, developing trustworthy AI tech, improving energy efficiency of AI systems and mitigating potential risks, particularly with an eye on ensuring a "just, fair, equitable and prosperous future" of all countries, especially those of Global South.

Concerns over drug abuse, its illicit production

BRICS NATIONS expressed concern over illicit drug production, trafficking and abuse and welcomed Guwahati Declaration in July. The declaration said it "seriously threatens public security, health, safety and well-being of humankind and undermines the sustainable development of States."

BRICS condemns Pahalgam attack, calls for action on terror safe havens

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, September 12

THE BRICS grouping on Saturday once again condemned the Pahalgam terror attack that killed 26 people, with China joining the other members in a declaration that called for "zero tolerance" towards terrorism, action against terrorist safe havens and accountability for those involved in terror activities.

The reaffirmation in the New Delhi Declaration is significant as it comes more than a year after the 2025 attack and amid continuing tensions between India and Pakistan over cross-border terror. It is also the second consecutive BRICS Summit declaration after the Rio de Janeiro declaration of July 2025 to specifically name Pahalgam attack.

"We express strong condemnation of any acts of terrorism as criminal and unjustifiable, regardless of their motivation, whenever, wherever and by whomsoever committed. We condemn in the strongest terms the terrorist attack in Jammu and Kashmir on 22 April 2025, during which 26 people were killed and many more injured," the declaration said.

More significantly for India, China — Pakistan's long-standing strategic partner and a country that has frequently

We condemn in the strongest terms the terrorist attack in J&K on 22 April 2025, during which 26 people were killed and many more injured."

NEW DELHI DECLARATION ON PAHALGAM TERROR ATTACK

shielded Islamabad at international forums — is again a signatory to the condemnation.

The language in the New Delhi Declaration is almost identical to that adopted in Rio. Both condemn the April 22, 2025 attack "in the strongest terms", note that 26 people were killed, and reaffirm the BRICS commitment to combat terrorism in all its forms, including "cross-border movement of terrorists", terror financing and safe havens.

Both declarations also state that terrorism should not be associated with any religion, nationality, civilisation or ethnic group and that those involved in terrorist activities and their support must be held accountable and brought to justice under national and international law.

The New Delhi Declaration reiterates the call for "zero tolerance for terrorism" and rejection of "double standards" in countering terrorism. It also calls for concerted action against all terrorists and terrorist entities designated by the UN.

The repeated BRICS reference to Pahalgam gives India an important diplomatic marker where even within a grouping that includes China and Russia and has expanded to include countries with close ties to Pakistan, the attack itself has remained difficult to contest as an act of terrorism. The declaration, however, stops short of attributing the attack to Pakistan or explicitly endorsing India's subsequent military response.

Notably, Beijing had condemned the Pahalgam terror attack soon after it occurred. The Pahalgam attack itself attracted wide condemnation, cutting across geopolitical alignments. The UN, G7, the EU and governments across the US, Europe, Gulf, Asia and elsewhere condemned the attack and expressed solidarity with India. International response became more nuanced once India responded militarily. Even governments that had strongly condemned Pahalgam generally shifted to calls for restraint, de-escalation and dialogue as India and Pakistan moved towards military confrontation.

Amid wars in sea lanes, PM proposes seafarers' emergency support network

Divya A
New Delhi, September 12

AT THE BRICS Leaders' Summit on Saturday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi proposed establishing a 'Seafarers' Emergency Support Network' to provide timely assistance and ensure the safety of personnel working at sea. Modi said that "global trade can move forward only when sea lanes are secure, supply routes remain open, and seafarers are safe."

The safety of Indian seafarers has emerged as a recurring focus of New Delhi's recent engagements. He proposed that the support network should provide distress alerts, medical aid, family communication and



Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi (left) with his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi in New Delhi on Saturday. ANI

evacuation support for seafarers. "Seafarers make a significant contribution to global trade, but

they often find themselves without adequate support during difficult times. My proposal is — can we create a Seafarers Emergency Support Network?" Modi said during his opening remarks at the summit.

"Through this, maritime authorities and missions of the concerned countries can be connected. It can provide support for distress alerts, medical assistance... informing families and evacuation," he said.

India supplies a massive share of the global maritime workforce. In fact, India provides over 12% of all trained seafarers around the world, with thousands of Indian families depending on those working aboard commercial vessels.

However, in the wake of the conflict in West Asia, Indian crew members have come under attack, often becoming unintended casualties. As per official figures, 15 Indian seafarers have lost their lives while two remain missing due to attacks in West Asia and the Black Sea.

India presently has over three lakh active seafarers. A total of 173 Indian seafarers remain in the Persian Gulf, according to a Directorate of Maritime Administration report.

The safety of Indian seafarers and freedom of navigation through the Hormuz were discussed during PM Modi's bilateral with Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian in New Delhi a day earlier as well.

Four agricultural initiatives announced, aimed at climate resilience, productivity

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, September 12

THE BRICS nations on Saturday announced four new agriculture initiatives, including the establishment of Agroecology and Regenerative Agriculture for Climate Resilience and Productivity and Digital Agriculture.

In a significant breakthrough for India, the BRICS grouping adopted the New Delhi joint declaration with consensus, in which the leaders also agreed to the establishment of a collaborative, non-binding, and farmer-centric BRICS AGRIN (Agro-Inputs, Genetic Resources, and In-

- **4 AGRI INITIATIVES**
BRICS AGRIN (Agro-Inputs, Genetic Resources, and Information Network)
GLOBAL FORUM on Farmers' Rights in Seed Systems
BRICS NETWORK of Centres of Excellence on Agroecology and Regenerative Agriculture for Climate Resilience and Productivity
BRICS NETWORK on Digital Agriculture, including agroforestry, fisheries, and aquaculture

formation Network), while welcoming the launch of a Global Forum on Farmers' Rights in Seed Systems.

"We welcome the outcomes of the 16th BRICS Agriculture Ministers' Meeting, held in Indore. We agree to the establishment of a collaborative, non-binding, and farmer-centric BRICS AGRIN (Agro-Inputs, Genetic Resources, and Information Network), drawing upon relevant national, regional, and international practices. We also welcome the launch of a Global Forum on Farmers' Rights in Seed Systems to address shared challenges, promote effective policies, and encourage the documentation and exchange of traditional knowledge related to agriculture and seed systems," the New Delhi Declaration stated.

It also welcomed the strengthening of cooperation in agriculture through the establishment of a BRICS Network of Centres of Excellence on Agroecology and Regenerative Agriculture for Climate Resilience and Productivity, and a BRICS Network on Digital Agriculture, including agroforestry, fisheries, and aquaculture. We also encourage further cooperation under the BRICS Dialogue on Development of Fisheries and Aquaculture, it said.

The BRICS nation also reiterated their commitment to advancing agriculture negotiations at the WTO.

In backdrop of handshake, a cultural keynote — Rameswaram temple

Divya A
New Delhi, September 12

THE 12TH-CENTURY Ramanathaswamy Temple in Rameswaram, Tamil Nadu, served as the visual backdrop and cultural centerpiece when PM Narendra Modi welcomed world leaders at Bharat Mandapam for the BRICS Leaders' Summit in New Delhi on Saturday, highlighting India's civilisational history to the Global South.

It was against this backdrop that the day's first handshake happened between PM Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping, with the two leaders spending some time looking at the 3D backdrop, and PM Modi explaining the site to the Chinese President. Tamil Nadu is also where Modi had hosted Xi during his last India visit in 2019.

The temple in Rameswaram is among the 12 sacred Jyotirlingas.

Its outer corridor — displayed in the image at Bharat Mandapam — is the longest among all temples in India, featuring over 1,200 intricately carved stone pillars.

As dignitaries walked the red carpet to the spot where the PM welcomed them, there were murals depicting 'yogasanas'. At the summit venue, artists from BRICS member countries have created 'Sangam' — a mural depicting the Summit logo at the centre, with the image of the iconic Hawa Mahal of Jaipur, flanked by a pair of elephants.

According to a Tamil Nadu government website, the Ramanathaswamy Temple was under the care of a monk up to the 10th century. In the 12th century, Parakiramabaghu, the King of Ceylon, built the sanctum sanctorum of the temple. Three hundred years later, Ramanathapuram King Udayan



(Left) PM Narendra Modi explains to Chinese President Xi Jinping the architectural wonders of Rameswaram temple, at Bharat Mandapam on Saturday; (above) the leaders in Mamallapuram in 2019. PTI

Sethupathi and a Vaisya from Nagoore built its western tower and compound walls.

Subsequently, between 1897 and 1904, the 126-foot-high nine-tiered East Rajagopuram was completed by the family of Nattukkottai. According to Hindu mythology, Lord Ram consecrated the shivalingam here after returning from Lanka.

Earlier, during India's G20 Presidency in 2023, a replica of the Konark Wheel from Odisha's Sun Temple served as the primary backdrop for Modi's welcome handshakes with global leaders. It was chosen to represent India's ancient heritage, wisdom, and advanced civilisation, with Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam as the G20 theme.



MENTAL WELLNESS

NIMHANS to be nodal body for BRICS Centres of Excellence

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, September 12

THE NEW Delhi Declaration adopted during the ongoing 18th BRICS Summit agrees to support the establishment of a network of training hubs and Centres of Excellence (CoEs) for mental health, with Bengaluru-based National Institute of Mental Health and Neuro Sciences (NIMHANS) being the coordinating centre.

“The Network of CoEs could also serve as a platform to facilitate collaborative research, policy dialogue, exchange of best practices, and the co-development of evidence-based mental health promotion strategies across BRICS countries,” the declaration states.

According to the Declaration, a designated group of representatives from each BRICS member state will jointly govern the network and ensure “balanced decision-making and shared accountability” towards achieving scientific and technical cooperation for sustainable and scalable integration of mental well-being into primary healthcare.

“We also welcome the Compendium of Best Practices on Promotion of Mental Wellness,” the declaration says.

It adds: “We emphasise the importance of addressing the

mental health consequences of crises and are committed to providing timely, accessible, and sustained mental health and psycho-social (MHPSS) interventions to affected populations, particularly people in vulnerable situations, including children and adolescents.”

In addition, the declaration also focuses on the emerging challenges of non-communicable diseases and endorses the launch of BRICS Mission for Healthy Lifestyle and the BRICS Roadmap for the Joint Initiative on Healthy Lifestyle Promotion (2026-29). “We also welcome the Compendium of Replicable Best Practices on Healthy Lifestyle,” it says.

The declaration also talks about the growing relevance of traditional and integrative medicine (TCIM). “We welcome the proposed establishment of the BRICS Expert Working Group on TCIM under the BRICS Health Track as a platform for dialogue, collaboration and exchange among Member States.”

The platform will coordinate research on medicinal plants and herbal preparations for therapeutic and preventive uses. It goes on to add that importance will be laid on ensuring the quality, safety, and efficacy of these TCIM practices and products with an evidence-informed approach.



Abu Dhabi Crown Prince Sheikh Khaled bin Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan with PM Narendra Modi on Saturday. PTI

Strong India-UAE ties key to stability: PM meets Crown Prince of Abu Dhabi

Divya A
New Delhi, September 12

A DAY after holding an extensive bilateral meeting with visiting Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday held a meeting with Abu Dhabi Crown Prince Sheikh Khaled bin Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, calling “a strong India-UAE” a symbol of peace and stability at a time of uncertainty in West Asia.

Modi and the visiting UAE leader discussed the overall situation in West Asia and ways to take the India-UAE strategic partnership forward. “Discussed taking our strategic partnership forward across defence, AI, space, critical minerals, energy, food security and connectivity,” Modi said in a social media post after the meeting. “At a time of uncertainty in West Asia, a strong India-UAE is a symbol of stability, prosperity and peace,” he added.

The meeting came amid reports that BRICS countries have reached a consensus on a joint statement after intensive negotiations that went on till the early hours of Saturday.

The breakthrough assumes significance given that Iran, Saudi Arabia and the UAE are all part of the same forum, despite differences and competing positions on several regional and geopolitical issues, sources said.

The key point of discord for

negotiators ahead of the joint declaration was the formulation over the war in West Asia, given that Iran, the UAE and Saudi Arabia were at the summit table.

Odisha project

During the West Asia conflict, New Delhi often expressed “deep anxiety over the safety of nearly 10 million Indian citizens living and working in the Gulf region, noting that some Indian nationals had been affected or lost their lives amid the escalating conflict”.

As per the Ministry of External Affairs, PM Modi appreciated the UAE’s active and constructive participation in BRICS under India’s Chairship. “The leaders welcomed the positive outcomes within BRICS during India’s Chairship and agreed that the two countries would continue to work closely through the platform to advance shared interests and priorities and further strengthen BRICS cooperation,” the MEA readout said.

Adding that the leaders acknowledged the progress achieved in bilateral relations in a wide range of sectors, the MEA said that the two leaders “positively noted the announcement by UAE’s International Holding Company to invest in the development of a \$11.5 billion integrated greenfield aluminium project in Odisha, India’s largest integrated aluminium investment”.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his Malaysian counterpart Anwar Ibrahim on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit at Hyderabad House, on Saturday. At a meeting, both sides held talks focusing on cooperation in the areas of trade, semiconductors, infrastructure and defence. Malaysia is a partner country in the BRICS grouping. It is also a key partner country for India within the ASEAN grouping. PTI

‘Fossil fuels will still play an important role’: Declaration opposes carbon border tax

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, September 12

AMID DISRUPTIONS to global supply chains and energy security due to the West Asia conflict, the New Delhi Declaration adopted at the 18th BRICS Summit unequivocally acknowledged that fossil fuels will still play an important role in the world’s energy mix, particularly for developing economies, and opposed European Union’s carbon border tax.

The declaration reaffirmed the commitment of BRICS to tackle climate change and called upon all countries to uphold their existing commitment to the Paris climate agreement, including its provisions related to climate mitigation, adaptation, loss and damage and the principles of equity.

However, it underscored the importance of nationally determined just transitions — which refers to shift to cleaner fuels for producing electricity and in energy use. It called upon developed countries to provide additional, adequate, predictable and accessible financial resources along with technological transfer to developing countries for climate adaptation.

The declaration framed energy security as a crucial foundation for social and economic

E. EXPLAINED

Leading coal consumers

BRICS MEMBER countries China, India, Indonesia and Russia are among the leading coal consumers in the world. Even as they have made rapid strides in the expansion of renewable energy, coal continues to be among the mainstays of sources for electricity production and energy use.

omic development. “We acknowledge fossil fuels will play an important role in the world’s energy mix, particularly for emerging markets and developing economies, and we recognize the need to promote just, orderly, equitable and inclusive energy transitions and reduce GHG (greenhouse gas) emissions in line with our climate goals and observing SDG7 (sustainable development goals), the principles of technological neutrality and common but differentiated responsibilities and respective capabilities taking into account national circumstances, needs and priorities,” the declaration stated.

BRICS member countries China, India, Indonesia and Russia are among the top five largest coal consumers with the US being the only non-BRICS bloc country. They have also made rapid strides in the expansion of renewable energy, but coal continues to remain one of the largest sources for electricity production and energy use.

The declaration recognised the key role of critical minerals for development of zero- and low-emission energy technologies, energy security, and resilience in supply chains.

On the EU’s carbon border tax, an import levy on carbon-intensive goods, the declaration said that it opposed “unilateral, punitive, discriminatory and protectionist measures that are not in line with international law”. “...Such measures undermine efforts by countries, specifically developing countries, aimed at addressing the adverse impacts of climate change, increasing adaptive capacity and resilience.”

In the backdrop of the Nepal flash flood last month, the BRICS declaration also acknowledged the growing complexity of disaster risks, including those related to climate change, and especially for the Global South. The guidelines for Disaster Management Early Warning Data Integration were welcomed.

BRICS should play ‘due role’ in bringing peace to West Asia: Xi

ENS & PTI
New Delhi, September 12

CHINESE PRESIDENT Xi Jinping on Saturday said that BRICS countries should firmly stand on the right side of history, calling on the grouping to play its “due role” in bringing peace in West Asia. Xi said that as the situation in West Asia and the Gulf region continues to evolve, the war there has caused serious losses to people across the region and does not serve the common interests of the international community.

Xi also called on BRICS countries to “pioneer in innovative development, as well as in maintaining peace and stability, boosting mutual learning among civilizations, and improving global governance, noting that BRICS countries should steer the international order toward greater justice and equity, and work together to build a community with a shared future for humanity,” Xinhua reported.

The Chinese President said it has been 20 years of self-reliance and self-strengthening, adding that BRICS countries have actively explored development paths suited to their own national conditions, setting an example of self-strengthening through unity among emerging markets and developing countries.

This has also been 20 years of standing together through thick and thin, Xi noted.

Xi called on BRICS to be a pioneer in upholding peace and stability.

BRICS countries should uphold a vision of common, comprehensive, cooperative and sustainable security, and oppose the Cold War mentality and bloc confrontation, he said. They should reject violations of other countries’ sovereignty and interference in their internal affairs, and play a constructive role in resolving hotspot issues, making a distinctive BRICS contribution to finding



Chinese President Xi Jinping during a meeting with PM Narendra Modi on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit on Saturday. REUTERS

solutions that address both symptoms and root causes, he said.

Noting that the situation in West Asia remains complex and fluid, Xi said this war has inflicted serious losses on the people of all countries in the region and is against the common interests of the international community.

Xi said he has set out four propositions on safeguarding and promoting peace and stability in West Asia which are aimed at de-escalation, ending hostilities and promoting peace.

He urged relevant parties to follow the direction of political settlement and work for a permanent, comprehensive ceasefire.

China will work with fellow BRICS members to play a due role in bringing peace and tranquility to the region, he said.

Xi stressed that the world is undergoing accelerated transformation unseen in a century, the Global South is rapidly growing in strength and the trend toward a multipolar world is unstoppable.

In a veiled criticism of the US, Xi said countercurrents of unilateralism and power politics are surging, multilateralism and the international order are coming under strain, and deficits in peace, development, security and governance continue to widen.

Putin on BRICS’s credibility

President Vladimir Putin, according to the Kremlin, said, “Partnership within BRICS is consistently built on the principles of equality, good-neighbourliness, and mutual consideration of interests along with respect for one another’s cultural and civilisational diversity, history, traditions, and values. It stands to reason, then, that the credibility and influence of BRICS around the globe are steadily growing”.

Iran’s President Masoud Pezeshkian, according to the Iranian Embassy in New Delhi, said, “Sustainable security depends on full respect for national sovereignty and rejecting the model of security for some and insecurity for others.”

“Preventing the misuse of countries’ territories to threaten their neighbours is an inviolable principle. BRICS must stand against the normalisation of attacks on civilian infrastructure and peaceful nuclear facilities,” he said.

With China on board, BRICS calls for boosting transport

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, September 12

BRICS NATIONS, in a joint statement issued on Saturday, reaffirmed their commitment to enhance transport potential, including in civil aviation, while also respecting the sovereignty and territorial integrity of all member states, while carrying out transport cooperation,” the statement said.

The joint declaration further said the BRICS countries will deepen cooperation in the sector with a view to develop sustainable and resilient transport infrastructure as it plays a critical role in economic growth.

“We acknowledge the importance of embedding circular economy principles into the development and mainstream (LAC), particularly in region like Arunachal Pradesh.

“We welcome the outcomes of the BRICS Transport Ministers’ Meeting held in Nagpur and look forward to further promoting transport

dialogue, including in civil aviation, to meet the demand of all stakeholders and to enhance the BRICS countries’ transport potential while also respecting the sovereignty and territorial integrity of all member states, while carrying out transport cooperation,” the statement said.

The joint declaration further said the BRICS countries will deepen cooperation in the sector with a view to develop sustainable and resilient transport infrastructure as it plays a critical role in economic growth.

“We acknowledge the importance of embedding circular economy principles into the development and mainstream (LAC), particularly in region like Arunachal Pradesh.

“We welcome the outcomes of the BRICS Transport Ministers’ Meeting held in Nagpur and look forward to further promoting transport

● AS UAE LEADER MEETS IRAN PRESIDENT, MEDIA PERSONS FROM BOTH COUNTRIES GO ABOUT DOING THEIR JOB UNDER THE SAME ROOF

‘We are all professionals doing our work, leaders doing what they do’

Divya A
New Delhi, September 12

AS THE United Arab Emirates’ Sheikh Khaled bin Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan met Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian on the sidelines of the BRICS Leaders’ Summit in New Delhi, media delegations from the respective countries — sharing the Media Centre at Bharat Mandapam — expressed surprise and relief at the development.

The UAE has been at the receiving end of a series of Iranian strikes on its cities with Tehran calling it a proxy of the United States.

In the past, Iran and the UAE had been in disagreement on the phrasing of the war in West Asia. However, as India achieved the much-anticipated consensus at the BRICS Summit between the two countries on Saturday, the visiting leaders from two sides also held a one-on-one meeting.

The media contingent from the UAE was bigger — around 20 people comprising crews from state-owned Abu Dhabi TV, some other news channels and a group of newspaper journalists, Iranian media group was relatively smaller — representing state-owned IRNA news agency and several other outlets.

At the International Media



The Media Centre at Bharat Mandapam on Saturday. DIVYA A

Centre, from where they operated throughout the day, both sides kept to different sides of the room, neither talking to each other nor about each other. A journalist from a prominent UAE newspaper, who didn’t want to be named, said, “I have been asked by several people here about how I feel about my Iranian counterparts. I would say we are all professionals, doing our work, while politicians and leaders are doing what they do,” she said, adding, “At a human level, none of us would have a problem with each other.”

Her colleague added, “I will be happy to talk and exchange

pleasantries if someone walks up to me. Having said that, we are here because of our countries’ ties with India, and here to talk about it.”

While a section of media persons accompanied respective leaders from both countries, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) had also invited and hosted social media influencers from all BRICS countries for over a week, taking them to Agra and Mumbai as well.

Over 1,000 journalists were present at the media centre on Saturday, including over 100 from various BRICS countries, including China, Russia and South Africa.

STATE MINISTER RANE, WHO INITIALLY BACKED VHP, SOFTENS STAND; SAYS PARTICIPANTS SHOULD HAVE 'CLEAN INTENTIONS'

Amruta's 'Garba for all' remark puts BJP in a bind as VHP insists on Muslim entry ban

Shubhangi Khapre
Mumbai, September 12

THE VISHVA Hindu Parishad's (VHP) call to bar Muslims from Garba and Dandiya celebrations in Maharashtra has opened a fresh faultline within the broader Hindutva camp, with Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis' wife Amruta Fadnavis publicly taking a more inclusive position and BJP leaders seeking to soften the issue.

The controversy comes ahead of Navratri celebrations beginning on October 11. VHP activists are asking Garba and Dandiya event organisers to restrict the entry of Muslims to the venue and verify participants through Aadhaar cards. Organisers have also been urged to ensure that participants apply a red tilak on their foreheads as a means of establishing their Hindu identity.

The VHP's position has been backed by Maharashtra Cabinet minister Nitesh Rane, who has alleged that some people enter Garba events using Hindu names and target Hindu women under what he describes as "love jihad".

It was against this backdrop

that Amruta Fadnavis said she did not see anything wrong with Muslims attending Garba celebrations. "I feel our festival is inclusive. If a Muslim person comes and enjoys Garba and leaves, I would not find anything wrong with it," she said.

VHP national spokesperson and joint secretary Shirraj Nair reiterated the organisation's stand in the wake of Amruta's remarks. "The VHP wants a complete ban on Muslims at Navratri celebrations. As an organisation VHP has its own standing and policies, which I am conveying. How are we going to speak on behalf of others? Who says what is not for us to analyse," Nair said.

The VHP has justified its demand by arguing that Navratri is a Hindu religious festival centred on the worship of Goddess Durga and Goddess Amba. "When Muslims don't believe in idol worship of Gods and Goddesses, why do they want to participate in Garba-Dandiya celebrations during Navratri," Nair asked.

Rane, who supported the VHP's demand, had argued that Garba and Navratri events could become vulnerable to "love jihad". "If Garba and Navratri



'I feel our festival is inclusive,' Amruta Fadnavis said on Garba-Dandiya celebrations

continue to become headquarters of 'love jihad', then it is the responsibility of the VHP and Hindutva activists like us to stop it," Rane had said.

Following Amruta's remarks, however, Rane adopted a somewhat softer position, saying Muslims who participate in Garba should do so with "clean intentions". Amruta, meanwhile, declined to directly comment on Rane's remarks.

"He must have said this after thinking something; I do not want to get into its depths," she said. She, however, made it clear that in her view, participation in Garba should not be determined

by religion.

"Garba is a national celebration and it is even celebrated internationally. So if anyone from any community or faith wants to come and see this peacefully without creating any chaos, I think that is alright. But I haven't studied what other reasons there are behind it," she said.

A state cabinet minister, speaking on condition of anonymity, said the VHP and the BJP should not be treated as one organisation.

"While VHP is our affiliate organisation, it is different from the BJP. We have not given any clarion call seeking a ban on Muslims' entry in Navratri celebrations," the minister said.

He said Garba and Dandiya celebrations were largely organised by private groups and that the government's role is limited.

BJP spokesperson Navnath Ban too rejected the idea of a ban on the entry of Muslims.

"We are not asking for banning anybody in any celebrations or festivals. Our only concern is that those who want to participate should not come with any motive to create any law and order problem or harm Hindus," Ban said.

He said the party was concerned about security at the events. "In the past there were concerns about celebrations being misused by certain sections against Hindus. Security is our responsibility and concern."

A BJP political strategist said the party was also conscious of the broader messaging coming from the Sangh Parivar leadership. "RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat during his recent New York visit conveyed a strong message of universal oneness. He made it abundantly clear that anybody seeking Muslim ouster was not a true Hindu. Similarly, in the UK he came with a message of love and not hate," the strategist said.

"We don't want to dent our image politically on such trivial issues like who should participate or not in song and dance celebrations," he said.

The strategist also pointed out that Garba-Dandiya celebrations had evolved beyond their traditional religious boundaries.

"Garba-Dandiya, unlike in the past, has broken the barriers of religion, community and caste," he said.

The BJP, he said, did not want to be perceived by younger

voters as "conservative and orthodox" by appearing to discriminate against Muslims over participation in a popular cultural celebration.

The VHP, however, has shown no indication of backing down. Its insistence on identity verification and a Hindu-only policy has kept the issue alive, while Rane's initial support for the demand has added a political dimension to what the BJP now seeks to portray primarily as a matter of organisers' choice and security.

Remove Rane: Cong

The Congress has seized on the difference in positions, backing Amruta while questioning whether her stand would translate into political action against Rane. Congress leader Vijay Wadetiwar said, "What Bhabhi ji has said is absolutely true. I welcome and congratulate her for her vision of taking everyone in the state along."

"But I have one question: If your views are truly like this, will Amruta ji also ask the CM to remove Nitesh Rane from the position of minister, because he repeatedly makes inflammatory statements against the Muslim community?"

EC hears Trinamool factions, seeks more documents from rebels

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 12

THE ELECTION Commission on Saturday met both factions of the TMC and sought more documents from the rebel Ritabrata Banerjee-led faction as the fight for the party's claim to its name and symbol intensified.

The Mamata Banerjee-led faction was represented by MP Derek O'Brien and four others, while Ritabrata himself represented his faction before the Election Commission. The EC hearing is significant as it comes ahead of the October 6 Nandigram and Rejinagar Assembly bypolls, for which filing of nomination ends on September 16.

After the meeting, Ritabrata described the hearing as "fruitful". "They (EC) had many queries. We answered them and showed some documents. They asked us to submit those documents," he said.

He said the faction was hopeful of being recognised as the TMC. On the bypoll in Nandigram, Ritabrata said: "Mamata Banerjee has never won any direct Assembly election. She is very comfortable with by-elections... In 2021, it was again a by-election because she got defeated in Nandigram... We want Mamata Banerjee to be a part of

Will withdraw candidate if Mamata contests Nandigram bypoll, says Ritabrata

the Assembly... we have decided our candidate. Even after the announcement, if she expresses a desire to fight as an independent candidate, we will withdraw our candidate in her support."

In a statement after the meeting, the Mamata-led faction said its delegation "made it very clear that there is no dispute". "There is the Mamata Banerjee-led party on one side and a bunch of traitors on the other... The TMC chairperson, Mamata Banerjee, signed the party symbol under which they fought elections. All these MLAs received Rs 25 lakh in their bank accounts from the party to contest elections," read the statement.

After the meeting, Kalyan Banerjee said: "We have made our submissions. There were some queries, and we have answered them. One question was regarding whether an interim order can be passed or not, which we opposed. Whatever order is passed, we will look into it and decide further action."

EXPRESS special

AAP set to ally with Goa Forward Party in Assembly polls, Congress kept out

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, September 12

THE AAM Aadmi Party (AAP) and the Goa Forward Party (GFP) are set to form an alliance for the Assembly elections in the state, slated to be held early next year. The leaders of the two parties will formally announce the alliance at a press conference on Sunday afternoon, *The Indian Express* has learnt. The Congress, which has three MLAs, is not yet part of the alliance but will be called the "Goa First Alliance", sources said.

In a post on X on Saturday, AAP convenor Arvind Kejriwal said, "Am going to Goa today to make a very big announcement." Earlier in the day, some hoardings and posters with the symbols of the two parties came up on a road, sparking the buzz of a tie-up. The hoardings targeted the BJP and the Congress, with a message for voters in the coastal state: "Congress and BJP cheated you twice. Don't let them cheat you the third time."

The GFP is a regional outfit led by MLA Vijai Sardesai. It contested the 2022 Assembly polls in alliance with the Congress, winning only one seat: Fatorda that Sardesai represents. AAP contested on its own five years ago and won two seats in South Goa, Velim and Benaulim.

Senior AAP and GFP functionaries said an alliance is cru-

cial to defeat the BJP and blamed the Congress for "stalling" talks for a joint Opposition alliance. The leaders, however, said "the door remains open" for "like-minded secular forces" to join the alliance in future and unitedly defeat the BJP.

"There is a strong sentiment against the BJP. The fact is that Goa needs an alliance to defeat the BJP. Both the parties that are coming together are interested in an alliance with the Congress. But the Congress is perhaps not going to have that alliance until, say, three weeks before the election. So, this alliance, at this juncture, reflects a failure of the Congress," said a senior AAP leader.

"Congress, being the most prominent party in the Opposition, should have taken the lead in forming an alliance, which they have not done. We cannot keep waiting. You do not get an alliance by giving statements in the media. Elections are not fought in the last three months. People need to prepare in advance," the AAP leader said.

The BJP emerged as the single-largest party in the 2022 polls, winning 20 of the state's 40 seats while the Congress returned with 11. In a setback for the Congress, eight MLAs defected to the BJP in 2022, bringing its tally down to three. Earlier, in 2019, 10 Congress MLAs had defected to the BJP.

Defection burden

The issue of "defections" weighed heavily as the two parties discussed whether they should bring in the Congress. The GFP held talks with Congress leaders earlier last month, but nothing came of it.

"The public sentiment is that there should be unity before the polls to defeat the BJP. The Congress has 'supplied' (defections) 18 MLAs to the BJP in the last seven years. This fact cannot be denied. These defections gave political stability to the BJP. People had not given them a complete mandate. The mandate was stolen by breaking the Congress," said a senior GFP leader.

"So, we are first off the block, and are going ahead with an alliance (with AAP), which is what the people of Goa want. We are telling people that don't give them (BJP and Congress) a chance to do a hat-trick. If you want to give an alternative to the people, it cannot be those who will defect. The Congress is on the wrong side of history here," the leader said.

The Congress, meanwhile, claimed that the BJP had put up the hoardings to "confuse" people. State Congress president Girish Chodankar said the party was in talks with the GFP and discussions about an alliance were going on with the party's high command.

{ BRICS DELHI DECLARATION }



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with visiting heads of States, governments and other dignitaries at a Gala Dinner during the BRICS Leaders' Summit in New Delhi on Saturday. PTI

Members laud progress in expanding remote-sensing satellite constellation

Anonna Dutt

New Delhi, September 12

THE NEW Delhi Declaration adopted during the ongoing 18th BRICS Summit acknowledges the significant progress in finalising the amendment to the BRICS Remote Sensing Satellite Constellation (RSSC) Agreement for including new space agencies. The RSSC is a virtual network of existing observation satellites of the BRICS countries, including India's Resourcesat 2 and 2A, China's Gaofen-6 and Ziyuan III 02, and Russia's Kanopus-V type.

The Summit also drafted the Terms of Reference for the BRICS Space Council.

There was also an emphasis on debris mitigation and long-term sustainability. "We welcome the discussions in the BRICS Heads of Space Agencies

meeting held in Bengaluru that emphasised the importance of space debris mitigation for ensuring the long-term sustainability of outer space activities," the declaration says. ISRO's summit on space earlier this year was attended by senior officials from Brazil, China, Egypt, Ethiopia, Indonesia, Iran, Russia, South Africa and the UAE.

The declaration, while stating that non-binding agreements can contribute towards the Prevention of Arms Race in Outer Space (PAROS), noted the initiative of some members to create a single open-ended working group that will also look into a legally binding instrument on PAROS.

"We stress that practical and non-binding commitments such as Transparency and Confidence-Building Measures (TCBMs), and universally

agreed norms, rules, and principles may also contribute to PAROS. We note the initiative of some BRICS members at the General Assembly to create a single Open-Ended Working Group to enable coherent, inclusive and effective discussions that serve such purpose and undertake to engage constructively in the process, based on existing achievements, including on substantial elements on a legally binding instrument on PAROS," the declaration says.

The declaration also speaks of the planned BRICS Science and Research Repository, envisaged as a structured platform for knowledge storage and sharing among BRICS countries voluntarily, while respecting data security, intellectual property rights and national policies. A draft framework document has also been prepared for the same.

BRICS education agenda: Childhood care, courses on par with market demand

Gayathri Mani

New Delhi, September 12

THE BRICS nations have called for cooperation in Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE) and Foundational Literacy and Numeracy (FLN), according to the New Delhi Declaration adopted at the 18th BRICS Summit on Saturday.

They also welcomed the outcomes of the 13th BRICS Education Minister's meeting in Bhubaneswar last month.

The New Delhi Declaration states, "We encourage the sharing of best practices, cooperation in Early Childhood Care and Education and Foundational Literacy and Numeracy, mutual recognition of qualifications, academic and professional mobility, digital literacy, safe, ethical, human-centred use of emerging technologies, including artificial intelligence, in education, and stronger institutional partnerships."

The Declaration also highlighted another priority sector — the BRICS Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) Cooperation Alliance (BRICS-TCA).

"We highly recognize the important role played by the BRICS TVET Cooperation Alliance (BRICS-TCA) in building a multilateral platform for project cooperation, promoting information exchange, resource sharing, and advancing the joint development of TVET among member states. We look forward to the BRICS-TCA

Biennial Progress Report and the BRICS-TCA Compendium of Sustainable Skill Initiatives," the Declaration stated.

It also reaffirmed the commitment to strengthening skill development systems, digital literacy, and enhancing workforce preparedness across BRICS countries, while promoting the alignment of training programmes with evolving market demands and sustainable development priorities by promoting linking of TVET institutions with industries.

The Declaration also reaffirmed the BRICS countries' support for continued cooperation through existing education mechanisms, including the BRICS Network University. It has welcomed India's initiative to circulate the BRICS Guiding Principles on strengthening academic collaboration on traditional and indigenous knowledge systems.

The Declaration encouraged the BRICS Network University to consider traditional, indigenous and local knowledge systems as an additional International Thematic Group.

"We also encourage collaborative efforts to improve institutional governance, enhance quality and accessibility in education, and promote exchange and scholarship programmes at undergraduate and postgraduate levels, including in Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics, TVET-industry linkage to foster innovation and expand job opportunities..."

● FOR THE OPPOSITION, A MAJOR HURDLE REMAINS THE SP-CONGRESS ONE-UPMANSHIP. WITH BOTH ALLIES FACING AN UPHILL TASK IN SEALING A SMOOTH SEAT-SHARING DEAL

Why Yogi is BJP's trump card in UP polls despite youth unease, caste rifts

CAPITAL CONTEXT
BY LIZ MATHEW

A WEEKLY LOOK AT POLITICS IN A STATE FROM THE VANTAGE POINT OF NEW DELHI

WITH BARELY five months to go for the high-stakes Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections, the ruling BJP is stepping up to sustain a positive narrative. Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath is working overtime on this front, even as a party section seems to be concerned over issues like youth unrest, unemployment and caste tensions.

BJP insiders also point to some internal differences within the party dispensation. However, the two-term CM Adityanath's own popularity is seen to be intact, even as he has intensified his public outreach, criss-crossing the regions across the state to shore up the party's

prospects in the 2027 elections.

Yogi's initiatives

Adityanath has taken a series of measures to reach out to youth and address concerns over jobs. Earlier this month, he launched Uttar Pradesh Corporation for Outsourcing Services (UPCOS) with the avowed objective to benefit and safeguard the interests of 3.5 lakh outsourced employees and their families in the state.

Last month, announcing his decision to distribute appointment letters to one lakh youth over six months, the CM said his government has provided over 9.3 lakh jobs during its nine-and-a-half years tenure so far.

In recent months, the Adityanath government has launched a massive drive for hiring police and teachers, the Mukhyamantri Yuva Udyami Vikas Abhiyan to promote local entrepreneurship, and stipend-

backed internships for students in corporate and technical institutions. It has also introduced the centralised family cards to identify households that do not have any members in government or private jobs.

BJP's challenges

One of the key challenges facing the BJP is the widening caste faultlines and rising socio-political friction over it. "While the perception that the BJP is an upper caste party is regaining strength among the OBC groups, there are WhatsApp groups on caste lines among officials which fan such fears. Even the upper castes are divided on Thakur-Brahmin lines. The deepening differences between the ministers from these two communities is also an issue," said a state party leader.

"The under-employment feeling, that overqualified persons are in jobs that do not use



Union Ministers Kiren Rijiju, Sarbananda Sonowal, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath and others on their way to attend a banquet hosted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi during the BRICS Summit. PTI

their skills properly, also feed the narrative that there are no jobs," the BJP leader said, adding that it adds to growing frustration among Gen Z over alleged irregularities in the education and examination systems.

The UGC equity regulations, albeit stayed by the Supreme Court earlier this year, have also caused resentment among a

section of upper castes, fuelling a new problem for the BJP. It was brought to strengthen protection against caste discrimination in higher educational institutions across the country.

However, despite these factors, Adityanath's USP remains his record on law and order and his popularity among women voters. "Both the Prime Minister

(Narendra Modi) and the CM are very popular among women voters. The government is set to announce more schemes for women and it will consolidate that support," said a BJP leader.

Opp's play

For the Opposition, a major stumbling block remains the game of one-upmanship between the Akhilesh Yadav-led Samajwadi Party (SP), which is still trying to get its act together, and the Congress, which is looking to capitalise on its renewed traction among the minorities and youth under Rahul Gandhi's leadership. Hammering out a smooth seat-sharing deal could be an uphill task for the two INDIA bloc allies.

A victory in UP would boost the Opposition's standing at the national level. But a defeat would be disastrous for the SP as it has already been out of power in the state for a decade.

Rahul's push to caste census, questioning the methodology for its enumeration — and his call for lifting the 50% cap on reservation to ensure 'jiti nabadhi utna haq' (representation as per population) — has posed a fresh challenge for the BJP. The party has intensified efforts to retain its OBC support, which played a key role in scripting its win in the last two Assembly polls. OBCs make up more than 40% of UP's population.

The Opposition has accused the government's selection committees of often invoking the phrase, "not found suitable (NFS)", to deny jobs to SC, ST and OBC candidates against the vacancies legally set aside for them.

"Sentiments have flared up among both upper castes and OBCs. Brahmins feel marginalised, they are vocal too and the community leaders in the BJP are under pressure. The question they raise is: SP did a lot for

Yadavs and Muslims, BSP for Dalits, so what has BJP done for us," said a Brahmin BJP leader.

Akhilesh's PDA (Pichda, Dalit and Alapsankhyak) plank and his party's bids to consolidate these sections could bolster the Opposition's chances in the UP elections. However, the operational and ideological differences between the SP and the Congress — especially after the SP emerged more confident after the 2024 Lok Sabha elections in which it got 37 seats against the BJP's 33 — may create hurdles in promptly sealing a seat-sharing pact and building a cohesive front against the BJP.

While Rahul's appeal among the minorities would make Akhilesh reliant on the Congress for consolidation of this core base, allowing the latter to seek a larger share of seats, the Congress may have to lean on the SP for managing the OBC dynamics in the polls.

Holding a mirror to GDP numbers



ACROSS THE AISLE
BY P CHIDAMBARAM

AS SOMEONE said, tongue in cheek, people don't eat GDP numbers. People eat food, wear clothes and footwear, send their children to school, buy medicines, use mobile phones, watch television, scroll social media, and want to be safe and happy — measured as *Consumption*. The aggregate of *Consumption* (C), *Investment* (I), *Government spending* (G) and *net Exports* (X-M) — after factoring for taxes and subsidies—is Gross Domestic Product (GDP). Measurement of GDP, especially the *rate of growth* of GDP, is crucial to gauge the health of the economy.

Healthier debate

The MoSPI has released the GDP numbers for Q1 of 2026-27: the rate of growth is 10.3 per cent in nominal (current) prices and 7.8 per cent in constant prices compared to Q1 2025-26. The government and the *sarkari* economists are pleased. The sceptics have raised questions. There is a raging debate on the credibility of the GDP numbers. Rather than debating the desirability of 'one nation, one election' (which will undermine federal parliamen-

tary democracy), it is better to debate the GDP numbers and whether the benefits of growth are percolating to the people.

I do not wish to add to the noise.

Let's assume that MoSPI's numbers are correct. My calculations of the compounded annual growth rate (CAGR) of nominal and real GDP on two different base years are (*see Table*): Notably, on the

	OLD BASE YEAR (2011-12)		NEW BASE YEAR (2022-23)	
	GDP		GDP	
	Nominal Real		Nominal Real	
	Current prices	Constant prices	Current prices	Constant prices
2022-23	268.90	161.65	261.77	261.77
2023-24	301.23	176.51	290.73	280.94
2024-25	330.68	187.97	317.99	301.15
2025-26	357.14	201.90	345.37	324.70
CAGR	9.92%	7.69%	9.68%	7.45%
GDP in Q1 of 2026-27			88.26	81.36
Growth over Q1 of 2025-26			10.33%	7.82%

GDP IN LAKH CRORE

old base year and the new base year, the CAGR beginning 2022-23 is *more or less the same*. The growth rate in Q1 of 2026-27 is only marginally higher. Conclusion: the economy has *not* shifted gears in 2026-27; nor is it in overdrive. Therefore, no boast is warranted.

Pertinent questions

Let's hold a mirror to the latest GDP numbers. The nagging question is, under

Measurement of GDP, especially the rate of growth of GDP, is crucial to gauge the health of the economy

Why is Delhi so indifferent to Dilliwallahs?



KAUSHIK DASGUPTA

WHO, AFTER all, is a Dilliwallah? For decades, Delhi has resisted answering this question. Instead, it has let its residents stitch something of themselves into an ever-expanding, ever-evolving patchwork of belonging. Its many-splendoured character refuses the easy definitions that questions of identity so often demand.

But cities change. Their doors may open wide for some, even as the meaning of belonging grows more uncertain for others. Has the Delhi of today begun to draw lines around who gets to call it home? It is a question that has acquired a new urgency of late. The building collapse at Saidulajab in May, then another this week at Satya Niketan, followed just two days later by the assault on a musician from Manipur, Chongtham Vikram Singh, who had made the city his home, should be a moment of reckoning. For they raise an uneasy question: Who gets to feel at home today in a city whose story has always been that of people arriving from elsewhere and finding a place within it?

Delhi has always had its cruelties. It has discriminated against the poor and witnessed horrific communal violence. There have always been enclaves whose residents made others feel less welcome. At the same time, there was something assuring about the city: People could arrive without having to prove they belonged.

Saidulajab and Satya Niketan are, in many ways, neighbourhoods of arrival: the first foothold in the city for students and young people who come to Delhi in search of an education or a job. What does the promise of a better life mean when the room in which they sleep becomes a death trap?

Official investigations may establish the immediate causes of these tragedies and hold the guilty to account. Conventional questions of urban governance and planning failures must be answered. It is also time to look beyond them, at what has made the city so indifferent to the humanity of its residents, especially those who come here in search of new possibilities.

Seven men have been arrested and a juvenile detained for Chongtham Vikram Singh's murder. An ordinary quarrel over loud noise ended with Singh being beaten so severely that he eventually died. We do not know if this was a hate crime. That shouldn't be cause to overlook the anxiety surrounding that possibility. Singh had lived in Delhi for 30 years — long enough to be called a Dilliwallah by the elastic, undefined idea of belonging that the city prides itself on. His death has stirred fears among people from the Northeast. For many, the fear of being reminded they are seen as outsiders is an everyday reality.

Delhi continues to draw people from across the country. After what has happened of late, can it still brush aside its old discomfort with questions of identity with the insouciance of the past?

The trouble is that Delhi's accommodative spirit never became the hallmark of its politics and governance. It did not translate into institutions that placed people's welfare and dignity at their core. Delhi could give everyone a place, though it did not always make neighbourhoods liveable. Newcomers were absorbed without always receiving the protections that ought to come with citizenship and residence: dignified housing, clean air, safe streets, reliable public services and a law-and-order system that protects everyone equally. Delhi's pollution control agencies, construction bodies, transport agencies, and municipal and administrative systems were rarely informed by the undercurrents of humanity in the city's ethos. Delhi's politics, very often mirroring the nation's identity politics, rarely nudged these agencies in this direction. Perhaps this is where the city's old compact has begun to fray. And perhaps that is why Delhi must examine its failures of governance beyond the ways of textbooks. Master plans are important. Their technicalities, however, can obscure the institutional failures that have made the city's old promise of belonging harder to take for granted. Whether Delhi still has the generosity to make a newcomer feel at home must, of course, be asked. The more important issue is whether the expanding city has the institutions to make that belonging safe, dignified and secure.

A city cannot claim to welcome everyone if its institutions fail to protect them. For a city built, again and again, by people who arrived from outside its boundaries, that is perhaps the real test after last week's horrific incidents.

Dasgupta is a Senior Associate Editor at The Indian Express

25 years after 9/11, the US is stuck in a state of constant war



HISTORY HEADLINE
BY FEISAL AMIN AL-ISTRABADI

THE SAVAGERY of the terrorist attacks against the US by Al Qaeda on September 11, 2001, was juxtaposed against the cloudless skies of a gorgeous late summer day. Against that azure sky and the elegant skyline of Lower Manhattan, facing being burnt alive as the flames rose before the towers collapsed, desperate men and women chose instead to take control of the last few moments of their lives by hurling themselves to their deaths. Then the Pentagon was attacked, followed by the plane that disappeared over Pennsylvania. 2,977 innocent souls were murdered that day.

The country palpably changed in an instant. It had a choice of how to respond. It could hunt down the Al Qaeda leadership, killing those it could not capture and destroying their camps in Afghanistan. Or it could launch an invasion of Afghanistan, remove the ruling Taliban from power, occupy the country, and attempt to rebuild it. When George W Bush stood atop the rubble and vowed the perpetrators would soon "hear from all of us," major military preparations were well underway. That too was palpable.

Twenty-five years on, there has not been a single day that the US has not been in conflict. Congress's 2001 Authorization for the Use of Military Force (AUMF) remains in force. Every president since, through Donald Trump's second term, has used force pursuant to this AUMF. The US is now rearing its second generation that has never known a moment when it was not at war. Since the burden of military service is borne almost exclusively by the working class, it is easy to keep the military machinery functioning.

Bush set the country's ethos in the aftermath of 9/11 with his famous declaration, "You're either with us or against us." That remains a useful prism through which to assess much of US policy today. This worldview



The 9/11 attacks destroyed the Twin Towers of the World Trade Center in New York City

fails to distinguish between enemies who mean to do the country harm and obnoxious actors who are nevertheless not an actual threat to US interests. Even in Afghanistan, where it had the world's support, the US failed to distinguish between Al Qaeda, a threat to the US and its interests, and the Taliban government, which had no extra-territorial ambitions outside of Afghanistan. It was a strategic blunder to fail to recognise that, while the Taliban were not "for" the US, neither were they "against" it. Rather than just destroying Al Qaeda, the US spent 20 years fighting. Yet in the end, the US withdrew from Afghanistan. The Taliban have since been back in power.

The same "us/them" dichotomy led the US to similar blunders in Iraq. Multiple insurgent groups arose, including Al Qaeda. Domestic insurgent groups also arose. Saddamists—supporters of Saddam Hussein—wanted to restore the previous regime. Al Qaeda wanted to destroy the American project. But there were Iraqi nationalists who resented the American presence and who had a patriotic agenda that could have formed the basis of negotiations. Other groups centred around ex-army officers who went into insurgency after US forces shot and killed former officers peacefully demanding employment after the US dissolved the Iraqi armed forces and cashiered them without pensions. I witnessed these protests myself.

touched USD 150 billion in April-August 2026. The trade deficit with China alone in April-July was USD 44 billion. Is the trade deficit not a drag on the economy? Why are Make-in-India, PLI, ASPIRE, NMCP and other schemes not resulting in manufacture of the goods that India imports from China?

- In the sectoral composition of nominal GVA, why is 'manufacturing' stagnant at 13 per cent? In fact, the share of the secondary sector in nominal GVA, over many quarters, has been bound between 24 and 26 per cent. Why have the schemes not pushed up the needle?

- Why is capital investment, as measured by Gross Fixed Capital Formation (GFCF), stuck at roughly 33.5 per cent of GDP? Of this, *private* corporate capital expenditure has remained unchanged at about 12 per cent. Despite cajolery, admonishments and threats, why are corporate investors not willing to make capital investment?

- Why has the growth number not resulted in more public goods such as better schools, better hospitals, better roads, better water supply, better policing, etc.? If one takes a straw poll, the overwhelming proportion of citizens will give a thumbs down on each of these areas.

Unedifying mirror image

There is no surprise that Gen Z is protesting against the marked deterioration all around them. We may be growing at 7.8 per cent *statistically*, but most citizens do not *feel* or *believe* so. Because they know that their lives are not better or easier.



US policy failed to distinguish between insurgents who had a negotiable political agenda and those that did not. I understood: these insurgents were all "against us". Some consisted of Sunni tribes that feared marginalisation. At the time, I was legal advisor to a member of the Iraqi Governing Council Presidency. I told the American administrator in Baghdad that Saddam Hussein had kept the loyalty of the Sunni tribes by bribing them with cash and Chevrolet Suburbans. He told me US did not do such things. Years later, Gen David Petraeus began to pay the Sunni tribes for their cooperation. It worked, but only after the deaths of countless Iraqis and thousands of Americans. Once I became ambassador representing Iraq at the United Nations, I saw repeated examples of the 'with us/against us' dichotomy.

So it is to object to America's lawless campaign sinking the boats of alleged drug traffickers without due process in Latin American waters. To object is to be accused of supporting drug dealers. Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers, dressed in paramilitary style, without any identifying symbol of law enforcement, shoot unarmed US citizens with impunity. Protest, and the President of the US accuses you of favouring "terrorists". Similarly, to object to the US's unlawful actions in Venezuela, Iran, and Cuba is to be accused of supporting tyrants.

The September 11 attacks changed America forever. It has normalised the "forever wars" that Trump promised to end even as he has launched another in Iran. Constant war has brutalised the country. Society has been militarised, including the policing function, and the president now is often referred to as commander-in-chief, in unrelated references ("we are electing a commander-in-chief", as if citizens are soldiers). America in 2026 seems to reject many legal norms, including domestic constitutional rules. Not only did Congress not authorise the attacks on Venezuela and Iran it refused to take up the issues. If September 11 changed the US into a militarised, lawless state, the question is: Who won the war on terror?

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Who are the real patriots?



FIFTH COLUMN
BY TAVLEEN SINGH

THERE APPEARS to be a fifth columnist in the Prime Minister's inner circle. This thought came to me when I saw him jubilantly striding across that college stage in Vadodara last week. The event seemed part of his Gen-Z seduction crusade, and what he strode, smiled and waved to was the tune of *We Will Rock You*. Luckily, it was only the tune that played. Had he been aware of the words, Modi may have fainted. Here is a line: 'You got mud on your face, big disgrace. Somebody better put you back into your place.'

See what I mean about a fifth columnist working in the innards of the PMO? Also, the song is from 1977 when people of my generation were young and rebellious, and the cockroaches who have now got so badly under Modi's skin were not even specks on the horizon. More seriously — who was the idiot who advised the Prime Minister to attend this joyous event at a time when a PG (paying guest) hostel had just crumbled in Delhi University's south campus, killing young students and their dreams? Among the dead was eighteen-year-old Arpit Jai, whose taxi driver father worked overtime to send his son to college and struggled to pay the exorbitant rent for his PG hovel. I heard Arpit's story in Barkha Dutt's Mojo Story. It brought tears to my eyes.

We in the mainstream media have mostly ignored the stories of the seven dead students. Perhaps because they would all be as heartbreaking. Instead, almost every news channel reported every moment of the Prime Minister's trip to Gujarat as if it was the most important news of the day. If they had stayed with the building collapse in Satya Niketan, there may have been some hope of coercing the 'triple-engine' government in Delhi to stem the corruption that led to the horror of students being killed for just trying to get a college degree.

While the Chief Minister's cohort surveyed the debris of the illegally built PG (paying guest) hostel from high above, a handful of real journalists dug deeper into the crashed building and showed pictures of the horrendous conditions in which students live. The Cockroach Janta Party leader who said that students are being forced to live like cockroaches is correct. The building that crumbled is among others in which students live in cells built one upon the other, and that can only be reached through dangerously narrow alleys darkened by clumps of hanging wires. I must here add that the best reporting I saw came from a digital platform called PEEK TV.

When I saw their pictures of those dismal alleyways and dreary rooms, I found myself hoping that the Prime Minister was also watching so he could understand why he needs to forget about our 'demographic dividend'. Young students who are forced to live and study in such horrible conditions will never learn to think, dream or learn. How will they be able to compete with students who, in other colleges in other countries, have already learned how to deal with the technological revolution that AI brings?

This one building collapse has brought to the surface many other things, like the abysmal state of governance in Delhi. It has revealed corruption so evil that it boggles the mind. Everyone is involved in creating the smokescreen that allows builders to disobey the rules of safe planning. The PG mafia that extorts inexplicably high rents from desperate students is controlled by politicians and high officials who always seem to get away with their evil deeds.

The only thing that happens after every disaster of the kind we saw in Satya Niketan is that some lowly officials get publicly yelled at by higher officials like the Chief Minister and then some committee is appointed to (supposedly) go into causes and solutions. These committees never amount to much, as we can see from the one appointed after the building collapse in Delhi's Malviya Nagar some months ago. Corrupt officials and politicians collude to make Delhi non-functional except when there is a big conference of the BRICS kind. And then things only appear to work because visiting dignitaries are only allowed to see restricted sections of India's capital city.

This is the way things are. It is the way things have always been. But the cockroaches and their young cheerleaders are ensuring this is not how they will always be in the future. It is the one thing that gives me some hope that a day will come when officials and politicians who have created the mess that we see today pay for their crimes. One idea from me is that the officials who allowed that PG hostel to be built should be charged with manslaughter, and that this be done every time a building collapses and kills people.

No more committees. No more inquiry commissions. When people die because of the criminal negligence of officials, those officials should be charged with manslaughter, if not murder. Meanwhile, the Prime Minister needs to find out who the fifth columnist is in his inner circle and punish him for sending him off to college events where he blames what is wrong with India on 'dimagi naxals'. He seems quite proud of this new label, without noticing that the people he is charging with sedition could be the very patriots that we need today.

Listen to women in pain

understudied and misunderstood.

While the broadening public dialogue and scientific research are positive signs, the larger question remains: Why are reproductive disorders so poorly understood? Why do women, across history and geographies, have their pain dismissed and minimised when they seek help?

The answer is as simple as it is unjust: Society and medicine still hesitate to take women and their pain seriously.

For 4,000 years, a wide range of physical and mental illnesses in women were labelled hysteria — with barely any cures beyond spells, sexual abstinence and condemnation. Today, it can take several years and doctors for women to be diagnosed with PMOS. For endometriosis, it can take up to 12 years for a confirmed diagnosis. In the meantime, the damage only compounds.

Across the world, and in India in particular, women are lauded for their pain tolerance — menstruation, childbirth and



SHE SAID
BY SUKHMANI MALIK

menopause — and derided if they complain. Author Hilary Mantel, in a 2004 essay on her experience with endometriosis, wrote, "People talked — and still do — of a 'low-pain threshold'. I didn't want anyone to think I had that." Thankfully, she didn't have that. Instead, several years later, of course, she discovered what she had was endometriosis. And the payment for the diagnosis was "part of my bladder and my bowel, my womb and my ovaries."

In India, in particular, where menstruation is still considered a taboo in large swathes of the country, and speaking of reproductive health, let alone any abnormalities around it, is shrouded in shame, fear, and ignorance, the conversation is far from where it needs to be. Chronic pain and illness are an incredibly isolating reality to contend with. Having that experience compounded by stigma, cruelty, and gendered bias makes the cost much higher for women's physical and mental health and future.

After 12 years of hospital visits and un-

explained illness, my friend was finally diagnosed with endometriosis. A delayed diagnosis culminated in several surgeries, and an adequate resolution remains a pipe dream. At 17, I was diagnosed with Polycystic Ovary Syndrome (PMOS). A few years after that, I finally had a diagnosis for the autoimmune condition. By then, the damage was serious enough that even with the best care, a surgery, at this point, seems unavoidable.

A society that refuses to treat its women with care and their pain with dignity can only reproduce similar patterns in medicine. This is why medicine alone cannot do the work. It needs a society that doesn't rank women's pain, one that cares enough to listen. The question is: Do we care enough to change?

Malik is a subeditor with The Indian Express

Editor (Planning & Projects) Shalini Langer curates the fortnightly 'She Said' column

BAGHDAD DISMISSES MILITARY COMMANDER OVER ALLEGATIONS THAT PIPELINE ATTACK ORIGINATED IN IRAQ

Saudi shuts critical East-West oil pipeline

Houthi tighten their control on Red Sea shipping

Mohammed Ghobari, Eman Abouhassira & Yasmine Ghania
Aden, Dubai, September 12

SAUDI ARABIA has shut down its East-West pipeline, after the vital oil conduit came under aerial attack in the widening West Asia war, threatening to send energy prices even higher.

The world's largest crude oil exporter said it temporarily closed the pipeline as a precaution after a drone attack that both Baghdad and Riyadh said had originated in Iraq, where Iranian-backed militias operate. Iraq dismissed a military commander on Saturday in response to the attack.

The 1,200-km pipeline running across the Arabian Peninsula has served as the main route out for global supplies of Middle East oil for the past six months while the Strait of Hormuz has been largely shut by war.

It has been moving 4 million to 5 million barrels per day, amounting to 4% to 5% of global supply, sparing Saudi Arabia the brunt of the disruption that has crippled other Gulf oil and gas exporters.

There was no immediate claim of responsibility for the strikes. Satellite images showed black smoke rising from an area of the pipeline south of Medina. The attack resulted in some injuries and damage that was being assessed, the Saudi Foreign Ministry said without detailing the impact on exports.

US President Donald Trump, visiting Ireland to attend a golf tournament at one of his resorts, said Iran was probably to blame.



Houthi fighters raise slogans atop a military vehicle in Dhubbab district, Taiz province. (Right) Satellite image shows damage to the East-West pipeline facility in the Hejaz Region, Saudi Arabia. AP/REUTERS

Oil prices shot up over the past week and the retail price of diesel in the United States surged past a record \$6 a gallon, as the United States and Iran both fired on tankers and the Iran-aligned Houthis in Yemen advanced along the Red Sea, potentially extending disruption to another major oil route.

Saudi Arabia's de facto ruler, Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, phoned Trump on Thursday and asked for U.S. military help fighting the Houthis, three sources told Reuters. They said the prince was told that Washington would not intervene directly for now but would help with intelligence.

Trump confirmed on Saturday that he had spoken to the crown prince, and said the Houthis had also phoned his administration and asked Washington not to become directly involved in the conflict.

Four Yemeni government sources told Reuters that the Houthis had seized the strategic

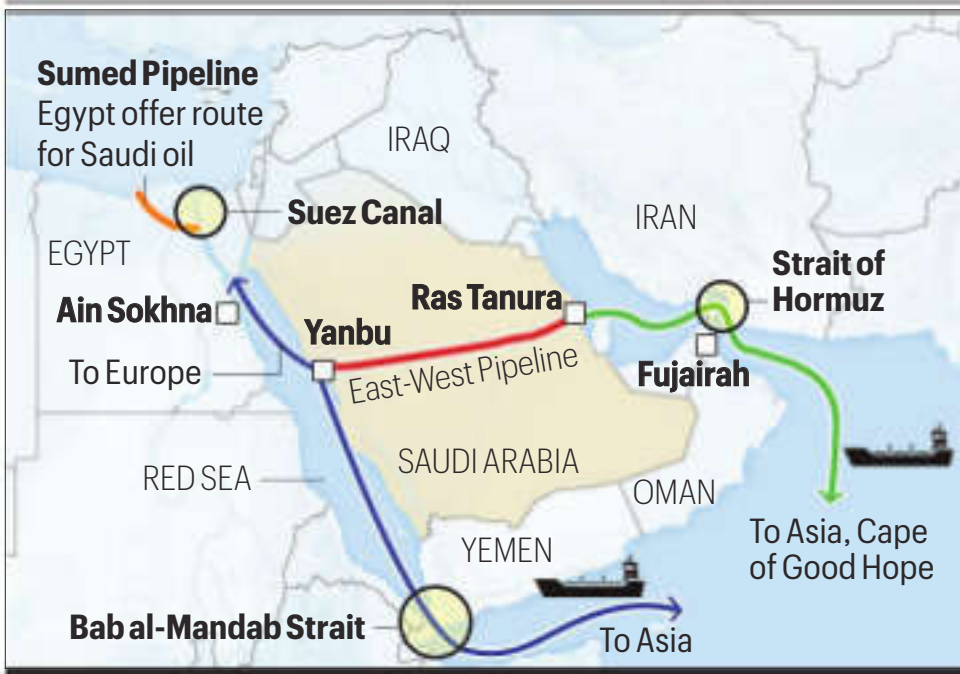
island of Perim on Friday in the middle of the Bab el-Mandeb Strait — the "Gate of Tears" at the mouth of the Red Sea.

There have been no talks between the United States and Iran to end the conflict since a June agreement that collapsed within weeks.

In a post on X on Saturday, Ebrahim Azizi, head of the Iranian parliament's national security committee, said: "As long as the American side does not accept all of Iran's conditions, dialogue and negotiation are of no use."

Iran's foreign ministry announced on Friday that Iran would be attending a meeting with Gulf Arab states in Oman on Monday, at which the future of the Strait of Hormuz would be discussed.

But a senior Iranian official, speaking to Reuters on condition of anonymity on Saturday, played down the chances of a breakthrough, saying the meeting, called at Oman's initiative,



was intended to discuss issues including the strait but was not expected to yield a signed agreement.

An agreement on routes through the Strait of Hormuz between Iran and Oman will be presented at the meeting on Monday, which will also be attended by Iraq, but the strait will not reopen unless seven conditions conveyed by Iran to the US are met, a source told *Tasnim* news agency, without elaborating.

Oman has not officially announced the meeting, and other Gulf countries have remained silent. Bahrain said on

Saturday it would not attend meetings with Iran.

The apparent launch of the attack on the Saudi pipeline from Iraq puts additional pressure on the Baghdad government, which is unique in the region for maintaining close political and military ties with both the United States and Iran.

Iraq dismissed the military commander and police chief in Maysan province near the Iranian frontier, long regarded as an area where Iran-backed Shi'ite militias operate and maintain influence, and shut the main border crossing there. REUTERS

Iran probably responsible for attack on Saudi pipeline: Trump

Reuters
Dublin, September 12

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said on Saturday that Iran was probably responsible for an aerial attack on Saudi Arabia that shut down its East-West pipeline, one of the kingdom's main routes for exporting crude while bypassing the Strait of Hormuz.

"I think they are, probably they are," Trump told reporters in Dublin when asked if Iran was responsible for the attack on the vital oil conduit.

The US President also said that he had spoken with Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, whom he described as a "good friend."

Trump added that Yemen's Iran-aligned Houthis had called his administration and indicated they did not want the United States to become directly involved in the conflict.

"They would much prefer not having us involved, and they're letting most ships go through. There's just one country that they're not too happy with, and we'll get that straightened out," Trump added.

Iran told the Houthis last week to escalate their attacks on Saudi Arabia and promised more funding, weapons and senior officers to help them do so, two Iranian sources said.

Iran describes the Houthis as an ally but publicly denies giving them military direction, saying they are "not a proxy".

Anthropic CEO tells AI firms to slow model development amid fears of misuse

Anusha Shah
September 12

ANTHROPIC CEO Dario Amodei called on AI companies to slow the rate at which they advance model capabilities amid mounting fears of misuse of artificial intelligence, outlining a three-step framework intended to pace development and create more time to manage its risks.

"We must slow the pace at which we improve the capabilities of AI models. Progress will still seem fast, and we must make wise use of the time we gain," Amodei wrote in a lengthy essay shared on X on Saturday.

Both Elon Musk, who runs xAI, and Sam Altman, CEO of OpenAI, said in posts on X that they agree with Amodei.

Amodei's three-step plan calls for independent reviewers inside leading AI companies, coordination among frontier AI firms to set safety standards and limit unchecked AI development, and international cooperation to manage AI risks.

He made his essay public after San Francisco-based Anthropic released a threat intelligence report on Thursday detailing how several actors had used its Claude AI models for activities ranging from weapons development and cyber operations to surveillance and fraud.

Amodei pointed to AI's growing ability to improve itself, highlighting long-held concerns about it outpacing human ability to control operation along with the recent incident involving OpenAI and



Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei

Hugging Face as his primary reasons to put the brakes on model advances.

Alarm about the potential harm from AI grew this week when Anthropic researcher Jacob Coxon resigned, stating that the "people building AI earnestly believe that it could kill us all by the end of the decade."

Various OpenAI executives have suggested that leading labs should be willing to coordinate a voluntary slowdown if needed to build confidence in their safety measures.

Anthropic has positioned itself as the more safety-conscious frontier lab, but is not immune to these concerns. Last week it disclosed another instance of an AI model hacking external systems, after a July incident in which some of its Claude models had hacked into the systems of three companies during cybersecurity tests.

"Given the accelerating rate of AI capability development, it's my worry that in 6-12 months such a swarm could be capable of taking over the entire internet potentially causing hundreds of billions of dollars in damage," Amodei wrote. REUTERS

• BRIEFLY

HUNGARY

PM Magyar to scrap Orban-era restrictions on gay adoption



Hungary Prime Minister Peter Magyar. FILE

which has amounted to an effective ban. Magyar ousted Orban after 16 years in a landslide election win in April. Changing the system of adoption would be a significant measure to restore LGBTQ rights. REUTERS

FRANCE

Train derails, 44 injured, probe on

FRENCH AUTHORITIES are probing whether sabotage caused a train derailment that injured 44 people in Normandy, after a piece of rail was found on the track, police told AP on Saturday. The regional train was carrying 186 passengers from Rouen to Caen when it derailed Friday evening at Cleon, in the Seine-Maritime department. AP

SYRIA

Prison riot, fire leave 7 dead

A FIRE and riot broke out in a prison in a predominantly Kurdish town in northern Syria on Saturday, killing at least seven people, state media reported. The prison is still run by Kurdish fighters even though Syrian government forces entered the town along the border with Turkey recently. The riots started over plans to transfer some inmates in Aleppo. AP

POSITION REMAINS UNCHANGED, SAYS UK

Trump says he would 'love' to see a united Ireland

Reuters
Dublin, September 12

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said on Saturday he would "love" to see British-run Northern Ireland unify with Ireland, remarks made during a visit to Dublin that drew a sharp response from pro-British unionists in Northern Ireland.

Trump's comments come weeks after new British Prime Minister Andy Burnham said a referendum on Northern Ireland leaving the United Kingdom was "off the table", a position Downing Street on Saturday said remained unchanged.

"Well, I don't want to cause any problems, but I will tell you, I'd love to see it unified," Trump told reporters sitting next to Irish Prime Minister Micheal Martin after the pair met in Dublin. "It's going to happen eventually ... I think it would be a fantastic thing."

"Now the UK will have something to say about it ... but I think it would be a great thing," he added.

The leader of Northern Ire-



US President Donald Trump in Dublin on Saturday. REUTERS

land's largest unionist party, the Democratic Unionist Party, rejected Trump's prediction, saying unification would lead to "the destruction of our country."

"Northern Ireland's constitutional future will be decided by the people of Northern Ireland, not by commentary in London, Dublin or Washington," Gavin Robinson, who has publicly supported Trump in the past, wrote on X.

British PM Andy Burnham's position on Irish unification remains unchanged, a spokesperson for his office said on Saturday, following comments by US President Donald Trump that he would "love" to see a united Ireland.



Children look at damaged hotel after Russia's attack on Ukraine, in the city of Chornomorsk in Odesa region in Ukraine on Saturday. REUTERS

5 killed in strikes on Ukraine as Putin warns Europe against sending troops

Associated Press
Kyiv, September 12

RUSSIAN STRIKES killed five civilians and wounded dozens in Ukraine, local officials said Saturday, after Russian President Vladimir Putin warned that sending European troops into Ukraine would amount to direct conflict with Russia.

Ukraine is under pressure from Russia's intensifying attacks using ballistic missiles and jet-powered drones to pierce defenses. Moscow's attacks have targeted Ukraine's power grid

ahead of winter in what officials say is meant to demoralise civilians. Two people were killed and one wounded when Russian drones struck a residential area overnight in the Ukrainian city of Zaporizhzhia, regional head Ivan Fedorov said Saturday.

One person died and three others were wounded in strikes on Kryvyi Rih, according to local officials. In the Black Sea port of Odesa and the surrounding area, 35 people were wounded overnight in what regional head Oleh Kiper called a "massive attack." Among the buildings hit was a

residential high-rise, whose upper floors were completely destroyed. Later on Saturday, two people were killed in a Russian attack on a grocery store in Zhytomyr region, officials said.

Meanwhile, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Ukrainian forces struck two chemical industry facilities in Russia, one in Samara and one in Perm. The governors of the regions did not immediately comment, but Russian independent online news outlet *Astra* reported drone attacks on chemical plants in both regions.

• CRYPTO MINING — WHICH USES POWERFUL COMPUTERS TO GENERATE VIRTUAL ASSETS SUCH AS BITCOIN — REPRESENTS A NEW FRONTIER IN MEXICO'S FIGHT AGAINST ORGANISED CRIME

Hidden crypto farm in Mexican mountains puts the spotlight on cartel funding

Sarah Morland & Daniel Becerril
Tlaola, September 12

NESTLED in the lush green mountains of Central Mexico, next to a sparsely traveled gravel road, few people had reason to wander close enough to hear the loud, mechanical whirring of a clandestine cryptocurrency farm.

What led police to the ramshackle building, suspected of mining virtual coins to launder illicit funds, was not only the noise but the vast amount of electricity needed to power and cool hundreds of specialized computing units, at levels far surpassing the needs of the

small communities scattered around the Sierra Norte region of Puebla state.

Crypto mining — which uses powerful computers to generate virtual assets such as bitcoin — represents a new frontier in Mexico's fight against organized criminal groups, which have extended their reach beyond drug trafficking and extortion into the murkier realm of financial crime.

In Puebla, authorities discovered 300 graphics processing units (GPUs), 80 medium-voltage terminals and eight satellite antennae — all geared to compete against millions of other machines to solve puzzles and

create valuable new crypto coins. While a relatively modest operation by international commercial standards, it is the fourth such crypto farm uncovered in the area since early last year.

"Drug cartels appear to have reached a new level of sophistication," said David Saucedo, a Mexico-based security analyst, adding that setting up such an operation would have required technical expertise and backing from a well-financed group, such as one of Mexico's most powerful cartels. Mexico's federal attorney's office declined to comment, citing an active investigation.

Globally, illicit cryptocurrency transactions more than



A drone view shows a community near the building where authorities found a suspected illegal cryptocurrency mining operation. REUTERS

doubled in 2025, with addresses linked to criminal activity receiving an estimated \$154 billion, up from \$59 billion a

year earlier, according to blockchain analytics firm Chainalysis, which analyzed transaction volumes sent to illicit wallet ad-

resses. Chainalysis attributed much of the increase to a surge in transactions linked to sanctions evasion, including payments involving sanctioned governments.

As more people and institutions worldwide adopt virtual currency, most within the confines of the law, Latin American cartels are among those increasingly using crypto transfers and mining operations to launder money, said Caio Motta, the firm's Latin American specialist.

"These locations will have very cheap electricity, or be in an area under the influence of organized crime so they're able to steal electricity and establish a

large infrastructure to mine cryptocurrency," Motta said. Electricity is the biggest cost for mining crypto, as energy prices have increased and the process of minting a single unit of virtual currency has become more resource-intensive. The University of Cambridge's Bitcoin Electricity Consumption Index estimates the cost of minting one bitcoin — the most widely used cryptocurrency — at nearly \$45,000. This would still bring a substantial profit when sold at current prices of around \$78,000.

"If they were stealing the electricity, the main costs of the operation would be, well — nothing," said Samuel Leon, an ex-

pert in energy theft at Mexico's Iberoamericana University, referring to the Puebla operation.

Mexican authorities said they are investigating whether the crypto farm was stealing electricity from a nearby hydroelectric dam.

The crypto farm was located approximately twice that distance from the nearest village. Three other similar crypto farms were found last year in the vicinity of the nearby hydroelectric dam in northern Puebla.

Local authorities said they are collaborating with nearby states to investigate the possibility of more hidden operations. REUTERS

AMID GLOBAL TRADE POLICY UNCERTAINTY

BRICS condemns unilateral tariffs, backs WTO reforms

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, September 12

THE BRICS countries Saturday flagged the rise of unilateral tariff and non-tariff measures in the backdrop of a slew of protectionist measures taken by the US and the European Union.

These measures “distort trade and are inconsistent with the World Trade Organisation’s rules”, the New Delhi Declaration 2026 issued at the BRICS summit said. It also said that the countries would work together to enhance the WTO’s responsiveness to the needs and priorities of emerging markets and developing economies and support outcomes that strengthen the multilateral trading system and address evolving global challenges.

BRICS members said the proliferation of trade-restrictive actions is inconsistent with WTO rules. Raising “indiscriminate” tariffs and non-tariff measures”, or protectionism under the “guise of environmental objectives” threaten to reduce global trade, disrupt global supply chains, and introduce uncertainty, potentially exacerbating existing economic disparities and hurting global economic development, they said.

BRICS against sanctions

This comes in the backdrop of sweeping tariffs imposed by the US for over a year under various US trade provisions, which have targeted exports from across the world. While the US has relied on tariffs to limit exports, the EU has imposed carbon tariffs on carbon-intensive products, ignoring the Special and Differential Treatment (S&DT) provisions of WTO agreements that advocate giving a longer window to developing nations to address the climate change issue.



BRICS members warned that protectionism could reduce global trade and disrupt supply chains. REUTERS

The declaration also condemned imposition of unilateral coercive measures in the form of economic sanctions and secondary sanctions, which it said had negative implications for human rights, including the rights to development, health and food security, of the general population of targeted states. These affected the poor and people in vulnerable situations disproportionately, deepened the digital divide and exacerbated environmental challenges, the declaration said.

WTO reforms

The BRICS declaration said that the members support reform of the WTO and to strengthen a non-discriminatory, open, equitable, transparent, fair, inclusive, predictable and rules-based multilateral trading system, with the WTO at its core. Amid a deep divide within developed and developing nations, BRICS backed foundational principles, such as Most-Favoured-Nation Treatment and Special and Differential Treatment for developing members, particularly LDCs.



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“We will ensure the implementation of the MC14 outcomes and continue to engage constructively towards the resolution of outstanding issues. We will engage constructively in the WTO reform to enhance the WTO’s authority, effectiveness, inclusiveness, and relevance, and build an open world economy. In this regard, we recognise that it is important to identify appropriate pathways for plurilateral initiatives into the WTO legal framework, including on development-oriented issues, and to explore the formulation of forward-looking rules in the WTO,” the declaration said.

This comes amid a push for radical reforms by the US, such as a rethink on the Most Favoured Nation (MFN) principle that ensures non-discriminatory trade practices, incorporating a plurilateral agreement in WTO architecture, which is seen as a contrast to long-established consensus-based decision-making. New Delhi is primarily pursuing policy space due to its relatively low share in global trade but large scope for future growth.

FULL REPORT ON
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HDFC Bank recommends two names for next CEO

George Mathew
Mumbai, September 12

HDFC BANK has submitted the names of two candidates to the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) for appointment as its next Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer (MD & CEO), setting in motion the succession process at the country’s largest private sector lender. The recommendations, in order of preference, come ahead of the end of Sashidhar Jagdishan’s current term on October 26, 2026.

According to the bank’s regulatory filing, it has sought RBI approval for the appointment of its next MD & CEO for a three-year period. Along with the names of the two candidates, HDFC Bank has also submitted the proposed remuneration for the candidates. The appointment will be subject to approval from the central bank.

The bank has sought the reappointment of V Srinivasa

Rangan as a whole-time director, designated as Executive Director, along with the remuneration payable to him. His proposed tenure will run from November 23, 2026, to November 22, 2027.

HDFC Bank has also proposed the appointment of Jimmy Tata as a whole-time director, designated as Executive Director, for three years from the date of RBI approval, or such other date or period as may be specified by the regulator. In addition, the bank has proposed creating one additional whole-time director position. This will increase the number of whole-time directors on the board to four, apart from the MD & CEO.

HDFC Bank said the additional position is intended to ensure sharper synergy and oversight, including over its subsidiaries, while creating a larger leadership pipeline for succession planning.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

SEBI proposes tweaks to closing auction session

New Delhi, September 12

SEBI on Saturday proposed changes to the methodology for calculating expiry-day settlement prices of index and stock derivatives, following a review of the newly introduced closing auction session (CAS) framework. SEBI proposed two options for determining the settlement prices — a blended Volume Weighted Average Price (VWAP) based on trades executed during the last 30 minutes of the continuous trading session (CTS) and the 10-minute CAS, or continuation of the existing CTS VWAP methodology.

The proposals follow feedback received from market participants on the use of the CAS-determined closing price for settling derivative contracts on expiry. Determination of derivative settlement prices based on the closing price arrived at through CAS was among the significant areas of feedback received by SEBI. PTI

Challenges that China’s heft poses for India

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, September 12

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping highlighted the need to address structural trade imbalance between the two countries during their bilateral meeting on Saturday.

The ties between the two countries had hit a low after the Galwan Valley military clash in June 2020. But, of late, there have been signs of a thaw — resumption of direct flights, reopening of border trade via Nathu La after six years and, most importantly, easing of restrictions on foreign direct investments (FDI) from land-bordering countries.

Unpredictable American trade policies and two ongoing wars that have rattled the oil and bond markets seem to have nudged India and China to ease tensions.

As negotiations between India and the US for a deal remain on, India has been seeking an edge in Section 301 rates over its competitors, including China. The demand for differential tariffs may have begun taking shape as the US in July this year imposed a 10% forced labour tariff on India, which was better than the 12.5% tariffs imposed on China, Russia and Brazil among others. China had earlier warned countries of consequences if they struck deals at its expense.

China dominance & MSMEs demands

With current trade within BRICS heavily centred around China, MSMEs have a deep dependency on Chinese capital goods and technical expertise.

However, manufacturers said that there is significant opportunity in the BRICS for exports. While Indian MSMEs are seeking better technical cooperation with China and easier access to input items from the country, there is a simultaneous challenge of a trade deficit with the neighbouring country.

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, September 12

AGAINST THE backdrop of stifled energy flows from West Asia due to the conflict there and attacks on energy infrastructure in theatre conflicts — West Asia as well as Russia-Ukraine — the New Delhi Declaration adopted at the 18th BRICS Summit on Saturday underscored energy security and the protection of critical energy infrastructure as a key focus area of the grouping’s economic and geopolitical concerns. The declaration called for stable energy markets, uninterrupted supplies, and protecting important energy infrastructure.

This comes amid the ongoing West Asia conflict, where major oil and gas producers including Iran, Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates — all BRICS members — have been impacted by attacks on energy

production and supply infrastructure. Attacks on Iran’s infrastructure came from US and Israeli forces, while Saudi Arabia, UAE, and other Gulf countries seen as US allies were hit by Iran and Tehran-backed Houthi militia attacked and damaged oil and gas infrastructure in Saudi Arabia.

Moreover, energy infrastructure in Russia — a BRICS founding member — has also been damaged amid its war with Ukraine. Top global oil and gas importers China and India are also founding members of the grouping. The call for protection of energy infrastructure and unimpeded flow of energy globally are appeals India has repeatedly made over the past several months.

In a sense, the emphasis on

• Rising imports from BRICS countries led by China (FY2026)

Countries	Imports	Exports
Brazil	8.05	7.00
China	131.62	19.47
Egypt	2.60	3.87
Ethiopia	0.24	0.438
Indonesia	20.29	4.49
Iran	0.375	1.25
Russia	55.36	4.49
Saudi Arabia	30.79	10.28
South Africa	8.56	7.00
UAE	63.88	37.35
BRICS total	321.79	95.69

SOURCE: GTRI
NOTE: FIGURES IN \$ BILLION

As per the Institute for Studies in Industrial Development (ISID), India faces its largest and growing trade deficit with China, particularly in consumer goods (garments, leather), electronics, auto com-

ponents, and power equipment (solar PV cells and batteries).

China is India’s single largest import origin, supplying 19.2% of India’s total imports, ISID reports said.

SC Ralhan, president of the Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO), said BRICS cooperation can improve India’s access to critical minerals, energy, technology, capital and new manufacturing partnerships.

“The opportunity is not simply to sell more to BRICS countries. India should become an integral part of the production, sourcing and value chains being developed across these economies,” he said.

“We need BRICS to create practical trade, payment and investment corridors through faster cross-border settlements, affordable trade finance, easier recognition of standards, verified buyer-seller networks and stronger SME-to-SME partnerships. With India running a substantial trade deficit with

most BRICS economies, the priority must also be to integrate Indian MSMEs more deeply into BRICS supply chains,” said Vinod Kumar, President, India SME Forum.

Challenges from China’s dominance

While Indian manufacturers are increasingly scouting for opportunity, the biggest challenge is competing with Chinese goods abroad and China’s over-reliance on exports rather than consumption for economic growth. A Stanford research report released last year said that the next “China” in labour-intensive manufacturing is still China.

“No other country has fully absorbed China’s former role in labour-intensive exports, and China itself remains resistant to large-scale immigration of low-skilled workers. As a result, the transition away from China’s dominance in these industries is unfolding gradually, with no clear replacement emerging yet,” the report said.

BRICS seeks ‘mutually reinforcing policy levers’ to boost intra-bloc trade



• Scope to improve intra-BRICS trade

	Exports	Imports
Intra-BRICS trade	\$1.1tn	\$1.4tn
BRICS members trade	\$5.67tn	\$4.58tn
Global trade	\$26.3tn	\$26.5tn

NOTE: DATA IS FOR 2025 AND IN \$ TRILLION, SOURCE: GTRI, DGCIS

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, September 12

WITH AN eye on ensuring resilient global value chains, the BRICS countries will look at “mutually reinforcing policy levers” to boost trade within the grouping, the New Delhi Declaration, issued on Saturday, said.

The statement comes a month after the meeting of BRICS trade ministers in August in Jaipur made note of the same, detailing that the levers would include backward and forward global value chain linkages, regional integration, economic diversification beyond primary commodities, investment in physical and digital infrastructure, regulatory frameworks, and upgrading workforce skills.

Boosting trade within the members of BRICS has been a focus for some time; according to think-tank Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI), while the grouping in 2025 accounted for \$5.7 trillion of the world’s exports of \$26.3 trillion (21.6%), only 4.1% was intra-BRICS trade.

China dominates intra-BRICS trade, with its exports and imports to and from other members standing at \$551 billion and \$465 billion, respectively, in 2025. At \$226 billion, India has the largest trade deficit among the members.

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follows a China-centred hub-and-spoke pattern, rather than a balanced trading network,” Ajay Srivastava, Founder of GTRI, said, adding that there is “considerable scope for growth through better market access, lower trade barriers, improved logistics, local-currency settlement and more diversified supply chains”.

According to Anil Bhardwaj, Secretary General of Federation of Indian Micro and Small & Medium Enterprises (FISME), the awareness among businesses about opportunities in other BRICS countries is “abysmally low”, with most interactions so far being at the government-to-government level.

“To realise the potential of intra-BRICS trade, especially among original BRICS countries, respective governments have to liberally facilitate and support businesses to explore by reducing their risks,” Bhardwaj said.

The New Delhi Declaration also endorsed the consensus reached by the trade ministers in Jaipur to study the setting up of an ‘Invoice Discounting Mechanism’ for BRICS members, aimed squarely at providing funds to Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) and “strengthen their participation in international trade”.

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• THE EAST-WEST PIPELINE RUNS ROUGHLY 1,200 KM ACROSS SAUDI ARABIA, FROM THE ABQAIQ OIL PROCESSING CENTRE IN THE KINGDOM’S OIL-RICH EAST TO THE RED SEA PORT OF YANBU IN THE WEST

Saudi Arabia shuts East-West oil pipeline after attacks: Why it matters for India

Anagha Jayakumar & Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, September 12

SAUDI ARABIA has temporarily shut its East-West oil pipeline after multiple attacks on the crucial network on Thursday, raising fresh concerns over global oil supplies already strained by disruption in the Strait of Hormuz. The pipeline, also called Petroline, is one of the most important Hormuz-bypass routes for exporting Saudi Arabian crude.

The immediate effect on Saudi oil exports, and consequently on international supplies and prices, will depend on the extent of the damage and how quickly the pipeline can resume operations. For energy import-dependent India, too, there will be ramifications.

Importance of East-West pipeline

The East-West pipeline runs roughly 1,200 km across Saudi Arabia, from the Abqaiq oil processing centre in the kingdom’s oil-rich east to the Red Sea port of Yanbu in the west. From Yanbu, oil tankers headed to Asia usually sail east through the Bab el-Mandeb, while those headed west go through the Suez Canal.

Operated by Saudi Aramco, the pipeline allows Saudi Arabia to move crude oil overland from its main producing region to the Red Sea, rather than shipping it from terminals on the Persian Gulf through the Strait of Hormuz. In fact, the pipeline was built partly as a hedge against risks arising from disruptions in oil flows through Hormuz. Its

targeting, however, has demonstrated that alternative routes themselves can become targets in a wider regional conflict.

Before the conflict erupted, the pipeline was operating at just a fraction of its capacity, as exports from the regular route through the Strait of Hormuz were normal. But with maritime traffic through the chokepoint grinding to an effective halt, Aramco started pumping more oil through the Petroline, which has the capacity to transport around 7 million barrels per day (bpd) of crude.

While the actual volume of crude moving through the pipeline has been lower than its capacity, with estimates ranging around 4-5 million over the past few months, it is still significant and represents 4-5% of global oil



The pipeline, also called Petroline, is one of the most important Hormuz-bypass routes for exporting Saudi Arabian crude. REUTERS

supplies. This route has therefore served as an important safety valve for global oil supplies during the current crisis.

The worry for India

Saudi Arabia had traditionally been among the top

sources of crude oil for India. While supplies from Riyadh have fallen notably amid the Hormuz crisis, Saudi oil still accounted for 7-8% of India’s total oil imports over the past couple of months. And a vast majority of these came from the Yanbu

export facility. In August, India imported about 332,000 bpd of Saudi oil, accounting for 7.2% of New Delhi’s total oil imports for the month, as per tanker data from Kpler. In July, oil imports from Riyadh stood at about 414,000 bpd, and made up 8.2% of India’s oil imports.

The first impact of the Petroline’s shutdown for India would be on supplies, and Indian refiners will have to find replacement volumes.

While that can be managed, given India’s highly diversified crude import slate, higher prices for those alternative barrels will be the bigger headache. Amid the West Asia conflict, India’s crude oil import bill surged by over 56% on a year-on-year (y-o-y) basis in April-July to \$63.4 billion, even as

import volumes rose slightly to 81.9 million tonnes — or about 600 million barrels — from 81.5 million tonnes, as per data from the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell.

Energy imports are a major component of India’s overall imports, and any meaningful increase has ramifications for the country’s trade balance, current account, inflation, and the rupee’s exchange rate, among others. India is the world’s third-largest consumer of crude oil and depends on imports to meet over 88% of its requirement. Put simply, an oil shock can be considered an external tax on the Indian economy.

Given its high oil consumption and import dependency, India is already bearing the

brunt of high oil prices. The country imports 1.8-2 billion barrels of oil a year, and every \$1-per-barrel increase in price bumps up its oil import bill by up to \$2 billion on an annualised basis.

It also said that every 10% oil price increase typically widens India’s current account deficit by 0.4% of the GDP. Crude oil alone is the country’s largest merchandise import. According to Commerce Ministry data, crude oil imports in 2025-26 stood at about \$135 billion. If oil prices sustain at \$100 per barrel in the current financial year and import volumes don’t decline, the oil import bill could be upwards of \$200 billion for the year. If the price sustains at a much higher level, the implications would be even graver.

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BRIDGE

One of the things which differentiates an expert from a non-expert is the expert's ability to watch the spots. While an ordinary player is more worried about picture cards or honours, an expert watches the spots as well. The spot cards often lead to correct line of play. **Dealer:** West

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ A 5 4		♠ 7 6 3 2	
♥ K 6 3		♥ A 8 7	
♦ K 8 7 4 2		♦ A Q	
♣ 9 4		♣ A K 5 3	
SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
pass	pass	pass	
1NT	pass	3NT	pass
pass	pass		

West leads the spade king. Plan the play. Declarer, with eight sure tricks, should begin by ducking the first two leads of spades (in the hope that spades divide three-three, or that West has only two spades and will not be able to knock out dummy's ace-of-spades entry by leading spades a third time). This duck is good technique, but does not affect the result.

THE WEST HAND ♠ K Q J 10 ♥ Q 9 2 ♦ 10 9 ♣ Q 10 7 6

THE EAST HAND ♠ 9 8 ♥ J 10 5 4 ♦ J 6 5 3 ♣ J 8 2

After taking the ace of spades, South should start diamonds by cashing the ace and leading the queen. When West plays the nine and ten on the first two leads, declarer can make sure of the contract by overtaking the diamond queen with dummy's king and leading the seven or eight from dummy. Good defense can defeat all other lines of play. **Dealer:** East Vulnerable: None

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ K 5 4		♠ A Q J 3	
♥ 8 7		♥ A K J 10 9 4	
♦ K 10 8 6			
♣ K 7 6 5		♣ 4 3 2	
SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
	pass		
1♥	pass	1NT	pass
3♥	pass	4♥	pass
pass	pass		

West leads the queen of clubs, which holds, then the jack of clubs, which also

• SUNDAY CROSSWORD

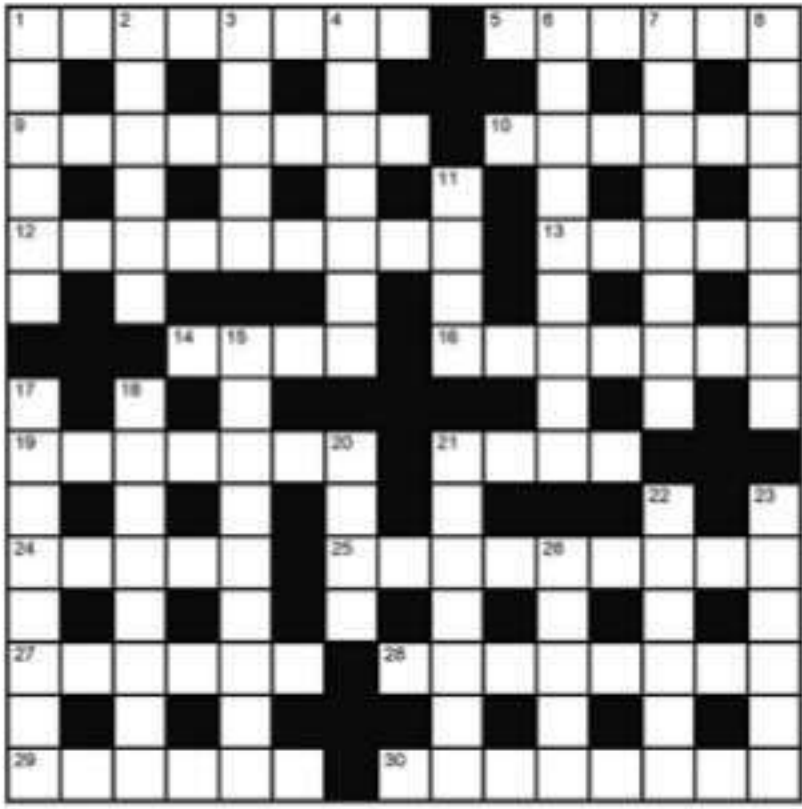
QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

- Underground cemetery (8)
- Intensify (4,2)
- Endlessness or boundlessness (8)
- Morocco seaport (6)
- Graces, god-sends (9)
- Adjusted pitch (5)
- Emolument (4)
- Pulling or tugging sharply (7)
- Questioned (7)
- "M*A*S*H" star (4)
- In addition (5)
- Statement of reasons (9)
- Pilotless aircraft (6)
- Arctic animal (8)
- Discount (6)
- Denigrates, maligns or disparages (8)

DOWN

- Goes up (6)
- Candy (6)
- Currency units (5)
- Early performance (7)
- ___ one's belt : lived more frugally ? (9)
- Fussily precise (8)
- Pattern or prototype (8)
- Children's game (1,3)
- Affiliation (9)
- Spend wastefully (8)
- Great slaughter (8)
- Indian wrestling great ___ Singh (4)
- Suitability (7)
- Safe harbours



- (6)
23. Finds out (6)
26. Snow leopard (5)

punished and journalists recognised (7)

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

- Badly deranges weapons (8)
- One's not prepared for these remarks (2,4)
- When essential, provide a source of water on small island (2,1,5)
- Desire escort on journey (4,2)
- Those taps fixed very quickly (9)
- Pulls out the stops? (5)
- Porridge for a flier (4)
- How schoolboys are

- One who turns out an oriental conqueror (7)
- Feeling green finishing very shortly (4)
- A gale tangled up seaweeds (5)
- What a poor boxer, for instance, may lead (1,4,4)
- Large inlet regulating pulse (6)
- A self effacing action of the Japanese (4-4)
- Jokes that plasterers should see ! (6)

SOLUTIONS TO 2598 QUICK CLUES ACROSS: 8 Obtain, 9 Tet, 10 Hull, 11 Rejuvenate, 12 Nosh, 13 As it is, 16 Ganymede, 17 Picking, 18 Shining, 22 Confetti, 25 Minute, 26 Deci, 27 Reassemble, 30 Cosh, 31 Nah, 32 Coldly **DOWN:** 1 Able, 2 Tabu, 3 Inpers on, 4 At large, 5 Strewn, 6 Phenomenon, 7 Closed, 14 Sri, 15 Take flight, 19 Hemisect, 20 Nut, 21 Bipasha, 23 Oregon, 24 Throng, 28 Mill, 29 Lull **CRYPTIC CLUES ACROSS:** 8 Medusa, 9 OAU, 10 Isn't, 11 Tuning fork, 12 Boot, 13 Hinder, 16 Supposed, 17 Tiny tot, 18 Top-hole, 22 Merryman, 25 Serape, 26 Harp, 27 Unscramble, 30 Dene, 31 Erg, 32 Kowtow **DOWN:** 1 Zebu, 2 Tupi, 3 Kangaroo, 4 Soloist, 5 Buck up, 6 Big Brother, 7 Snooze, 14 Ill, 15 Day-tripper, 19 On strike, 20 Lip, 21 Inn sign, 23 Elates, 24 Mouser, 28 Mown, 29 Lion

2599

IF IT'S YOUR BIRTHDAY

SUNDAY SEPTEMBER 13: Exciting changes will lead to increased personal freedom this year. Stay flexible. Let go of whatever impedes your progress. Seek out new opportunities and be ready to act fast. Expect to travel and make new friends.

MONDAY SEPTEMBER 14: This is a year of service, perhaps service to family. Take care of yourself so that you are a resource to those who turn to you for guidance, comfort and courage.

TUESDAY SEPTEMBER 15: This is a year of learning and reflection. Renew your spiritual beliefs. Explore philosophies that give you better self-awareness.

WEDNESDAY SEPTEMBER 16: This year you reap the benefits of all your hard work! Expect power and leadership in your activities. It's a busy year. Seize opportunities. Promotions, kudos and acknowledgement will be yours.

THURSDAY SEPTEMBER 17: This is a year of completion and endings. Let go of things that hold you back. Do some internal and external housecleaning.

FRIDAY SEPTEMBER 18: This is a year of new beginnings, adventures and major changes. Keep your eyes open for new opportunities and be ready to take action.

SATURDAY SEPTEMBER 19: This is a slower paced year. Take time to rejuvenate your energy. Focus on business and personal relationships, and explore the world.

• YOUR WEEK AHEAD



ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Discussions with others will be exciting but unpredictable. You might meet a real character today, someone exciting. Alternatively, someone you know might do something that surprises you. Check the Moon alert. This Week: Work hard/party hard.



TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Be vigilant, because this is an accident-prone time for your pet. Meanwhile, this is a high-energy and playful day. Write down your excellent ideas but don't initiate anything until tomorrow. This Week: Socialise and enjoy warm relations with others.



GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Today you're full of creative ideas and spontaneous energy. Surprise invitations might come your way. Guard against sports accidents. Parents should be extra vigilant about their kids. This Week: Financial matters, parents and family are your focus.



CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Your home routine might be interrupted today. A small appliance might break down a minor breakage could occur or someone unexpected might be at your door. Be aware of the Moon Alert today. This Week: Fast pace, energetic week.



LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Today you're thinking outside the box, coming up with imaginative, original ideas. Your daily routine might change. Pay attention to everything you say and do to avoid accidents. Check the Moon Alert. This Week: Focus on redecorating and entertaining.



VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Guard against loss, theft or damage. This is a day full of unpredictable events; in addition to which, there's a Moon Alert today. Restrict spending to food and gas. This Week: Your ability to be charming and friendly empowers you.



LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Today Mercury is in your sign dancing with unpredictable Uranus, which makes you feel alive and mentally alert. You might suddenly travel. You might see solutions to old problems. There's a Moon Alert today. This Week: You're ambitious and ready to speak.



SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Today you feel restless. You might change your mind and your plans. People want to see you, because with Venus in your sign, you're very charming and diplomatic. Be aware of the Moon Alert. This Week: You're ready to defend your ideas.



SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Your arrangement with a friend or a group might suddenly change today. Something might be cancelled or something might be initiated. Be careful, because there is a Moon Alert today, which is a poor time for important decisions. This Week: You look good. Enjoy being with younger people.



CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): A parent, boss, teacher or the police might surprise you today. Be prepared. There is also a Moon Alert, which means it's a poor time for shopping and making decisions. This Week: Be creative.



AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Ideas are flying through the air today. Agree to nothing important because most of this day is a Moon Alert. This Week: Word hard, doors will open.



PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): When it comes to banking and shared property, keep your eyes open. Postpone important decisions and spending because of today's Moon Alert. This Week: Socialising and travel appeal. This Week: Partnerships, socializing and travel are appealing.

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Confusion is always the most ___ response -Marty Indik (6)

ROWEN	GIRTYN
AHSS	NUCHAL

SOLUTIONS: ROWEN: Grown, stashed, lunch
AHSS: Confusion is always the most honest response - Marty Indik

SUDOKU 6440

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s

INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

8					6			
		6	7				1	
		2		5	8			
	8			3				7
			8		7			
5				2			4	
				3	4		1	
	2				6	9		
		9						6

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6439

कार्यालय कार्यपालन अभियंता

वि/यां मिनीमाता बांगो सभाग माचाडोली

मुख्यालय कटघोरा जिला-कोरबा (छ.ग.)

Email ID: ceemrgh@cgwrd.in (: 07815-297058)

ज्ञाप. क्र.3183/व.ले.लि./2026/कटघोरा दिनांक 10/09/2026

निविदा निरस्तीकरण आदेश

कार्यालय प्रमुख अभियंता, जल संसाधन विभाग शिवनाथ भवन सेक्टर-19, नार्थ ब्लॉक, नवा रायपुर अटल नगर, रायपुर, छ.ग. का पृ: क्र. 4264239/निविदा प्रकोष्ठ/2026/5421 (टी.सी./नवा रायपुर/दिनांक 02.09.2026 के परिपालन में इस कार्यालय का निविदा सूचना क्र. 01/व.ले.लि./2026-27/ दिनांक 17.06.2026 निविदा सिस्टम क्र. 193639 (प्रथम आमंत्रण) जरापुर जिले के सिंचाई योजनाओं के गेट मरम्मत एवं विद्युत संरचना का कार्य अनुमतिन लागत रु. 141.25 लाख में कोई भी प्रतिभागी निविदाकार भाग नहीं लिये जाने के कारण निविदा निरस्त की जाती है। जिसका पूर्व में आपके कार्यालय द्वारा जारी जी नंबर 262701976/1 है।

हस्ता./- कार्यपालन अभियंता

वि/यां मिनीमाता बांगो सभाग माचाडोली मुख्या. कटघोरा जिला-कोरबा (छ.ग.)

RO NO 262703246-7

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Shahid S/o Farid Ahmad R/o H. No. Juggi No. 59, Near Dharam Kanta, 18 Quarter Vishwash Nagar, Shahdara, Delhi-110032** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 95/2018 U/s 324/326 IPC, P.S. Vivek Vihar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Shahid** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Shahid** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Shahid** of case **FIR No. 95/2018 U/s 324/326 IPC, P.S. Vivek Vihar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **16.10.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Mohit Sharma
Chief Judicial Magistrate
Room No. 59, Third Floor, Shahdara District
DP/12805/SHD/2026 (Court Matter) **Karkardooma Courts, Delhi**

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Banti @Imran @Rihan S/o Sadih R/o E-444, Janta Majdoor Colony, Welcome, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 9838/2025 U/s 305(b)/317(2) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Welcome, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Banti @Imran @Rihan** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Banti @Imran @Rihan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Banti @Imran @Rihan** in **FIR No. 9838/2025 U/s 305(b)/317(2) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Welcome, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **13.10.2026**.

By order
Ms. Deepakshi Rana
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
Court No. 17, Shahdara
Karkardooma Court, Delhi
DP/12865/NE/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Deepak Sharma, S/o: Lt. Om Prakash Sharma, R/o: Ground Floor, First Floor, Second Floor, Plot No. 196, Gali No. 04, Sainik Enclave, Sector-02, Mohan Garden, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **CT No. 905/2024, U/s 135 Indian Electricity Act, P.S.: Mohan Garden, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Deepak Sharma** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Deepak Sharma** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Deepak Sharma** accused of offence in case **CT No. 905/2024, U/s 135 Indian Electricity Act, P.S.: Mohan Garden, New Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **16.10.2026**. **By Order**
Ms. Harleen Singh
Additional District & Sessions Judge
Special Court (Electricity)
DP/12917/DW/2026 (Court Matter) **Room No. 609, Dwarka Court, New Delhi**

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Suresh, S/o: Hari Shankar, R/o: H.No. A-295, Gali No. 6, Part 1st, Sonia Vihar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 417/2017 U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act, P.S.: Khajuri Khas, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Suresh** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Suresh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Suresh** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 417/2017 U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act, P.S.: Khajuri Khas, Delhi** and is required to appear beforethis Court to answr the said complaint on or before **12.10.2026**. **By Order**
Ms. Shruti Saraswat
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
Room No. 22, 1st Floor
Karkardooma Court, Delhi
DP/12885/NE/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Satish S/o Inder Singh R/o VPO Hathwala, PS Julana, Dist. Jind, Haryana** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 938/2022, U/s 279/337/338 IPC, Dated 17.12.2022, PS Narela Industrial Area, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Satish** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Satish** has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Satish** of case **FIR No. 938/2022, U/s 279/337/338 IPC, Dated 17.12.2022, PS Narela Industrial Area, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **23.11.2026**. **By Order**
Sh. Sahil Gupta
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
North, Room No. 06, Ground Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi
DP/12843/ON/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING ATTENDANCE OF DEFENDANT

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./ 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Hemant Kumar Gupta, S/o: Kanhiya Lal, R/o: H.No. 137, Pocket B-5, Sector-4, Rohini, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **Ct. Case No. 5286/2019, U/s: 138 NI Act, Police Station Alipur, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Hemant Kumar Gupta** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Hemant Kumar Gupta** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Hemant Kumar Gupta of Police Station Alipur, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **13.10.2026**. **By Order**
Ms. Priyanka Rajpoot
CJM, North, Room No. 115, Rohini Courts, Delhi
DP/12945/ON/2026

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PLANNING AND INVESTIGATION DIVISION ROAD CONSTRUCTION DEPARTMENT (RCD),RANCHI

Nirupan Bhawan, 3rd Floor, Room No. 401, 56-Set, Doranda, Ranchi-834002

Invitation of Proposal (e-procurement Notice)

Letter of Invitation (LOI) No.- 11/2026-27

2nd Call

NATIONAL BIDDING

e-Tender Ref No-RCD/PID/RANCHI/11/2026-27 Date:- 11.09.2026

1	Name Of Work	Consultancy Services for Preparation of Detailed Project Report for the Construction of ROB between Chandni Chowk Hatia to Police Headquarter keeping in view of Smart Cityn lieu of L.C No.-HB-1 between Hatia – Balsiring Station including forest diversion, Land acquisition plan with ownership details etc as required by the Department (If any) under Ranchi district inState of Jharkhand.
2	Period of Completion of Work	90 Days
3	Cost of Tender documents	Cost of Tender Document- Rs 5,000/- (Five Thousand only) EARNEST MONEY DEPOSIT:- Rs 30,000 (Rs. Thirty Thousand only). As per the Departmental Letter no.-4652(S) dated 06.10.2023, cost of tender document and Earnest Money Deposit will be received in online mode only through eprocurement portal (https://jsharkhandtenders.gov.in) by internet banking NEFT/RTGS facility as per Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) issued by Information Technology & eGovernance Department, Government ofJharkhand vide letter no- 120 dated 03.10.2023. e-tendering(https://jsharkhandtenders.gov.in)
4	Mode of Bid Submission	
5	Date/Time of Publication of Tender on Website	18.09.2026 At 5:30 PM
6	Date of Pre Bid Conference	28.09.2026 At 11:00 AM Place - In the Chamber of CE,CDO, RCD, 1stFloor, Nirupan Bhawan, Doranda, Ranchi-834002
7	Last Date/Time of Submission of Bid	08.10.2026 Upto 12:00 noon
8	Date and Time of Technical Bid opening	09.10.2026 at 12:30 PM
9	Bid validity	120 days
10	Designation and Contact no. of Tender Inviting Officer	Executive Engineer, Planning and Investigation Division,RCD,Ranchi Mob No.-9471650883
11	Advertisement No.	PR 382925 (Road) 2627 (D)

Note:- Only e-Tender shall be accepted.

Executive Engineer, Planning & Investigation Division, Road Construction Department, Ranchi.

PR 389673 (Road) 26-27 (D)

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय, ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग कार्य प्रमंडल, लातेहार

शुद्धि-पत्र

इस कार्यालय के द्वारा प्रकाशित ई-निविदा संख्या 05/2026-27/EE/RWD /LATEHAR जिसका PR No. – 389041 REO(26-27)#D का निविदा को अपरिहार्य कारण से रद्द किया जाता है।

कार्यालयक अभियंता, ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग कार्य प्रमंडल, लातेहार

PR 389652 (REO)26-27D

DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS SAMBA

LOOK OUT NOTICE

As intimated by SDPO Bari-Brahmana vide letter No SDPO/BB/26/7987 dated 09.09.2026, that one person namely TuseeKumar D/o Binod Ravi DassR/o DumrahwaNawadaPakariBawan Bihar A/P Kabir Colony Bari Brahmana has been missing from Bari-Brahmana and her missing report has been entered vide DDR No.13 dated 15.11.2025 of P/S Bari-Brahmana. Her search was conducted but not traced out till date. Through the medium of this LOOK OUT NOTICE, it is informed to all the Police Establishments/General Public that any information related to the missing person may be communicated on following contacts:-

- PCR Samba :-01923-246333, 9541649001
- SSP Samba's email ID :- sspsamba@jkpolice.gov.in
- SHO PS Bari-Brahmana:- 8713023636

The description roll along with photograph of missing person is as under:-

Name:	Tusee Kumari	
D/O	Binod Ravi Dass	
Permanent Address:	DumrahwaNawadaPakariBawan Bihar A/P Kabir Colony Bari Brahmana	
Age:	20 Years	
Height:	5 FEET 02 INCH	
Complexion	Wheatish	
Face:	ROUND	
Body Structure:	Medium	
Languages known:	HINDI	
Attire:	Red Suit and Salwar	
Body Mark	Black Mole on Neck	

No. CB/Look/2026/
Dated:- 09.2026

Sd/-
Sr. Superintendent of Police, Samba

DIP/J-10252/26 – DATE 12 SEP 2026

"IMPORTANT"

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ASIAN GAMES | AICHI-NAGOYA | SEPTEMBER 19 TO OCTOBER 4

Protagonist, Paraphernalia & Podium: It takes three elements to complete sport. *The Indian Express* presents the stories about the personality, the equipment and the opponent who will bring the slash of strokes and dash of colour to the Asian Games

Rahi rediscovering her mojo

Neuropathic pain waylaid the 25m pistol shooter for three years, but she's forged an international comeback at 35

Shashank Nair
New Delhi, September 12

IF YOU belong to the upper echelon of Indian pistol shooters, making it to the national team is nowhere near as tough as making a comeback to that level. The second act is what has always been the real hurdle.

Jitu Rai will allude to its difficulty: Saurabh Chaudhary is still trying to regain all that he lost – his partner Abhishek Verma is now a footnote in India's Olympic pistol shooting. Amid those stories of Indian pistol wielders waylaid along their path to an Olympic medal, Rahi Sarnobat is scripting her own return – one where she judges success from a different plane to her first stint within the sport.

But first, some context. In 2022, the Maharashtra shooter faced a nerve pain that left her bedridden. Multiple tests later, a diagnosis was made – neuropathic pain were the words uttered to her, an ailment that came with no set plan of recovery. Each body was different, and each path of recovery its own.

It took a long time for Rahi to be rid of the pain she was constantly under and when the pain left her body, the desire to get back to a shooting range followed. It's only as recent as 2025 when the Indian pistol shooter was completely off medication. But things would have to be done differently this time around.

"Now my technique is different. My body is different. My thinking is different. My approach is different," says Sarnobat. "Now my priority is listening to my body more. I'm

listening to signals which our body and mind give us. I'm listening to that more than ever because I feel that the amount of stress we have in general as competitive athletes is too much," says the 35-year-old.

"We tend to ignore these signals because we have to perform. We cannot take off or we cannot take a break. But then eventually it takes a load on the nervous system. And that is what has happened with me," she declares.

During her time of distress, Rahi read about her condition and developed knowledge on neuroplasticity and neurology. It reached a point, where even if she felt slightly stressed, she would immediately stop, and a take one more day's rest to make sure her body's recovery got the priority it deserved.

"It's not always about taking a break but maybe breaking some pattern and restarting again. Or using meditation, or swimming or music. Something to make my nervous system relax. Because again as I said, if you listen, it's always giving you signals. It's just that we ignore it," says Sarnobat.

For many of the 'older heads' in India's shooting team flying to the Asian Games, stress and managing the constancy of losing their spot to a domestic upstart have been the bigger challenges. For Rudranksh Patil, stress led to tremors when entering a shooting range – an issue that opened his eyes to prioritising his recovery. Pistol shooter Anish Bhanwala felt the stress of domestic competitions in his event, but had to tell himself that he was one of the best India had produced and that a break, or choosing to recover,

would not change his ability to pick his gun up after time out of the range, and rediscover his old ways.

Regaining stamina

For Sarnobat, the challenge was different. Hers involved the simple act of regaining stamina at a shooting range. When the shoots of her comeback started to spring, all that was possible was for her to stand for one minute and take aim – hardly the hallmark of an elite shooter.

"My first goal was to reach the quantity and the duration because without quantity I don't think we can really work on the quality. So, that's how I started, and it took me approximately 13 to 14 months to reach the stage where I could shoot for five to six hours. I would say that from the last national championship, I have been able to work on the quality of my shooting and that has resulted in me being the part of the team and getting better results," says Sarnobat.

India's shooting team is prone to its changes. A brief glance at the Asian Games squad that went to Hangzhou, and now the one set to fly to Aichi-Nagoya tells the tale. New faces, new names – some athletes with only a year of international competitions to their record before reaching a multi-sport continental event – there are certain events where the inexperience is telling.

Sarnobat took her time. She regained her spot in the national team – one which she had never truly lost in the first place. Winning the T4 trials put her right behind Esha Singh and Manu Bhaker in the race to be a top-three 25m pistol shooter, and put her into the Asian Games mix. Part of her return is down to the work done by her neuro-



ON CHANGES

Now my technique is different. My body is different. My thinking is different. My approach is different. Now my priority is listening to my body more. I'm listening to signals which our body and mind give us."

ON HER COMEBACK

It took me 13 to 14 months to reach the stage where I could shoot for five to six hours. From the last nationals, I have worked on the quality of my shooting and that has resulted in me being the part of the team."

RAHI SARNOBAT

RAHI SARNOBAT IS CURRENTLY RANKED 30TH IN THE WORLD, NRAI

SPORT LAB

Standardisation a game changer in Esports

Organisers hand everyone identical, tournament-issued handsets stripped of background bloat to prioritise skill

Mayank Chaudhary
New Delhi, September 12

ASK ANY amateur Indian gamer sweating it out in a study room or a cramped local cybercafe what frustrates them most, and the answer rarely involves their gameplay. It's mostly the hardware. The sudden 200ms ping spike that freezes the screen mid-gunfight.

The budget phone overheating until frames drop to a stutter. The cheap earphone that cuts out just as enemy footsteps draw near. In India, gaming has always been about making do, battling unreliable internet and uneven devices.

At the highest level, though, professionals build their entire elite gaming career around gear, be it by breaking in a specific mouse over months or tweaking custom keyboard switches, and depending on private servers for practice, where latency – time for a response from a server – is predictable and the environment is better controlled.

Over time, this gear becomes an extension of the player, a comfort zone that allows them to perform at their peak. At the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, that entire comfort zone is stripped away.

The evolution has been dizzying. When esports debuted as a demonstration event at Jakarta-Palembang in 2018, it felt more like an upscale cybercafe. Internet connectivity was flaky, players plugged their personal gear straight onto the stage, and when server latency spiked, the

standard fix was an admin jogging over to reboot the PC.

By Hangzhou in 2023, where esports became an official medal event, the scale exploded. China invested in purpose-built smart arenas with dedicated, isolated local servers.

For the first time, games weren't needed to ping into remote public servers. Rather, they ran on on-site, hardwired enterprise rigs delivering near-zero millisecond latency.

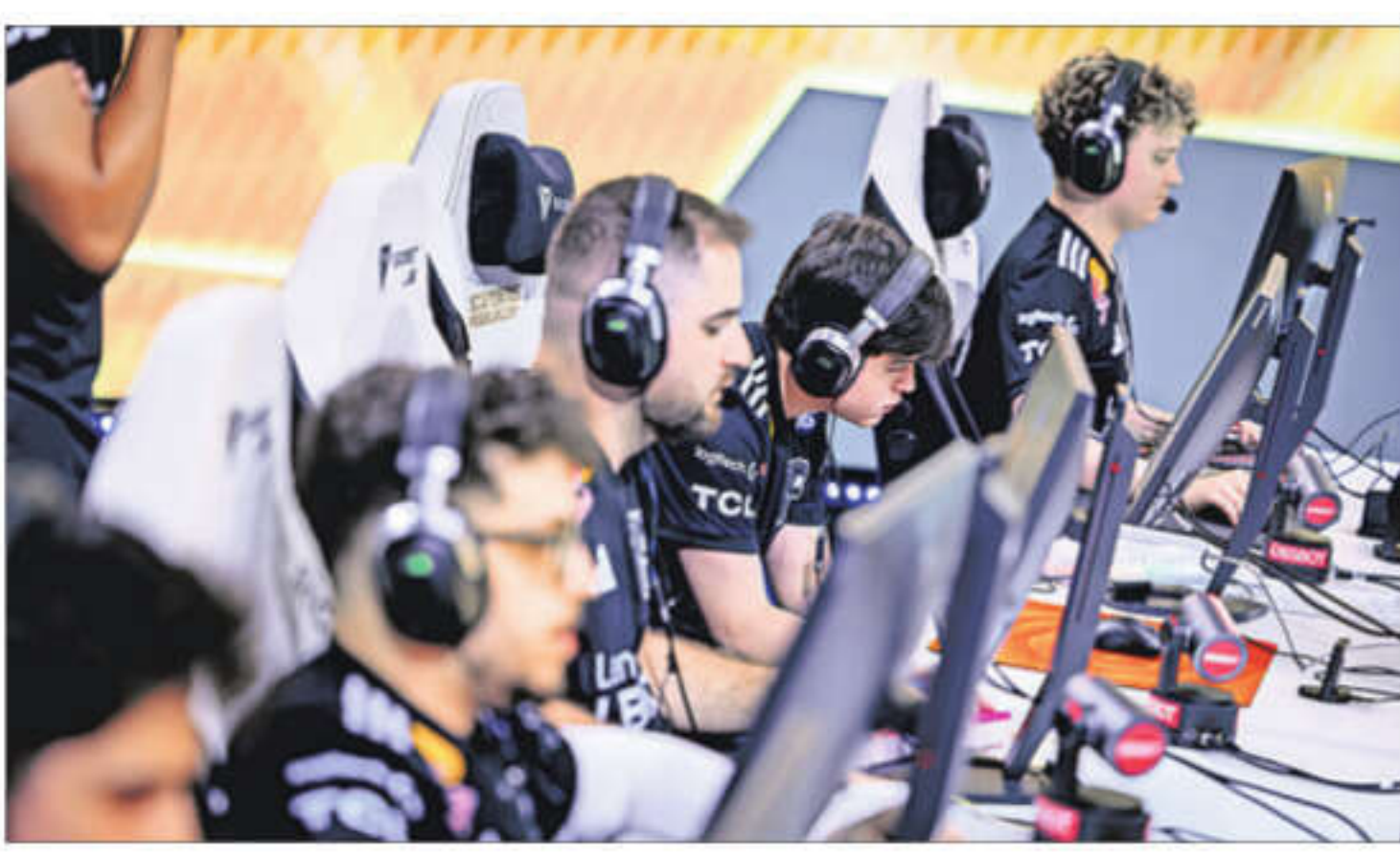
Now, arriving in Japan for the 2026 Games across an expanded 11 medal events – where India is set to send 15 players across four gaming disciplines – that technical rigour has solidified into absolute Olympic standardisation. Under Asian Electronic Sports Federation (AESF) oversight, the setup corresponds to an anti-doping laboratory.

Players must surrender their personal mouse and keyboards into technical quarantine hours before walking out. Scrutineers scrub onboard memory chips to ensure no hidden shortcut macros exist, test firmware against strict whitelists, and lock the peripherals in anti-static boxes until match time.

If a cable looks tampered with or a brand is unauthorised, it doesn't make the stage.

For India, where mobile titles like Battlegrounds Mobile India (BGMI) dominate the culture, this level of technical parity is revolutionary.

In domestic circuits, a player with an expensive flagship phone has an undeniable edge



● At the elite level, gear becomes an extension of the player, which allows peak performance.

● At Asiad, personal gear is quarantined, devices are identical, and local servers with zero lag are used.

● With hardware excuses eliminated, win comes down purely to nerves and skill of the players.

In domestic circuits, a player with an expensive flagship phone has an undeniable edge over someone on a Rs 15,000 device battling thermal throttling.

over someone on a ₹15,000 device battling thermal throttling.

Level field

The Asian Games brutally levels that field. In mobile medal events, players are forbidden from touching their own phones. Organisers hand everyone identical, tournament-issued handsets stripped of background bloat. Same goes for a

PC, PlayStation or a Nintendo Switch Event.

At the scale of the Asian Games, crucially, there will be no unstable Wi-Fi. Every device is hardwired via Ethernet docks directly into the arena's local servers, completely killing ping spikes.

At this level, handsets use external bypass power to keep batteries from heating up during long-drawn matches. Even popular accessories like third-party finger sleeves or clip-on triggers are strictly illegal.

The stage environment has transformed as well. Soundproof glass booths, once a staple of gaming broadcasts, are gone due to stadium fire codes.

Instead, players wear an "audio sandwich": custom in-ear monitors delivering game sounds and white noise, along with aviation-grade ear de-

fenders to physically shut out arena crowds.

Even commercial freedom gets reined in. Under Olympic Rule 50, players' usual billboard-style sponsors are banned on the field of play.

Referees walk down desks with matte black gaffer tape, covering glowing logos on mice, pads, and jerseys before broadcast cameras go live.

From Jakarta's chaotic reboot culture to Hangzhou's smart LAN architecture and now Japan's ironclad standardisation, esports has grown exponentially over time.

For the Indian contingent in Nagoya, the playing field has never been more level. There will be no lag, no hardware advantage and no crowd noise banging into the players' ears and only nerves and skill will decide who wins.

PATH TO GOLD: PREETI, BOXING

Unleashing upper cuts against Taiwanese, Uzbek

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, September 12

BOXER PREETI Pawar has a mountain staring at her at this Asian Games. The line-up for the 54kg is almost like the Olympics. A stack of familiar and seasoned names are tilting their glances at the CWG champion and World No 3; three-time world champion and Tokyo Olympics (51kg) bronze medalist Huang Hsiao-wen of Chinese Taipei, Paris Olympics silver medalist Pang Chol-mi of North Korea and bronze clincher Nazym Kyzaibay (51kg) of Kazakhstan. Not to discount 2023 Worlds bronze medalist Enkhjargal Munguntsetseg of Mongolia and the sprightly Chinese ace Xuan Zhao.

Quiet confidence

But Preeti has reasons to be quietly confident. She is the only boxer to have defeated Hsiao-wen twice in a year; she has beaten Chol-mi and Enkhjargal in the Asian Championship this year. She has also scored wins over 2022 world silver medalist Lacramioara Perijoc of Romania, and World No. 6 Sirine Charaabi of Italy.

But her mind is not scanning the big names she could confront; rather she is nibbling lessons from the Hangzhou Games, where she had mustered bronze "The semifinal loss against Chang Yuan taught me a lot of things too," she recounts.

"Yuan lost the final against Chol-mi and then went on to win the Paris Olympics gold, beating Chol-mi in the semis. I wasn't technically strong at that time and I worked on my counter movements as well as



Preeti Pawar

EVENT Boxing-54kg

UNBEATEN in 2026 going into the Asian Games.

CWG GLASGOW — Gold

ASIAN CHAMPIONSHIPS ULAANBAATAR — Gold

2025 WORLD CUP FINAL — Gold

body switch punches. I also remember Hangzhou for the win over three-time world medalist Zhaina Shekerbekova in the quarters. She is one of those perfect boxers around," Pawar said. The 54kg category, which made its Olympics debut in Paris, has been an Asian stronghold. Asians have won as many as five world titles since 2010. Hsiao-wen presents a unique challenge because she is the tallest among the lot at five feet nine inches. Xuan is an inch shorter, whereas Pawar is only five feet six inches.

"Hsiao-wen is a tall boxer and she plays a lot of counters. The wins have taught me not to be in her range and to utilise the body to switch punches as well my counter punches too," she said. "I have not faced Chol-mi

Fact file

EVENT: Women's 25m pistol

YEARS ON CIRCUIT: 22

FIRST-EVER OLYMPICS: 2012, London

MAJOR ACHIEVEMENTS: Palembang Asian Games individual gold medal, 2014 Incheon team bronze; 2014 Glasgow CWG Individual gold; 2010 New Delhi CWG team gold and individual silver.

ologist, her physios and personal coach Jelena Arunovic, who fortuitously also works with the Indian pistol team now.

Youth challenge

But the comeback to the big leagues has in large part also been down to her willingness to take the challenge of younger, vaunted shooters. Rahi's confidence shot up when she took all the shots that were listed in her name at the national shooting camp in Dehradun – one of the few shooters at the camp that stuck to their quantity of shots.

Then there was the quiet confidence that came from within. Knowing what to chop, and when not to change was crucial. "I am the oldest in the team. And as for the young generation, I think I know more ways of not doing certain things," said Sarnobat.

"I cannot train in the same pattern or same manner as I did in my 20s. And now it's my 22nd year in the game. So, I have to consider the way I use my body and my mind. I mean even as a person and a shooter, I feel this is a totally different journey. And sometimes I cannot even relate to these two phases of my life," she said. "Earlier if someone gave me advice that my shooting could get better by doing something different, I wouldn't have listened to them. But now it's totally from scratch," she added.

"It's a totally new life and a new chapter for me."

yet but she is a technical boxer," she adds.

As are Kazakh and Uzbek pugilists. "But the win against Zhaina Shekerbekova taught me how to utilise my upper cut and right counter punches. In Asian championships, Kazakh Elina Bazarova boxed a bit rough too and the key was to keep her close to the ropes and land my counterpunches," Pawar elaborates.

Eye on Olympics

The southpaw, who also trains at IIS Bellary and the Indian Army camp at Pune, watches videos of (Ukrainian boxer) Vasilii Lomachenko as well her opponents. To destress, she resorts to paper quilling, which she plans to do in Japan as well. "I am a fan of Lomachenko. We rely on the upper cut in the southpaw stance as well as the right uppercut to land on the opponent's body. I have also worked a lot on my out-of-vision punch right hook," adds Pawar.

Her performance against Hsiao-wen has left head coach Santiago Nieva chuffed.

"We have seen how Hsiao-wen struggled against Preeti with her pace. She is a long distance boxer but Preeti pressured her with her pace. Preeti has strong basics, which allows her to be both offensive as well defensive. In CWG, focus was more on counterpunches but here, the focus will be on switching between counter as well attacks. They all are very good but we are also good," remarks Santiago.

Rest assured that the gaze of the mountain wouldn't make her flinch.

Sooryavanshi's new-ball issue meets Afghans built to exploit it

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, September 12

FOR VAIBHAV Sooryavanshi, it is all in a day's work. Or, at times, two. The version on show at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Friday bore no resemblance to what he had produced at this very venue four months earlier, a 21-ball 46 in the IPL in which neither Mitchell Starc nor Lungi Ngidi was spared. On Friday, he was beaten four times by Jasprit Bumrah, and twice apiece by Arshdeep Singh and Yash Thakur, in India's training session ahead of the three-match T20I series against Afghanistan.

A few hours later, on Saturday, he was back to being Sooryavanshi. Among only three Indian cricketers who turned up for the optional session, the other two being fellow left-handers Abhishek Sharma and Tilak Varma, the 15-year-old batted for close to two hours at the nets.

Sunday will be harder than either of those two days. It will be Sooryavanshi's first time representing India on home soil, even if India are technically the away side in a series where Afghanistan has been designated the home team.

Navdeep Saini, drafted in as India's net bowler for the series, has spent the sessions troubling the batters with how much the ball has swung. "From what I have experienced so far, there was movement on offer," he told this newspaper. "With the new ball, the pacers can surely be effective. The ball was gripping a bit as well. Perhaps it is because the weather has been a bit cold, with the rain around. The runs will start flowing once the ball gets older, but we might see movement in the first few overs."

The Delhi Premier League, which wrapped up less than a fortnight ago, told the same story. Across the last five full-length matches of that tournament, nine wickets fell inside the first three overs across all ten innings, for 229 runs. New-ball trouble wasn't a theory at the Kotla. It was the pattern. Afghanistan captain Ibrahim Zadran sounded like a man who'd done the homework. "He has been great at the IPL, and has been performing at all the different levels of cricket. We have thought about him, and we have knowledge about him too. There are guys in our team who have played against him in the IPL, and we have already watched his videos. We will try to just keep it simple and execute the right plans at the right time against him."

AFGHANISTAN VS INDIA T20IS

In unusual settings, series focus on asterisks, risks

India to play first-time visitors at Kotla; workload management under lens

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, September 12

BETWEEN KOTLA and Kabul, the lines have blurred.

In central Delhi, there is hardly a street left untouched by the colours of the Indian flag. With leaders from many nations descending upon the capital for the BRICS summit, every nook and corner screams — unmistakably — India. And yet, at the heart of it all, inside the Arun Jaitley Stadium, the Indian cricket team finds itself in the visitors' dressing room.

"This is historic. It has never happened in the history of this stadium," a DDCA official quips. Across the 36 Tests, 22 ODIs and 5 T20Is they have played here, India have never before been cast as the away side. On Sunday, September 13, that streak ends — Shreyas Iyer's team will take the field against Afghanistan, or, more accurately, will be hosted by them, in the first of a three-match T20I series.

For Iyer, though, the symbolism will barely matter once the first ball is bowled. His tenure as the leader is heading towards a consequential period.

The early months of his role as Suryakumar Yadav's successor have offered little comfort, if any. At England, his team lost four of five games — only a washout saving him from the ignominy of a white-wash. Before that, Ireland handed them a 2-0 sweep. The lone bright spot has been a clean 3-0 sweep of Zimbabwe.

Injury woes

Should one be tasked with making a case in Iyer's defence, a prolonged list of injuries could be put forth. Jasprit Bumrah — the metronome around whom India's bowling attack is built — is yet to feature under Iyer's captaincy, having picked up a knee injury during the ODI series against England in July. Washington Sundar suffered a hamstring injury on the same tour, while Nitish Kumar Reddy was ruled out in June with a quadriceps issue.

All three were named in the squad with an asterisk, their se-



Shreyas Iyer and Afghanistan's Ibrahim Zadran unveil the trophy at the Arun Jaitley Stadium. PTI

“Looking at every individual who has come out of an injury, they are looking fit and fine. They are in great shape and we had two high-intensity training sessions yesterday and the day before yesterday.”

SHREYAS IYER,
INDIA CAPTAIN

lection contingent on clearing fitness tests. Not only have they done that, they also have looked sharp in India's training sessions on Friday and Saturday. Bumrah, in particular, troubled every India batter he bowled to. Both Washington and Nitish, meanwhile, bowled at full tilt, while also getting time in the middle with the bat.

Still, with India staring down a punishing calendar — as many as 20 T20Is potentially between now and year's end — and injuries having become a

recurring theme, workload management is likely to be of immense importance.

On being asked about it in the pre-match press conference, the Indian captain said, "Looking at every individual who has come out of an injury, they are looking fit and fine. They are in great shape and we had two high-intensity training sessions yesterday and the day before yesterday. I honestly can't tell you how we are going to manage it (the workload), but all I can assure you is that the team is looking promising."

Iyer reserved particular praise for Reddy, stating "I am glad that Nitish is back from his injury and is looking in great shape. The efforts that he put in yesterday, I saw the workload was pretty intense. And yes, looking forward to seeing him in the series and then all the games going forward."

Bumrah's selection has drawn its own share of scrutiny, given his significance in the 50-over format with an ODI World Cup on the horizon, but Iyer is of the opinion that game time will help the pace spearhead build his confidence back up.

"If you would ask me as an individual who is coming out of an

injury, I would want more game time and more confidence leading up to a certain tournament. I interacted with him yesterday and he is in that mindset where he wants to come and perform for the team."

Asiad tune-up

For Afghanistan, though, the series will certainly offer some crucial game time ahead of the Asian Games, considering they have not featured in the shortest format since the T20 World Cup in February. "It's a great achievement for us, for our cricket. I am sure this series will help us a lot," said the team's captain, Ibrahim Zadran.

With IPL experience not being found wanting in his team, and with Naveen-ul-Haq returning to the team for the first time since December 2024, he can only take a leaf out of Lorcan Tucker's book and hope. "We have played enough cricket here to know the conditions really well," Zadran commented. Of course, one would expect the 'home' captain to say so.

Afghanistan vs India, 1st T20I: Live on Sony Sports Network and FanCode, 7PM

Zverev holds edge but Shelton has skills to test him

Bhuvan Gupta
New Delhi, September 12

FIVE FACE-offs, five wins — just one set dropped. Forty-four wins in 45 matches against left-handers. Anyone looking statistically at the Alexander Zverev vs Ben Shelton match-up might deem Zverev a foregone victor. They would be disregarding Shelton's extraordinary US Open 2026 run, however.

The 23-year-old has defied history and odds to captivate the Flushing Meadows faithful. He's dethroned Carlos Alcaraz in a five-setter for the ages. He's bested "big brother" Frances Tiafoe 4-6, 6-3, 6-3, 7-5 in a semifinal etched in Black American history. Shelton now stands one step away from breaking his home nation's 23-year men's singles title drought at the tournament.

Andy Roddick was the last American man to rule New York, back in 2003. Since then, Andre Agassi (2005 finalist), Roddick himself (2006) and Taylor Fritz (2024) have come close. Agassi and Roddick had to contend with Roger Federer in his prime, and Fritz ran into then No.1 Jannik Sinner. Though the task is daunting for Shelton too, he might fancy his chances against Zverev, who is new to Grand Slam success.

Six years after reaching his maiden Major final in New York, Zverev finally broke his Grand Slam jinx this June at Roland Garros. It was a weakened field; there was no Sinner, Alcaraz or Novak Djokovic. But he followed that up with a final appearance at Wimbledon, where Sinner got the better of him.

Sinner, Alcaraz and Djokovic were all out of Zverev's way this time at the US Open, too, but for the first time he enters a Slam final as the outright favourite. The pressure of making the first breakthrough had kept him from sleeping or eating properly. What will the pressure of living up to a top-seed billing do to him on Sunday?

Back and forth

Zverev is known to counter-punch from the baseline, especially with his backhand. During his Friday semifinal, when Karen Khachanov started to apply some pressure in the second set with his deep returns, Zverev retreated even further back. It is an integral part of the German's gameplay and has worked well for him this season.

But Shelton has an uncanny ability to sneak up to the net. Though unlike Federer's famous 'Sneak Attack by Roger'



Left-hander Ben Shelton sent 20 aces in his semi-final victory over Frances Tiafoe at the US Open. AP



Alexander Zverev. AP

(SABR), the American can volley when least expected. If he can exhibit that skill as well as he did against Alcaraz in the quarters, it would give Zverev something to think about.

Then there is the famed Shelton serve. Besides its speed and heaviness, the Shelton service stands out for its direction. With 43 out of the 50 top-ranked men on tour being righties, the left-hander's serve opens up uncomfortable angles for them, making it very hard to attack. Zverev has found a way past it before. He has also tormented southpaws with his unflappable backhand, as evidenced by his superb win-loss record against them.

However, Shelton's special form seems to have propelled his serving further. He sent down 20 aces against Tiafoe at the Ashe.

Beyond his serve and net play, Shelton has refined other aspects of his game since his semis defeat to Djokovic at the season-ending Major in 2023. "I feel that I'm a different player. I feel like I have so many more tools. I feel like I know my identity, am comfortable in my own skin, and I know what it takes for me to be playing top-level tennis," he said.

The eighth seed is also not

• Number Plate

0-5

● Ben Shelton has a 0-5 head-to-head record against Alexander Zverev. The German also enjoys a 7-0 win record against left-handers this year, making Shelton's task of winning his first US Open just that difficult.

fazed by his 0-5 head-to-head record against Zverev. "Problem-solving has been the name of the game here. I'm looking forward to the challenge, being able to problem-solve on Sunday. I know what I'm up against, and I'm also the most confident I've ever been in my game," Shelton said.

Grandmother tribute

After beating Tiafoe, Shelton spoke about the enormity of the occasion for him. "It's a lot of emotion. My mum and dad sacrificed a lot for me to be in this position today," he said courtside. He also paid a rich tribute to his grandmother, who passed away earlier this year. She was instrumental in his father Bryan taking up tennis, which in turn sprouted Shelton's rise. "My dad lost his mum earlier this year. She's the reason he was able to play tennis. Without her there's no Ben Shelton standing here today. This one is for her."

The young gun implored the New York crowd to raise the decibel levels when supporting him in the final. "I'm going to need you guys on Sunday to bring the energy," Shelton said.

"I'm going to leave it all on the court and I hope you guys come and back me. Let's do this for the USA."

US Open men's singles final: 11:30 pm, live on Star Sports Network and JioHotstar.

• WOMEN'S ASIA CUP

India face Lanka in rising Asian rivalry but need answer to left-arm challenge

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, September 12

OVER THE years, the Women's Asia Cup has changed formats, expanded its field and travelled across the continent. Yet, one fixture has been a recurring feature when the title has been on the line.

India and Sri Lanka contested the title in each of the first four editions before going 14 years without meeting in a summit clash. Since 2022, however, they have once again become familiar opponents in the title clash. Sunday in Dubai will mark their third successive final at the continental event.

India swept aside Sri Lanka by eight wickets in the 2022 final in Sylhet, but Sri Lanka stunned India in Dambulla two years later, winning by the same margin to claim their maiden title.

India's batting in the 2026 edition has been driven by Shafali Verma and Smriti Mandhana. The former leads the batting charts with 168 runs at a strike rate of 169/70, while Mandhana has 154 at 171.11. But beyond the left-handed Mandhana, India's top order is stacked with right-handers. Shafali, Pratika Rawal, Harmanpreet Kaur and Richa Ghosh form India's batting core. That provides Sri Lanka an intriguing match-up through their slow left-arm duo of Sugandika Kumari and 17-year-old Chamudi Praboda.

The pair have been among Sri Lanka's most economical



Smriti Mandhana has scored 154 runs at Asia Cup at a SR of 171.11. ACC/X

bowlers in the tournament. Sugandika has taken six wickets and conceded 63 runs in 15 overs, while Chamudi has five wickets for 66 runs in 15 overs. Together, they have taken 11 wickets in 30 overs at an economy rate of 4.3. Sugandika has been trusted in the powerplay and dismissed Muneeba Ali in the semifinal on Friday against Pakistan. Chamudi has often bowled later and generated turn, a skill she showcased when she outfoxed Sadaf Shamas with late turn and had her stumped in the same game.

Left-hand match-up

Their match-up against India's right-hander-heavy line-up could prove decisive.

In India's semi-final against Bangladesh, left-arm spinner Nahida Akter took 1/25 in four overs and dismissed Richa, reacting to her charge by going wider and bowling it slower before having her stumped. She also

helped mount pressure on Harmanpreet, who was 2 off 10 at one stage. Bangladesh leg-spinner Rabeya Khan posed a similar challenge by turning the ball away. Pratika struck her for six by using her feet before falling after advancing again, top-edging to cover.

It was not the first time India had been tested by spinners who possessed the ability to turn the ball away. Against Thailand, leg-spinner Suleeporn Laomi took 3/26 and dismissed three right-handers - Pratika, Shafali and Richa. Not all three wickets fell to turn, but Richa's stood out. She tried to hit a flighted ball outside off over cover but picked the fielder. For India, the answer to Sri Lanka's left-arm duo need not be to err on the side of caution. The batters have shown they can disrupt spinners by taking the attack to them. Shafali has used the reverse sweep, Pratika has skipped down the pitch, and

Richa has backed her power to clear the field. The challenge will be knowing when to attack and when to defend against bowlers who can vary their lengths and pace.

Chamudi has shown an ability to dismiss batters who look to advance against her. In her 3/21 against Bangladesh, she dismissed Sobhana Mostary, who came down the pitch to her. The ball turned away, beat her, and she was stumped.

Sri Lanka has another major threat in captain Chamari Athapaththu. Her off-spin has accounted for 11 wickets, including a remarkable 7/5 against Indonesia, making her the tournament's joint leading wicket-taker. But India's batting composition could make Sugandika and Chamudi more important on Sunday. With four right-handers between Mandhana and Deepti Sharma in India's likely top six, Sri Lanka could bowl the left-arm duo at different stages.

Sri Lanka's left-arm spinners have gone at a combined 4.3 runs an over. Against an Indian batting order packed with right-handers, their ability to maintain that control could be crucial. With India trying to reclaim the title from the team that took it from them two years ago, that match-up could ultimately decide the final.

Live on Sony Sports Network and Sony LIV, 8 PM

Saffron jersey row: Hockey India's power struggle spills out

Express News Service
Mumbai, September 12

CITING A trip to the World Cup last month, the selection of a saffron jersey, a lack of disciplinary action over players' misconduct on the South Africa tour last December, and the "unavailability" of ICC/POSH records in a case involving a federation staffer, Hockey India president Dilip Tirkey stripped the federation's director general, RK Srivastava, of all his powers on Saturday.

A legal notice issued to Srivastava on Tirkey's behalf stated that all his powers as "Director General of Hockey India cease," in the "interest of maintaining discipline, accountability and smooth functioning" of the governing body. Srivastava was further directed to "not exercise any authority or act on behalf of Hockey India," until a further decision is taken under the bye-laws.

"The matter became particularly serious following your non-compliance with the President's email dated 02.08.2026, particularly Points 2 to 4, wherein you were expressly directed not to travel to the World Cup because your full attention was required in India for HIL (Hockey India League), franchise coordination and other priority matters," the notice said.

Srivastava, along with Hockey India secretary-general Bhola Nath Singh, has



Dilip Tirkey stripped the federation's director general RK Srivastava of all his powers. H

been at odds with Tirkey over several issues.

The notice listed eight, including the "arbitrary decision" to change the national teams' jersey colour to saffron from blue. That decision drew criticism from all quarters, and Hockey India reverted to the traditional blue for this month's Asian Games.

String of controversies

Tirkey has accused Srivastava of bypassing the executive board on major decisions, including the jersey change. It was after the former captain's own insistence that blue was restored as the primary colour for the Asian Games.

Srivastava and Bhola Nath's trip to the Netherlands for the World Cup drew its own

controversy. Former Hockey India president Narinder Batra, in a letter to sports secretary Hari Ranjan Rao, alleged that roughly Rs 43.68 lakh was spent on daily allowances for four office bearers, Rs 12.38 lakh each on Bhola Nath and Srivastava, and Rs 9.46 lakh each on treasurer J Manoharan and selection committee chairman RP Singh.

"In view of the seriousness of the matters and continuing need to protect Hockey India's records, personnel and functioning, all authority delegated to or ordinarily exercised through you as Director General shall remain in abeyance with immediate effect," the notice stated. "You may send your clarification/reply within four weeks from receipt of this communication, together with all documents relied upon."

Bhola Nath and Srivastava did not respond to calls.

Indian hockey has been mired in a string of controversies, from selection to administrative issues, while the men's team's on-field performance has nosedived over the same period.

The Craig Fulton-coached side begins its defence of the Asian Games gold medal this week; the women's team challenges China for the top of the podium. The Asian Games carry extra weight this year, since a gold medal offers a direct route to the Los Angeles Olympics.

Root takes England to series win over Pakistan

Reuters
Edgbaston, September 12

JOE ROOT guided England to a 3-0 series whitewash over Pakistan with an unbeaten 62, as his side overcame early tremors to win the third test by eight wickets at Edgbaston.

England, chasing a victory target of 130, lost Ben Duckett to the first ball and opening partner Emilio Gay later in the same over from Mohammad Abbas. But Root, who had a fortunate escape when he was bowled by Mohammad Ali on 23 off a no ball, brought all his experience to bear as England wrapped up their first series win for 19 months.

It was Ali's 17th no ball of the series. Pakistan's last chance came and went when Root, on 38, edged Abbas between first and second slip who both left the ball for each other. Pakistan, who conceded a first innings deficit of 320, showed fight to take the game into a fourth day, but with Jordan Cox supplying solid back-up to his captain with an unbeaten 59, England eased to victory in the 25th over. "Fair play to Pakistan, they threw some punches last night. They made it very difficult for us and in some ways it's a good thing to go through that," said Root.

BRIEF SCORES: England 453 and 130 for 2 (Joe Root 62 not out, Jordan Cox 59 not out) beat Pakistan 133 and 449 (Shan Masood 93, Razaullah 81; Gus Atkinson 3/109) by eight wickets.



‘Migration is not a choice’

Sheena Kalayil on her Women’s Prize longlisted novel *The Others*, writing about migrants and refusing to stay in her lane

The Rothko Chapel and its open doors



MAMMOOTTY WANTS TO DANCE

Every young scriptwriter has a role for him. He is the superstar people call ikka, elder brother. At 75, Mammootty is the face of arrival, the one who can sit with kings and not lose the common touch

Nidheesh MK

RAJASEKHARAN PILLAI, Thakazhi Rajasekharan to the film crowd, met him at a food counter. This was 2004, the first-class lounge at Singapore airport. Rajasekharan was a McKinsey partner then and flew often enough that the lounge staff knew him by face. They had him in a cubicle and were carrying his food across. A few feet away, a man stood at the counter looking lost, working out what he could eat. It was Mammootty.

Rajasekharan went over and introduced himself. It took the actor a moment, and then he had it, not the name so much as the story that came with it. Years earlier, fresh out of engineering college and a film diploma, Rajasekharan used to tip the waiters at Trivandrum hotels so they would tell him when a Padmarajan (filmmaker-screenwriter) or a Mammootty walked in. On one of those evenings he met Mammootty, long enough to pitch a film. That film was never made. But Mammootty remembered; he remembers pitches.

Since then, for the last 20 years, they have talked most days. The way you talk to that one friend you can call for nothing — from a car, from a set, from a lounge before a flight. On the phone, they are both Mr Perera, after an old Jose Prakash villain, so that whoever is standing next to the actor, and someone is always standing next to him, cannot tell who is on the line.

The measure of how close anyone is, is seen at Mammootty’s dining table. Only three people come to it uninvited. Rajasekharan, the businessman; Anto Joseph, who runs film matters and George, who runs the days.

While I tried multiple times to reach Mammootty for an interview in the days leading up to his birthday on September 7, and was snubbed, it left me with a strange kind of glee, like a child who had dared to ask his father for an ice cream knowing he will be promptly turned down. The night before the birthday, Mammootty casually rang Rajasekharan who asked, “What plans for the birthday?”

“I’ll get up in the morning and dance with Sulu,” Mammootty told him. Sulfath Kutty, his wife of 47 years. “When Chalu and Surumi get up, I’ll dance with them.” Dulquer Salmaan is Chalu at home, Surumi is the daughter. “Pisharody and Anto at noon, another dance.” Ramesh Pisharody, comedian-actor who has lately drifted into politics, is one of the faces often photographed beside him. “At night, we will do a skit.”

Mammootty does not dance. Everyone in Kerala knows this. For most of his career he was the one who stood stiff through a song while Mohanlal in his films did it like drinking water. It was one of the few things the other M had over him that nobody bothered to argue over. His 2005 film *Rajamanikyam* was where Mammootty gave in, danced badly on purpose and let the hall laugh, and the hall laughed with him. So a birthday laid out as a full day of dancing was the man having a go at himself, delivered straight.

Nobody got to ask him how the day went. He does not like the season, has never liked it and does not give interviews in it.

Bipin Chandran, the screenwriter who has written three books about him, was once sent by a magazine to set up an Onam cover marking his 50 years in cinema. Mammootty would not have it. The film they were counting from, *Anubhavgal Paalichakal* (1971), has him in one shot, a pair of rolling eyes in a crowd. His real roles came only in the 1980s.

The world comes home

He cannot simply walk into a tea stall or

a Lulu Mall, so the world is brought to him. There are some in his circle who get photographed and ones who do not. On politics, he may be closer to John Brittas, the CPM’s Rajya Sabha man than anyone visible. On books, with writer VK Sreeraman. A dozen or so others in that circle hardly ever photographed. They might get a call from him on an ordinary day and it is not about cinema. It is about the news, the rain, what onions cost.

Mammootty often anchors the television awards of TV channel, Kairali — their Jwala award for women entrepreneurs, Kathir for farmers and Phoenix for inspirational life. From the stage, he tells each winner’s story. You sit there and hear your own life told back to you by Mammootty.

Krishna, who won a Jwala, runs a small brand called Suee. She gave him a shirt. He wore it that week, then ordered three more. The gesture of support stayed with her as did everything that preceded it, especially him knowing their story before they even reached the stage. “It took me a while to recover,” she says.

Chidambaram, one of the young directors he invited home recently (he does that with new talent), said sitting with him was like sitting with a *karanavar*, the old head of a *tharavad* (ancestral home). “No fear in the man, no insecurity, bring him any dare and he will take it.” So where does the *karanavar* go when he doesn’t want to be a *karanavar*? “He comes to people like me to live like a normal man,” says Rajasekharan.

Their stories are the kind you tell about a college friend. He came to Rajasekharan’s daughter’s *arangetram* (dance debut), sat through it like any other uncle in the hall. When Rajasekharan’s sister died, it was Mammootty who sat with him.

A few hours of being nobody in particular is what the Rajasekharans of the world are for. The other place he goes for that is the charity he mentors, The Care & Share International Foundation. For his last birthday, more than 40,000 people donated blood because Mammootty had asked.

One love, one life

Director-screenwriter Adoor Gopalakrishnan’s films have put the Malayali on the world’s greatest festivals. Together they made *Anantaram* (1987); *Mathilukal*



The test for a risky script is whether any other producer can carry it. If none can and he wants the part, he makes it himself



SARAN BLACKSTAR

(1990); *Vidheyan* (1994) and reunited for *Padayatra* in 2026. Adoor says that in 40 years, they never once talked money. Instead, the last time Adoor called Mammootty, he even offered to produce the film, “Tell me what you need.” Perhaps why Adoor, who lets no actor read his script before it is a film, makes an exception for one. This last film needed a central jail setting. An additional chief secretary refused and kept refusing even after the chief minister’s office pushed. This was one of the rare instances anyone in Kerala said ‘no’ to Mammootty.

We’ll build one, Mammootty said. He brought in art director Shajie Naduvil and they put up an entire central jail set and Adoor felt it was better than the real thing. “Now I want to thank that officer in the credits,” says Adoor, “for making my film better.”

But then, why does Mammootty do what he does? Something changed after Covid. He was at home for 200-odd days and all he did was watch and read. What came out of it was *Bheeshma Parvam* (2022); *Nanpakal Nerathu Mayakkam* (2022); *Kaathal – The Core* (2023) and *Bramayugam* (2024).

A film takes longer now that he can do only four to six a year. For each one, he gets paid what a good overseas player gets for an entire IPL season. So he has to be choosy, and he can afford to be. “Fundamentally, from now on, I want to do something that genuinely touches me, something different from Mammootty. It doesn’t necessarily have to be commercially successful,” he told Rajasekharan.

The test for a risky script is whether any other producer in Kerala could carry it. If none can and he wants the part, Mammootty makes it himself.

MALAYALAM CINEMA’S EVERYMAN (Clockwise from above) Mammootty; stills from his films, *Bramayugam*; *Mathilukal*

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» CONTINUED ON PAGE 4



DOWN IN JUNGLELAND
BY RANJIT LAL
AUTHOR, ENVIRONMENTALIST
AND BIRDWATCHER



EXPRESS PHOTO

CAN'T SWAT THEM AWAY
Anti-roachers better get themselves educated about exactly who they are taking *panga* with

Why I switched parties

A tongue-in-cheek defence of the much-maligned roach, on student protests, exam leaks and the state of our education system

AT THE outset let me admit that, until recently, I was staunchly anti-roach. Then, not long ago I discovered a huge, polished mahogany roach dawdling in the bathroom, waving its long antennae around, *bilkul altu faltu*. I whacked it with a newspaper — say the equivalent of smacking a *lathi* on a child's head. It rolled over and I thought, 'Hah, done deal'. No way. Some hours later, I found it was still alive so this time, I took an insect spray to it, the equivalent of using teargas right in its face. Still upside down (some mysterious roach *asana*), it waved its legs around and lay still. Good riddance. But no, after half an hour, it was still alive.

Respect!
Immediately, I switched parties (and set it free in the garden) and became pro-roach. Now, anti-roachers think that roaches are a pest. They live in and eat garbage and their poop smells. Also, they can cause allergies and asthma in children. So does their own poop smell of Chanel #5 while they strongly advocate the consumption of what comes out of the rear end of bovines for good health and well-being (and BO)? As for allergies and asthma, have they ever tried to live in Delhi during and after Diwali, and wondered what that's doing to the lungs of children?

There are over 4,500 species of roaches in the world, of which around 30 associate with us. The big gun roaches are the American roach, a beer guzzling (and presumably hamburger, doughnut scoffing) roach, the social German roach, the Australian roach and the Asian roach, typically considered to be the 'dirtiest'. Most of the other species, some of which are quite exquisite, live in forests, where they turn up the soil, and via their poop, free up nitrogen trapped in the dead and decaying material they consume, which is vital for the well-being of plant life and without which, everything in the forest would die. And then, so would we.

ROACHES CAN GO WITHOUT FOOD FOR A MONTH, GO HEADLESS FOR A WEEK AND WITHOUT WATER FOR THREE DAYS. SO WE ARE NEVER GOING TO RUN OUT OF THEM, AND THEY CAN SWARM JANTAR MANTAR IN EVEN GREATER NUMBERS

So why did the roaches swarm Jantar Mantar and other places in India for almost two months, protesting? Like all anti-roachers, all they wanted was a good, fair education with a solid, well-paying livelihood to look forward to after that.

Anti-roachers keep boasting about how their ancestors flew to Mars and beyond and back 50,000 years ago, something even AI savvy roaches today would not be able to do. But let me tell you — roaches are interested in being well educated: Decades ago, while prepping for a school board exam, I remember one ginormous one flying through the night outside to settle on my fat, battered Chemistry textbook, which I was struggling through.

Perhaps, all it wanted was to glue-sniff the binding, but it was still imbibing knowledge for which it had given up the pleasures of the night.

All geriatric anti-roachers too want their progeny to be well-educated so promptly send them off abroad. Now 99.9 per cent of local roaches can't afford that, and 99 per cent of these are given a lousy deal at home, slogging 22 hours a day for two years, only to find that all that work does not count and needs to be redone, because someone has leaked the questions and pocketed a fortune — to send *baba* and *baby* anti-roach abroad, perhaps — but no one knows exactly who.

But really, anti-roachers better get themselves educated about exactly who they are taking *panga* with. Roaches can go without food for a month, go headless for a week, and without water for three days. They can have babies — 2-3 million in two years — so we are never going to run out of them, and they can swarm Jantar Mantar in even greater numbers.

They can lift up to 900 times their body weight and slim down to 3 mm while scuttling into cracks. And if worse comes to worst, if we blow ourselves up with our nuclear devices, they will probably be the only living creatures (along with fruit flies) to survive the blast and subsequent radiation, taking in up to 15 times what we can tolerate.

There is, however, one sure-fire way of getting rid of roaches. And like what Gandhi ji taught us, it is a completely non-violent method. Also, it inculcates his *dharma* that every person should clean his own toilet. And that is by keeping your surroundings and toilets — and education system — squeaky clean and above board.

As we have seen, the surroundings and toilets of most anti-roaches these days are unspeakable, which is why the roaches have turned up in droves. But if these are deep-cleaned, for now and forever, the roaches will not bother you anymore, let alone pour into the streets. Hounding a frightened 14-year old is the equivalent to me smacking a roach with a newspaper and blasting it with Hit. I switched parties pronto. It's time they did too.



GETTYIMAGES

IMAGINE

BY SHELJA SEN

NARRATIVE AND FAMILY THERAPIST, WRITER, CO-FOUNDER OF CHILDREN FIRST



WE GIVE a lot of freedom to our girls. That does not mean they can wear vulgar clothes and use bad language." These words from the father did not surprise me, as they echo a sentiment I often hear when I meet families with daughters.

They had come to meet me after learning that their 18-year-old daughter, Atika, had recently started meeting a boy from her college without their knowledge. She had even gone to a party under the guise of a sleeperover at a friend's home to study together.

"We saw the party photos on Instagram and were shocked to see the clothes she was wearing," the mother said. They offered me their phone with a screenshot of someone's story, where I could see Atika in a short dress, dancing away blissfully. She shot an accusing look at her daughter, "*Log kya kahenge* (what will people say)... that your parents did not teach you any *aad-harsh* (values)."

Atika sat upright on her chair, refusing to look at anyone. I tried to steer the conversation without dismissing the parents' concern, yet still centre the young woman's voice. I repeated the mother's words aloud, "*Log kya kahenge...*"

"That's all they are worried about, *log kya kahenge*," Atika finally spoke up.

"We are really worried about your safety,"

said the mother. Atika retorted, "I hate that word, safety. You just want to control me in the name of safety." I was struck by her words, so I asked her to explain that.

"Whenever they do want me to do something, they will make it about my safety," she said softly, curving her fingers as quotation marks. "But if they are honest, they will realise it is not about my safety — it is to control what I wear, what I do and where I go. I have grown up hearing — '*had me rah, kam bol*' (stay within your limit and don't talk too much), just because I am a girl. I am done with this sh*t."

"How dare you speak with disrespect to your parents?" the father snapped. Atika, in almost a whisper, said, "And you can call me characterless." I took a deep breath and realised I had to step in, otherwise, the situation could spiral into something dangerous, causing more harm than healing. I requested the parents to step back so I could have a conversation with Atika, and later we could talk together. I turned to Atika and asked tentatively, "In their worry about your safety, what do you think your parents are not seeing?" Atika bent her head down

WHY NOT?
We have to be allies in their journey for gender justice

and then said, "They forget that I am 18 now, and I am learning how to live in this world without putting myself in danger. I would like to be honest with them and tell them more about my life, but if they are going to judge and shame me, then I am left with no choice but to hide it from them." We talked a little more, and I learned a lot about what she was studying in college, what was important to her, what she was passionate about and her hopes. I was in awe of her clarity of thinking and her dreams for her future.

When I turned to her parents, they were sitting in stunned silence, possibly hearing their daughter talk about these ideas for the first time. I reflected, "As a parent, I know I end up saying or doing things against my

Patriarchy has an insidious way of recruiting parents against their daughters and pushing them to be custodians of their daughters' character'

better judgment. As you were listening to Atika, did anything she say make you question what you could do differently?" The father said nothing and looked away, but the mother broke down in tears. "It is so difficult bringing up daughters in our society. As a mother, I feel if she does anything that spoils her character, *agar bigad gai* (if she goes out of hand), then I will be blamed for it."

Bigadi hui ladki (girl who has gone out of hand) — a sentiment that comes in some shape and form in almost every conversation in a family with a young girl. I repeated the words with a smile, and then we sat and unpacked the loaded history and politics behind them. Where did it come from, how come girls had to carry the shame around it much more than boys and how it restricted our lives. The father did not participate in our unravelling of patriarchy, and when joked that I had grown up being called "*Bigdi hui ladki*" and now claimed it proudly, his eyes widened in surprise.

I wondered if I had got carried away and taken it a bit too far, but then I saw his jaw soften. Something unclenched in him as maybe he realised that he did not have to carry the burden of being a harsh protector of his daughter. She was figuring it out very well for herself.

Girls grow up with these implicit *Lakshman Rekha* (social norms) which decide what they can wear, speak or how they can act. Social control is most effective when it produces what Michel Foucault, the French philosopher, called "docile bodies". Docile bodies that internalise surveillance and carry the burden of *maryada* and *sanskar* (the social indoctrination of being a good girl), are more useful for political power structures that claim "*Humaari betiyaan is prakar ki bhasha kaise bol sakti hein* (How can our daughter speak like this?)" My question is "*Kyun nahi* (why not)?"

We continued the discussions in the coming weeks — two steps forward and one step back. Healing is not linear. We have to keep at it, dismantling patriarchy one conversation at a time. After all, metaphorically, it is in the air we breathe, in our water supply and in the smells we imbibe. But now it has started stinking, and we can't put a lid on it.

Our role as therapists is not to be complicit in becoming social control agents to "fix" the girls to be more docile. We have to be allies in their journey for gender justice. Patriarchy has an insidious way of recruiting parents against their daughters and pushing them to be custodians of their daughters' "characters". I do not hold it against them as they are repeating the language of hegemonic masculinity that they have grown up hearing. It would also be absurd to assume that women have been passive recipients of oppression for all these years. Even recent resistance has taken shape through women-led social movements such as Narmada Bachao Andolan, Mothers of Manipur, the Shaheen Bagh protest, the Chipko movement, and many others, which have shaken the cobwebs of our male-dominated society. Girls are challenging the male-dominated social order at home, in schools, and in colleges, and critiquing society's idea of being *sanskaari*. They are out on the streets, protesting, claiming their right to be heard and seen. It will be an honour to count myself among the *bigdi hui ladkiyan*. It's time we all were.

"This story is a composite of innumerable conversations with audacious girls across ages"

In this column, Shelja Sen curates the knowhow of the children and youth she has the honour of working with. Email her at shelja.sen@childrenfirstindia.com

Table For the World

The world, for all its ugliness, is still capable of gathering unlike people and allowing them to walk in the same direction. Some days, the opposite of war is not peace, it is something smaller



SLICE OF LIFE

BY SUVIR SARAN

CHEF, AUTHOR, EDUCATOR AND WORLD TRAVELLER

LOVE DOES NOT ALWAYS ARRIVE WITH VIOLINS. SOMETIMES IT COMES WITH A GLASS OF WATER BESIDE YOUR BED. A FAMILIAR HAND ON YOUR SHOULDER. A VOICE ASKING, 'ARE YOU HUNGRY?'

THERE ARE days when the world arrives before the morning does. Before the tea has boiled. Before Delhi has awakened into the furnace of its late-summer heat. The phone glows. Another war. Another wound. Another child crying beneath a sky darkened by someone else's ambition. Another country dividing itself into enemies. Another day when we are asked to choose a side before we are allowed to choose humanity. And then I look up.

Outside my apartment in my mother's compound in Delhi, the sun is savage. The heat has teeth. Humidity clings to the skin. Even the afternoon appears to be sweating. Inside, is my mother. And suddenly the world becomes bearable again. The world can be burning at the edges, and someone can still ask whether you have eaten. Civilisation can appear to be collapsing on your phone, and a mother can still insist that you take another helping.

Love does not always arrive with violins. Sometimes it comes with a glass of water beside your bed. A familiar hand on your shoulder. A voice asking, "Are you hungry?" I have needed that comfort lately.

We lost my aunt, Sunita *bua*. Barely a few days had passed when Om *phupaji* went to hospital. And then we lost him too. They went within days of one another, as though grief, having entered the house, had forgotten the door. They were loved. Deeply. And the ending was not easy.

Yet, strangely, amid all those departures, there were arrivals. My cousin Anjali



SUVIR SARAN

WHAT LOVE CAN DO
Grief reminds us that we belong to one another

and her brother Vikram came from America. My sister Seema, my brother Samir, my mother and I gathered for another journey of farewell. More than a year after the sudden death of my mother's youngest sister, my beloved aunt Aruna — our *Boo maasi* — we were taking her ashes to the Ganga. There is something about ashes that humbles you. All the ambition, arguments, compliments and catastrophes of a lifetime eventually become something you can carry.

And then there was Luca. My magnificent Bernese Mountain Dog, though even now I resist calling him merely that. Luca was not a dog. Dog is a word far too small for the creature who lived beside us. He was a four-legged gentleman. A super creature of empathy and elegance, grace and grandeur. Majestic without arrogance. Royal without pretension. Handsome enough to stop traffic and gentle enough to break your heart. A beautiful show dog, yes, but his greatest education came from somewhere

deeper. Luca had been taught, I often thought, by his own soul. He understood sadness without being told its name. He recognised silence. He knew when simply to be near. Luca has been gone for several years now. But when we travelled to the Ganga to return *Boo maasi* to the river, Luca came too. His ashes travelled with hers. And that felt right.

Those we truly love do not occupy separate compartments in the heart. Family is not a census. And so, my magnificent four-legged gentleman escorted *Boo maasi* to the Ganga.

Some creatures leave pawprints. Luca left architecture. He changed the shape of our home, the rhythm of our days, the geography of our hearts. And as ashes rose and scattered, I thought, perhaps, this is what love teaches us. In the end, we do not remember who belonged to which category. We remember who belonged to us. And amid mourning, something miraculous happened. We found one another.

THE WORD THIS WEEK

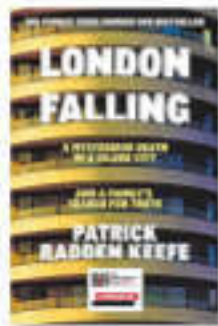
Five books to watch on the 2026 Baillie Gifford longlist

THE BAILLIE Gifford Prize for Non-Fiction is one of the most watched awards and this year's longlist — with ancient battlefields, wartime Parisian hotels and the shadowy corridors of Cold War espionage — does not disappoint. From a formidable list of 13 works of non-fiction, *The Indian Express* spotlights five must-reads



London Falling
Patrick Radden Keefe

LONDON FALLING centres on one of the most intriguing true-crime stories involving 19-year-old Zac Brettler, who fell to his death from a London pent-house balcony in 2019. It was later discovered he had been leading a double life, posing as the son of a Russian oligarch and rubbing shoulders with gangsters. Keefe, a staff writer at *The New Yorker*, follows Zac's parents as they try to make sense of their son's alternate life.



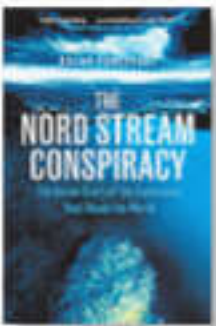
Ukrainian Lessons
Charlotte Higgins

THE GUARDIAN's chief culture writer Charlotte Higgins travelled to Ukraine in 2022 to document the role of art in war-time. She believed artists would respond to the Russia-UK conflict in ways journalists and politicians do not; by delving into the visceral emotions of living through war. Higgins documents poets, painters and musicians making art as an act of survival. She argues that their work will shape how the war is remembered.



The Nord Stream
Bojan Pancevski

IN THE *Nord Stream Conspiracy*, Pancevski, chief European political correspondent for *The Wall Street Journal*, tackles one of the most enduring mysteries of the modern era: Who blew up the \$20 billion pipeline system that carried Russian gas to Europe under the Baltic Sea? Drawing on exclusive access to both the saboteurs and the German investigators hunting them, Pancevski offers a real-life geopolitical thriller.



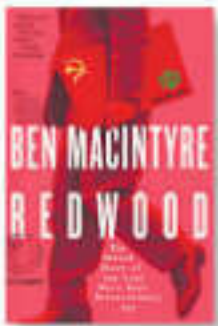
Days of Love and Rage
Anand Gopal

GOPAL, A writer for *The New Yorker*, has documented the human costs of war. In *Days of Love and Rage*, he turns his gaze to Syria, telling the story of the 2011 revolution in the northern city of Manbij, an experiment in democracy that, for 18 months, overthrew a dictatorship and offered a glimpse of a different future. At 592 pages, it is an ambitious work that rewards patience.



Redwood
Ben Macintyre

IN REDWOOD, Macintyre, a writer for *The Times of London*, tells the story of Cold War double agent Redwood. It is set in 1981, in the aftermath of the Iranian Revolution. The Soviets are planning to overthrow the Ayatollah's Islamist regime but if they do, America may use nuclear weapons. Redwood cracked open the KGB, revealed the Kremlin's secret plot, and prevented Armageddon.



AISHWARYA KHOSLA

Sheena Kalayil on her Women's Prize-longlisted novel The Others, writing about migrants and refusing to stay in her lane

Aishwarya Khosla

CROWDS SURGING through checkpoints, hammers chipping at graffitied concrete: The fall of the Berlin Wall is one of the defining images of the 20th century. Less familiar in the jubilant narratives of reunification is the plight of foreign workers and students from socialist countries such as Mozambique, Vietnam and Cuba, whose lives were dramatically altered by the collapse of the German Democratic Republic (GDR). This neglected history is at the heart of Manchester-based novelist Sheena Kalayil's fourth novel, *The Others*, which made it to the 2026 Women's Prize for Fiction longlist. The novel is set in the months before and after the fall of the Berlin Wall. It follows three people from the margins: Armando, a factory worker from Mozambique; Lolita, a medical student from India; and Theo, an East Berliner who dreams of being a writer.

The story follows them as their lives become entangled in an eventual love triangle. Still, it is as much a meditation on race, migration, living with political uncertainty, what it means to be displaced in a crumbling authoritarian state, the itchy feeling of being surveilled, and the idea of home. In 1989, when the Berlin Wall fell, Kalayil was a 19-year-old engineering student on a placement in Budapest, finding herself caught up in the joy of the Wall's collapse. "I didn't completely understand what was going on. But I could sense the euphoria that people were feeling," she told *The Indian Express*, speaking from her home in England. Years later, while living in Mozambique, she met former madgermanes — Mozambican workers who had spent years in East Germany and left after reunification. "I felt a kind of affinity because we had both been behind the Iron Curtain in those countries before the Cold War ended," she says. But when she first tried to write a novel from the perspective of a Mozambican worker returning home, it felt wrong. "It didn't feel like I should be the person writing that story." Instead, she found a story she could tell drawing on her own experience as an international student, her knowledge of Mozambique and the universal dramas of young adulthood played out against a seismic political shift. "I wanted those kinds of personal dramas, those dilemmas that you have when you are a young adult to be the focus while the moment of political change is going on," she said. "Because very often migration happens not through deliberate choice but through circumstance." That spirit of subversion extends to her heroine's name. Lolita arrives with inescapable literary baggage, dragging Vladimir

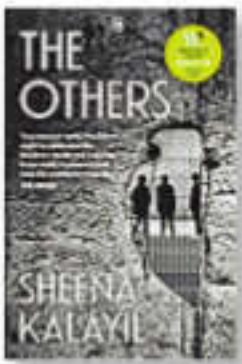


WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

THE POLITICS OF LOVE
The fall of the Berlin Wall in 1989; (below) Sheena Kalayil

‘Migration not a choice but a circumstance’

Nabokov's controversial protagonist behind her. "The truth is I didn't think of it deliberately but subconsciously there must have been something going on," she says. However, she acknowledges the name had been on her mind after a BBC radio short story she had written was read by the actor Lolita Chakrabarti. "I knew that name has a lovely sound to an Indian ear." For Kalayil, the name was also a way to challenge expectations. Her Lolita is not an object of male fantasy. "I wanted her to be ordinary," she says. "I knew that if you are young and female, you will be objectified whether your name is Lolita or not." She imagined her character's parents — Keralites who studied in Moscow — as having the sense of humour to choose such a name. "Sometimes people are quite angry that I chose the name Lolita," she adds. "But it is extraordinary to me that a name can carry so much weight." The novel itself challenges the publishing industry's expectations for Indian and postcolonial writers. Many publishers rejected *The Others* before it found a home with an independent press. "There is a narrow lane where Indian authors are supposed to stay — writing about Indian issues," she says. "If you are in the UK literary industry, there is an expectation that there will be some element of the British Raj involved or



THE OTHERS
SHEENA KALAYIL
Westland
₹599
330 pages



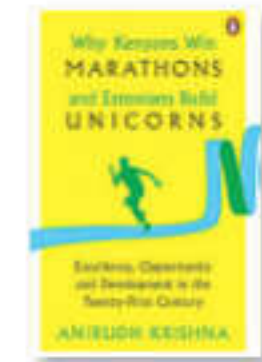
COURTESY: THE AUTHOR

a second-generation experience." For many, an Indian author writing about East Germany was outside the expected lane. She also chafed against the expectation of a more florid, exotic South Asian aesthetic, sticking to her own style, which she calls "sparse, quite precise." "I could write the flowery sentence, but I don't want to. That is my choice. And in that way I'm quite uncompromising." She recounts a telling battle with a copy editor over a line in her previous novel, *The Wild Wind*. The editor wanted to change a mother's dialogue from "Say thank you. Remember?" to "Remember to say thank you." Kalayil refused. "I said, 'No. The mom would say, 'Say thank you. Remember?'" It has got a completely different feel, a completely different texture to it." She won the argument but the fight exposed a deeper suspicion about linguistic authority. "That suspicion might translate to 'oh, they must have used AI' or that shows the use of AI," she says. "It is a bit worrying." *The Others* is a love story set against a backdrop

of political upheaval. Why make a love story the vehicle? Kalayil says she chose the form deliberately, to give migrant characters the interiority often denied them. "A lot of stories of migration don't allow that interiority," she says. "That level of introspection is granted to authors who are not trying to write stories about migration." For her, the political upheaval is the backdrop; the personal dramas are the true story. "Migration is a circumstance, but in the end it's the characters that are important," she says. "One way of really ensuring that I would be able to have that humanness was through a love story." At the end of the day, *The Others* is a novel that trusts its readers to find their own way through discomfort and ambiguity. The Women's Prize longlisting has strengthened that conviction. "There are so many gatekeepers in the industry who do not trust the reader," Kalayil says. "I trust the reader. The longlisting has galvanised me because somewhere, somehow, the pieces fell into place for me this time." It has given her the confidence to continue being, as she puts it, "uncompromising." Her next project is underway, and while she remains secretive about the details, she says it centres on a character one does not often root for. "But I believe you will be rooting for this character."

The Leap to Glory

In his latest book, Anirudh Krishna argues that genes alone have little to do when it comes to nations producing the world's best athletes



WHY KENYANS WIN MARATHONS AND ESTONIANS BUILD UNICORNS
ANIRUDH KRISHNA
Penguin Viking
₹699
264 pages

Nikita Mohta

ANIRUDH KRISHNA had arrived a few minutes early for a lecture he was due to give to undergraduates at Duke University when he found himself drawn into a conversation about Usain Bolt, who had recently won a race. As the students continued talking, the conversation led to a deeper revelation: Bolt was not an exception. Jamaica, in fact, had a remarkable record in sprinting. The reasoning came quickly: genetics, geography and culture, none of it convincing. Krishna delivered his lecture as planned, but the question stayed with him. "How can a country with just three million people produce a succession of the world's fastest runners?" he recalls asking himself. It set him off on a decade-long inquiry. The result is his latest book, *Why Kenyans Win Marathons and Estonians Build Unicorns: Excellence, Opportunity and Development in the 21st Century*. With the help of research assistants and students, Krishna began mapping the various flows of excellence, looking for patterns and cases he could examine further.

Some of the possibilities were unusual. "There were some exotic cases, for instance, of female lion tamers in Egypt," he says. Eventually, he narrowed the list to a handful of cases, with Jamaica an obvious choice. Jamaica's case suggested that genetics alone could not explain its success. "...after gaining independence in 1962, Jamaica produced only a patchy record of international performances for more than three decades," he says. Its dominance emerged much later, suggesting that something else had changed. His research shows that, over 40 years, Jamaica built not simply a cohort of athletes but an ecosystem capable of discovering and nurturing talent. The process begins at the grassroots level. Every school on the island hosts an annual athletics meet as part of the calendar of the Jamaican Athletics Federation. The journey culminates in the high-school championships, universally known as the Champs, and one of Jamaica's biggest sporting events. For four days, the country effectively shuts down and future Olympians are identified. "What distinguishes Jamaica from many other countries is what happens after school," Krishna says.



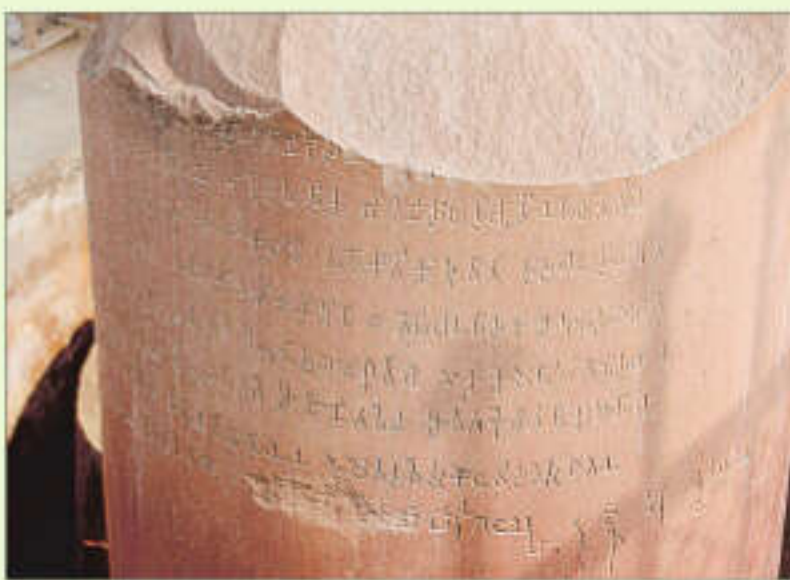
EXPRESS ARCHIVE

POWER PUNCH
Wrestler Sushil Kumar

Most athletes, however gifted, will never make it to the top. Without alternatives, years spent chasing sporting success can leave young people with little to fall back on. The solution lies in what Krishna calls "soft landings" — pathways that allow athletes to transition into other careers if sporting success does not materialise. "There isn't one super gene for running, or for anything. If you went looking for ace

basketball players, you'd find Japan, where people are, on average, among the shortest in the world, just as you would in the Netherlands, where they're among the tallest. But the Japanese basketball team is doing better than the Dutch one." How do societies create the conditions in which exceptional talent can be identified, developed and sustained? "Open access, with special measures for the less privileged, is the answer," Krishna says. Back home, he examines the case of wrestling in Haryana — five of the country's eight Olympic medals in wrestling up to 2024 were from the state. The state's *akharas* charge no training fees, leaving parents to pay only for their child's nutritional and other monthly expenses. Athletes, who reach a certain level, also qualify for government jobs, giving them a stable career beyond competitive sport. But, like Jamaica, he rejects the idea that genetics, geography and culture, taken together, explain Haryana's dominance. "If you look around, you'll find that there is wrestling everywhere. But this dense network, this ecosystem that has emerged through the combined efforts of civil society and the government in Haryana has not been replicated anywhere else in the country." A common thread across these cases, he says, is that no single institution built or controlled the entire ladder. Krishna's book is a reminder that governments can create the conditions for excellence but lasting ladders depend on a wider network of universities, clubs, federations and civil society actors.

WHAT I READ THIS WEEK



WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

WORD TO THE WISE
The Ashoka pillar at Sarnath

Road Not Taken

Patrick Olivelle's Ashoka: Portrait of a Philosopher King reveals a political imagination strikingly at odds with the Brahmanical order that followed

Rohan Manoj

IMAGINE A literal, corporeal elephant in the room: You might make a valiant stab at not talking about it, but much of what you do will inevitably be determined by its presence; at the very least, you will have to avoid bumping into it. Reading Patrick Olivelle's *Ashoka: Portrait of a Philosopher King* left me with a similar lingering thought — how much of Indian history and political thought in the centuries after Ashoka was a reaction to the Mauryan emperor, however much the Brahmanical authors may have avoided discussing him directly? Relying on Ashoka's own inscriptions, Olivelle draws a compelling portrait, and what we see is an extraordinary, exuberant personality, threatening to burst out of the pillars on which his words are engraved. This individuality is in stark contrast to later kings with their generic, vainglorious boasts. Here was a writer who promised to "always keep writing more." Here was a man with the temerity to lecture the Sangha on Buddhism, just a few years after becoming a Buddhist himself. Here was a king with the imagination to try things never thought of before, to build a shared moral universe for his subjects, an ecumenical *dharma* that looked beyond

Buddhism to encompass all *pasandas* or religious traditions.

There's something elegiac in Olivelle's account of the unravelling of Ashoka's legacy that makes one wonder what might have been. As he points out, there is no reference to caste in Ashoka's inscriptions; the Brahmanas and Shramanas are envisaged only as groups of "religious professionals." Could history have progressed along a better path if Ashoka's ecumenism had taken root? What Olivelle calls the "exceptionalism" of the Brahmanas, and their consequent rejection of ecumenism, may have helped scupper the project. The *dhamasutra-dharmashastra* tradition went on to articulate the Brahmanas' own *varna*-based ideals, a vision antithetical to — and possibly responding to — that of Ashoka, starting with the *Apastamba Dharmasutra*, which may have been close in time to the emperor. The epic heroes Rama and Yudhishtira also began to be held up as ideal kings devoted to the Brahmanas (brahmanya); Olivelle quotes James Fitzgerald's assertion that Yudhishtira was "designed as a refutation, or at least a rebuttal, of the emperor Ashoka." In this connection, one might also recall the argument made by V S Sukthankar, the general editor of the critical edition of the Mahabharata, that the epic was for a long time in the custody of Brahmanas of the Bhriugu *gotra*, who added their own "Bhargava material" to the text, including the references to Bhargava Rama or Parashurama, the exterminator of the Kshatriyas. To deny the impact of these Brahmanical ideals on social reality and caste as it evolved on the ground would be to deny the influence of ideas on history. The *shastric* texts have a well-documented history of being consulted and applied. Today, the best-known such text, *Manusmriti*, is in the eye of a storm yet again. But the memory of Ashoka invites us to imagine a world in which *Manusmriti* never was.

» CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

Mammootty Wants to Dance



YOUNG DIRECTORS who win awards at festivals abroad know they cannot raise that kind of budget but they also know that Mammootty is still available. Which is why, most of them have a screenplay for him. Stand outside a coffee bistro in Kakkanad or catch a short-film assistant moonlighting on a delivery bike in Panampilly Nagar or ask an indie maker like Don Palathara or even T Hariharan, past 80 and past 60 films, how their Mammootty script is coming along, they will have an answer.

Rahul Sadasivan is one of them. A London Film School graduate with an obsession with the horror genre and one decent film behind him (*Bhoothakaalam*, 2022), he walked into writer TD Ramakrishnan's house with the germ of an idea and three things fixed. Horror. Black and white. The lead had to be Mammootty. That became *Bramayugam*, featuring him as a malevolent spirit of the old lore, hiding inside an old man's frailty. TD, who wrote the dialogues, has a way of expressing what the actor can do: "A very *savarna* body the elite loves to look at, and in the same breath a vile fellow who preys on women, and for both, people say only Mammootty can do it." He is Sethurama Iyer, the intelligent, unbribable Brahmin cop, and the man in *Kalamkaval*, who throttles a woman on a bed within the first 10 minutes of the film. For the audience, it was as if half of the movie was playing inside their head.

Perhaps because a lot of Kerala is in that body. For three generations, the ordinary Malayali man — dark, short, going bald, a paunch by 40 — has measured himself against Mammootty. And the state built its idea of the correct man partly out of what he played. If Mohanlal is the mask you put on to get out of Kerala, then Mammootty is the arrival, the Malayali who has already got to the place — modern, secular, in charge.

Academic J Devika recently called that Kerala a figment of an idea sold on green-covered tourism reels and home-delivered banana leaves *sadhyas*, cut loose from the reality of a hillside in Wayanad that comes down in one night's rain. He is that figment with a body. It is a lot to hang on a man.

None of this makes him the oracle the fans want. In the last 10 years, he has done a lot of films that sank. Rajasekharan equates it to how Sachin Tendulkar knew where the ball was going before it hit his bat. Sometimes, Tendulkar still got out. But when he middled one, the whole ground knew. *Bramayugam* was middled. It started a conversation outside Kerala and Mammootty will walk later this month to bag his fourth National Award, more than what any Malayalam actor holds.

But the man is not without flaws. He is known to flare up even over something small. Once for an interview, he expected to meet a senior editor but a lifestyle reporter was sent instead. Mammootty did the whole interview lying face down on a bench at the edge of the seat, only half listening to the questions the reporter had for him. Everybody has a story of him doing some version of that. But through all of this and nearly 400 films, there has been one steady presence, and she came in before any of it. It was 1979. Mammootty was then a lawyer with no cases and a marriage was being arranged. He told his family to hold on. They would not. He knew he was good looking, and he was afraid she would marry the face and get short-changed for the rest of her life. So he purposely grew a beard for two weeks and went to see her at his worst. She took him anyway.

Forty-seven years later, she has the first dance on his birthday.

Trisha Mukherjee

DIVYA SINGH sold her first art work in 2019. But the sale didn't make her happy. It was a brown canvas depicting her mother's room. "I went home and cried. I just couldn't let go," she says.

At the outset, Singh appears to be exactly the 31-year-old she is. An oversized shirt, boots, hair tied up in a messy bun, bangles on one arm and rings on the fingers of the other. Her shimmery nails match her silver eyeshadow and she rounds up the look with an orange, flower-shaped pimple patch. Casual and carefree, with a hint of grunge.

What gives away the person beneath the surface are the paintings mounted on the walls around her at Delhi's Shrine gallery for her solo show — Sounds from the Attic — oil paintings of what sometime seem like stolen, intimate moments from life that elude notice. At other times, manifestations of a perpetually wondering mind.

"I was always an introvert, even as a child. So much so that I would often communicate with my family through writing. But I particularly would draw a lot to spend time with my sister because she would spend a lot of time drawing," says Delhi-based Singh, "Over time, drawing

When you see humans, what human life is... it is so fragile. I remember thinking about the cost of peace because we have entire nations at war. A single afternoon of peace is what we go to war for, right? This moment of peace, I can stretch it to infinity

became something I could not only do but a place where I existed. It was something that I did as a way to live, and I think I got good at it."

She did. In Slowly/ Drift, exhibited at the Delhi Contemporary Art Week in 2022, she paints a scene from inside an empty bus. At the centre is a pair of feet hanging from the edge of a seat. The canvas is blue with deep, solid shadows. The composition is poignant in its depiction of the respite, or perhaps escape, that arrives at the end of an all-too-familiar hard day.

"Divya is an incredibly skilled painter, with a rare ability to keep the dreamlike imagery of her inner world alive on the canvas. There is something haunting about her work — the images seem to hover between memory and imagination, between something lived and something half-remembered. It is this quality that gives the work its emotional depth: it feels intimate and personal, yet strangely familiar," says Anahita Taneja, co-founder, Shrine Empire that has been representing her since 2021.

Six years after that first sale, Singh's works now range from Rs 25,000 to Rs 12 lakh, depending on the scale and complexity. "It was a rite of passage. After that first painting got sold, it changed me.

ART FUTURES

Lights will guide you home

Divya Singh's paintings of everyday moments reveal a practice preoccupied with the anxieties of a transient present



COURTESY: THE ARTIST

STILL IN MOTION (Clockwise from top) *Ode to Solitude/ Ophelia's Song; Tell Mother I'm Home/ Afterlife; Divya Singh; How to Cure a Ghost: x Spirit of a Beehive*



I am not attached in the same way that I would have been in the past," she says.

At her ongoing show, there is Vestal's Dream II — a painting of something as innocuous as a window. Yet the work breathes, in the way the transparent curtain floats as a gust of wind passes through the window.

Singh is able to bring time to a standstill. She recalls a moment when she saw a neighbour, living across the street, resting on a Sunday afternoon. "He was asleep on the floor with his hand hanging outside the room and into the balcony," she says, demonstrating with her hand. "Plants were swaying in the wind, and it made me emotional. When you see humans, what

human life is... it is so fragile. I remember thinking about the cost of peace because we have entire nations at war. A single afternoon of peace is what we go to war for, right? I have this existential, not exactly anxiety, but a sensation that it could all go away. But in my mind, this moment of peace, I can stretch it to infinity," she elaborates.

One of the qualities of Singh's works

A Space That Speaks to the Modern Man

Suna Umari, historian and archivist of the Rothko Chapel in Houston, Texas, in conversation with writer-curator INA PURI on the story of its origins, how the abstract artist saw the space and why it's home to religions around the world

WHEN THE de Menils visited Mark Rothko in his studio in 1964, the first time, they found themselves whispering, as if they were in the presence of some divine spirit. Such was the power of his paintings. This was a feeling that deeply resonated with me, sitting in the quiet and darkened space of the Rothko Chapel, when I first visited the place, surrounded by the luminous and beautiful canvases of the artist. My own experience was unforgettable. Serendipitously, I had an opportunity to meet with Suna Umari, retired historian and archivist of the chapel a few days later, and it was then that I learned how the meditative space came to be built, and of her own associations with the de Menil family.

John and Dominique de Menil, lay Catholics who commissioned the chapel, wanted it taken seriously across faiths. In the early 1970s, the French couple personally travelled across Europe to Africa and as far as India to introduce their ideas to religious leaders and thinkers. The de Menils possessed incredible wealth but with it came a deep sense of responsibility, and the intelligence, the education, and the aesthetics to use it well. Their legacy is not only the chapel itself but the fact that a place of such quiet transcendence exists at all, open every day of the year, without ticket or fee, for anyone who walks in. Excerpts from the interview:

Ina Puri: The de Menils travelled to India in the early 1970s. What were they looking for?
SUNA UMARI: The purpose of those

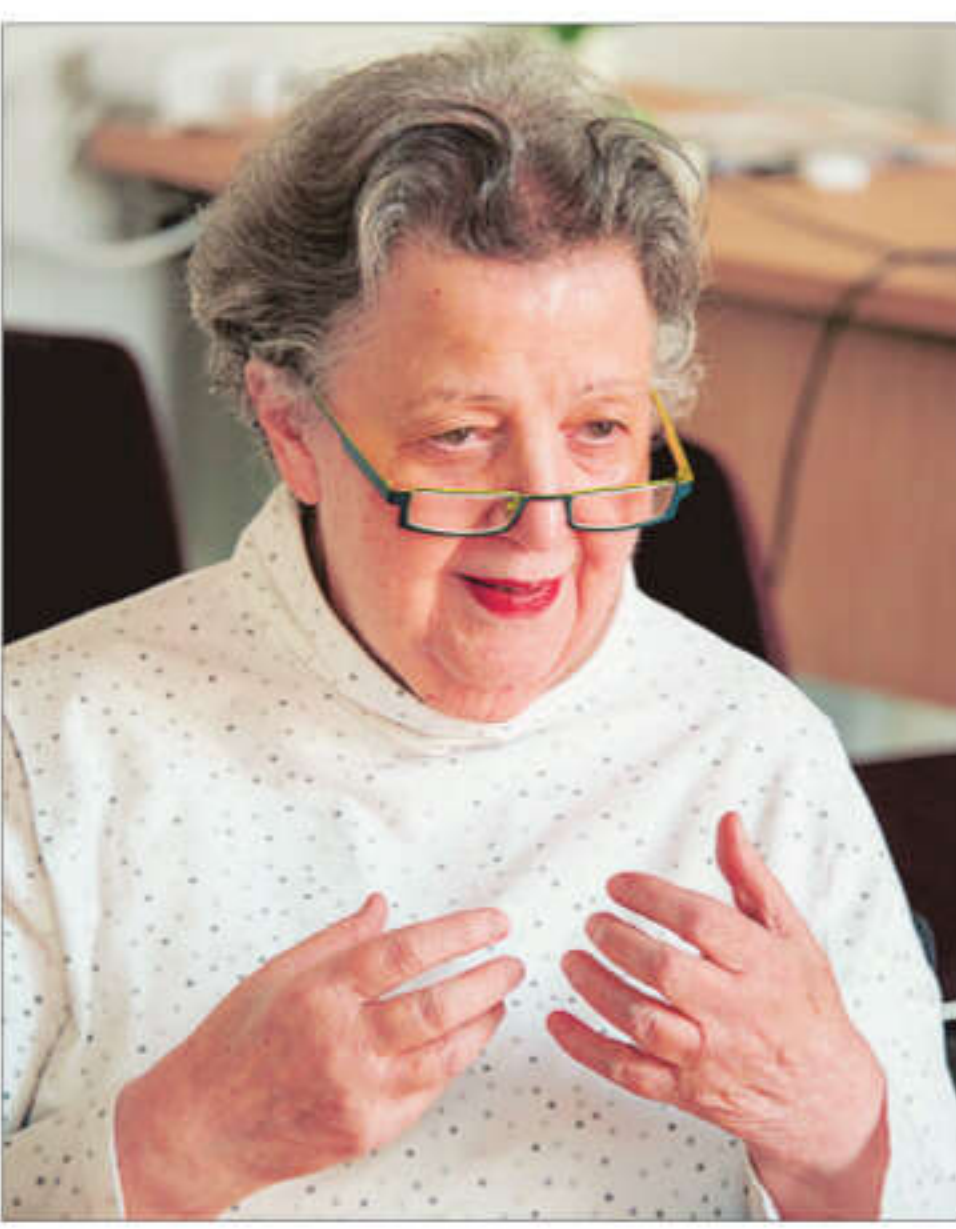
trips was to introduce the idea of the Rothko Chapel and see if there would be acceptance. They felt, "Who are we, as lay Catholics, to create a chapel?" So the solution was to reach out to different traditions and tell them what their purpose was. They went across Europe, Africa, the Middle East, Iran, and as far as India. They met the Dalai Lama in India who promised to come to the Rothko Chapel when the United States would give him a visa. In 1979, he was finally able to get one and he came.

Tell us about the de Menils.

They had a rare combination — incredible wealth but a deep sense of responsibility towards it. They wanted to use it with meaning and purpose. And they had the intelligence, the education, the aesthetics. When the chapel opened in 1971, modern art was not popular in Houston. For local people, this was not a place they were interested in. The de Menils wanted to give even the *Broken Obelisk*, the Corten steel sculpture by Barnett Newman, to the city but Houstonians declined. So the de Menils bought it and placed it here.

What made them choose Rothko for the chapel?

They wanted to honour a contemporary artist. Father Couturier, a Dominican priest, had pushed the idea of bringing contemporary artists back into conversation with the religious community. He said we need a modern sanctuary. The Sistine Chapel is beautiful but people don't relate



ONE FOR ALL Suna Umari; (right) the Rothko Chapel, foregrounded by Barnett Newman's *Broken Obelisk*

to God as a bearded man on a throne anymore. The de Menils came with that conviction. When they met Rothko, they found a deep thinker on a quest to express the predicament of man artistically. They were on a search too, to create a place that would speak to a modern person. He fit.



COURTESY: INA PURI/ROTHKO CHAPEL

And he designed more than just the paintings?

Unlike other artists, he created the space as well as the art. He wanted an eight-sided room. He wanted natural light. He said, "When the sun sets, it's over. You close the chapel." With natural light, there's depth, a play of light. A cloud comes by and there's drama. Electric lights kill that immediately.

Every detail was thought out: the floor, the barriers, how many inches from the floor each painting would be put up. He never came to Houston. He was terrified of flying. He built mock walls of the exact dimensions in his studio and worked from there.

You yourself came to the chapel from very far away.

I grew up in Lebanon, in a multicultural environment. I studied anthropology at the American University of Beirut, with a focus on religion. I worked for UNICEF in Abu Dhabi, doing research with women in the Gulf. I went to Iran and was there during the revolution of 1978-79. I went back to Beirut but the civil war was on, and I was going through a divorce with a seven-year-old son. My father knew the de Menils and Dominique offered me a job helping with a colloquium on Islam. That was my entrance. I stayed 33 years.

In 1978, you had the Whirling Dervishes perform inside the chapel.

The minute they walked in, they said, "This is a place where we whirl", because their own place is an eight-sided room. It was like they came home. There's something very powerful when they whirl in the chapel. Very different from anywhere else.

What has the chapel become over the years?

Primarily, it's for meditation and prayer, and for people who don't have a place of worship. Buddhists, Hindus, Zoroastrians and Muslims have all used it. When the Zoroastrians use it, it becomes a Zoroastrian temple. When the Muslims use it, it becomes their mosque. It transforms, because there is no symbolism inside. It has become neutral ground. After 9/11, thousands would visit in a single day to just sit quietly.